

NOTHING BUT SHE MAKES SENSE  
TO HIS ENORMOUS WORLD.



# HER KNIGHT IN SHINING ARMOR

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# Her Knight in Shining Armor

**by Isfah Ribu**

*Nothing but only she makes sense in his enormous wild world.*

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Aden David Pattersen, the demon of his own world. Who cares about absolutely nothing in this universe. He was ruthless towards the term love as he had a brutal and unfortunate childhood. But an ordinary college going girl suddenly becomes the end of him, knowing he is something unappealing to her. There are nothing but obstacles in their way. But he'd get her anyway.

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Evelyn De Jones, simple but marvelous looking girl who lights up every room she enters. Trusting someone she shouldn't is her biggest fear since that one tragedy of her life. But afterwards she collides with a soul who fulfills her inner self, who she didn't realize she needed.

It's the love, beyond impossible to come out with so many barricades in its way. Yet, it eventually does and she becomes something he'd destroy the world for.

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# CHAPTER 1

## EVELYN

Some things could feel very owned, for me it was the place. I never contemplated leaving the city. The magnificent beauty of rural mountains, rivers and peaceful atmosphere was hindering me from leaving.

“You ready to head out, Eve?” Edward called out from downstairs. I didn’t say anything. Then I came down there.

“Look on the bright side, Eve. Your brother isn’t thrilled about it either.” Hannah tried to comfort me, rubbing her hand over my shoulder. I let out a moist smile so she wouldn’t realize my gloominess as we were leaving Covington, VA.

After reaching the airport, we were waiting in the departure lounge for our flight to board. I felt a pang in my heart after looking at the departure gate of “Virginia to New York city”.

I didn’t utter a single word throughout the whole one and a half hour flight.

After landing we took a cab and reached Brooklyn. Everything had already started to feel unfamiliar. We stood in front of our new house.

“Don’t worry, kiddo. Everything’s going to be perfect.” Edward patted my back.

We entered the house and I went to my room. Everything was nicer and bigger. But, I knew no one here. I felt like a total stranger. I was so exhausted from the journey that I lay down on the bed and fell asleep without even taking my shoes off.

The next morning was fresh, and the weather was lovely. I came downstairs.

“Good morning,” Hannah and Edward synchronized.

“Good morning, guys. You look exhilarating,” I chuckled.

She excitedly clasped her hands, “so, do you feel ecstatic about your first day at college?”

“I... uhm,”

“It’s a big deal, freshman year of college,” Edward interrupted.

“I guess,” I sighed.

Edward patted both my shoulders pushing me towards upstairs, “Now, go get ready in fifteen minutes, or I’ll leave without you. Cause, It’s my first day too. So, chop-chop.”

I got ready in a few minutes and got out before him and waited for him in the car and Hannah kissed both of our foreheads, “Drive safely. I love you both.”

Though he said he would, he didn’t.

## EVELYN

We reached the college in twenty minutes. A strange and ironic feeling was rolling in my heart as I stood in front of the college gate.

Edward kissed my hair and walked in regard to his office, “best of luck champ.”

*Obviously, I’d be the ultimate champ when I faint down in here with fright.*

Teaching was his passion. Therefore, we had to relocate here for his work. And it was the best for me.

*According to them.*

English literature was his fundamental breathing supply, one that I kind of inherited from him.

“I sincerely apologize for letting my eyes wander,” I said, as I bumped into a girl, because I was walking backwards.

“Chill, girl. Are you alright? Can you breathe fine?” she said, in confusion as though I just made a fool out of myself.

I was embarrassed and as well as tensed, “I should be the one asking you this, I’m genuinely sorry for causing you harm.”

“Wow, you’re apologizing like you murdered someone. Here people don’t even look back after colliding with someone. Out of town?” A peal of surprised laughter escaped her lips.

She was Blonde, five feet two inches tall with ocean blue eyes, cheerleader and had a nice figure.

*I knew I didn’t belong here.*

“Just moved here, freshman year,” I confirmed her.

“Welcome to Central View University,” she generously welcomed me.

“I’m Shayla Campbell.”

“Evelyn... Evelyn Jones.”

“So, you’re related to the new English professor!” she said, surprised, pointing her index finger at me.

“He’s my brother and apparently he’s the reason why we moved here,” I assured her.

“No offense, but he is super hot.”

Though she sounded extra gross, I didn’t take it personally. “None taken.”

“Hey, Shayla! Oh my god, who’s this gorgeous little creature?” Ana, another cheerleader, blonde, five feet five inches tall, almost as tall as me with olive green eyes, approached Shayla moving her gaze at me from head to toe.

Her face was filled with makeup.

“I know right?” Shayla agreed with Ana Cameroon.

Their compliments caught me off guard and I tried transitioning from that conversation as I was embarrassed.

"I'm sorry, who are we waiting here for, again?" I asked, since we stood there motionless for a few minutes, in front of the waterfall, right beside the college field, from where the entrance gateway was clear to look at.

"No one except for her dreamy scarred villain," Shayla teased Ana with a playful grin.

Ana said in embarrassment brushing her hair from her eyes, "yeah, stop it. It was just one time I had a crush over him."

All of this was a new experience for me, since I never dated anyone. Not that I couldn't or didn't want to. It all seemed like a waste of time. No one was worth my trust. I couldn't just roll the dice and take the chance. Safe to say I lack interest in this. Call it low self-esteem. But, it didn't happen in eighteen whole years and shouldn't happen now.

The gate opened to its fullest extent for a black Porsche 718 spyder. Though I didn't have much knowledge about cars, how could I not recognize this beauty?

My eyes seized on the six feet one or two inches tall guy as the car door opened. I assumed that was Ana's boyfriend with a solid block of muscles and black silkiest hair after Edward. It wasn't very evident from afar, but I believe he had grey eyes, like mine. His hand was tucked inside his pocket.

*Holy shit! He is gorgeous. He could eat hundreds of guys looking just handsome for a slender breakfast.*

One thing about him was highly shocking, given that he didn't raise his gaze at any girl including Ana. But that didn't stop a troop of butterflies flying in her stomach as she nearly fainted with the sight of his presence.



“That’s my breathtaking man.”

“I thought he was your boyfriend, why is he not coming to you?” I asked, my thoughts a confusing jumble.

“Yeah, she wishes,” Shayla mocked her.

“That’s Aden Pattersen, just graduated senior year, captain of the college football team, though it’s something he does out of passion, but eligible for every competition and most importantly red and bloody desire of girls. But unfortunately, no one here is good enough for him. He makes out with anyone he finds intriguing and the next moment he doesn’t even recognize her. However, the moment is heaven for the girl,” she continued without moving her gaze from Aden. “He’d recently become the CEO of their company.”

Apparently Henry Pattersen, the founder of The Central View University, Brooklyn, NYC, was his father.

Aden did have an odd influence on girls having physical sensations, like butterflies bolting in their stomachs.

But, no. I didn’t have any recollection of that. As an alternative, I felt a romantic turmoil leading to stab me in the heart and give my heart a tight wrench.

It was a novel experience. I had never encountered such feelings for a boy. It was unprecedented.

“Let’s go. We’re going to be late for class. Mr. Gitens will tear into us for getting late.” Shayla pulled me in the direction of class, startling me as I was eying Aden who was on his way to the college field.

## ADEN

I never had any passion or ardour for the role of student council president. But, I was stuck with it. I’d rather kill a few

people who deserve to be dead. That's more of what I did. That's my 'forte'.

Though I didn't do any of the work as president, I have always had things done by others.

"Aden, we're done with the preparations, we just have to visit classes for their opinions and problems. Booths are ready as well," Luke called out loud my name to get my attention.

Luke and I had been best buddies since freshman year. Now he had become my right hand in college and business as well.

We headed towards the classes, even though I hated it so much that I'd smoked in there while others were communicating with students. That was one of the advantages of being the son of the founder. No professor gave a damn about it.

As I stood in a class, leaning backwards on the desk having my gaze down to avoid eye contacts, cause I knew most girls were gawking at me. I let out the vapor, a slight inartificial smile blurred in it.

### *That's a new face*

I kept my eyes averted more often than not, nevertheless, that never stopped me from noticing everything in the room. I mean, I had to be cognizant of my enemies or they'd always have the clear view to tear up my heart, before I do theirs.

She was new here. She possessed a high degree of grace.

Princesses were almost as beautiful as her. She was marvelously elegant.

She flickered her eyes at me. Our sights got locked for a moment before she moved hers back to her friends.

She wasn't petite; however, she wasn't so tall either. She was an average five feet five inches tall with astonishing grey eyes. They were glittery, unlike mine with dark humor. Her hair looked

almost red. It wasn't too red, but a combination of red and black overwhelming beauty.

I felt something, a sudden ache in my body. Felt like she had darted an arrow right across my heart.

Instead of the urge to fuck her right there, I felt a slick devotion. I was deeply captivated by her. I was besotted with her.

She was clearly made for love, which I hadn't owned to give her. But, I wanted to love her to death at that moment.

I knew that she was the goddess who'd be the death of me right away.

I pulled Luke toward me by his collar and pointed my sight at her, "who's the new girl? She isn't from here."

He whistled, chaffing me, "Aden Pattersen fancies a girl."

I hauled him harder and growled with my teeth, "utter another word, you'll barely have the time to say goodbye to your girlfriend."

He creaked in a moist pain as his throat was in my hand, "hold on, let me ask. God, you almost killed me."

Luke snapped his finger at her, "hey, you. Stand up, honey. What's your name?"

She got uncomfortable and rose hesitantly.

"Eve-Evelyn Jones."

I smacked him from behind. Then he softened.

"You just moved here didn't you?"

"Yes," she replied.

I stood steadily and inhaled the last vape as I kept it in my pocket and ordered out loud.

"Everyone out, move to the classroom next to this one, you'll have the rest of your classes there for today."

Everyone hurried to the room and she was departing as well.

I groaned humbly with a gesture, “you, you stay here.”

She was scared. I hadn’t been pleasant to anyone. I couldn’t be. It just described the nature of a heartless person. Maybe I didn’t want one.

*Until now.*

Yet I tried to be charming to her even though I knew I couldn’t be. Cause I could never be in these twenty five years of life.

“Take a seat. Evelyn, is it?”

She was paralyzed by fear, so she overrode my order and stood still. She didn’t want me to get that, but her pretty big frightened eyes told everything anyway. I walked towards her and I went closer to her, she was taking a step backwards until her legs hit a bench and she almost collapsed if I hadn’t grabbed her waist with one hand and her wrist with the other.

In a micro second, she was so close to me as I lifted her up that I could hear her breathe so fast and unevenly.

She carried the lingering grace of magnolia. Her hair was fragrant with floral scent as well. She had a sleek, beautiful body and delicate hands. Exactly the opposite of me.

She flinched and recoiled as I whispered in her ear, “Your sight is enough to catch my attention, you don’t have to hurt yourself for that.”

“I’m going to be late for my next class,” she stuttered and tried to slip away.

I slid my hand against the wall obstructing her way, “you can’t leave until I tell you to. I mean you no harm, darling.”

She tentatively met my gaze. “I’m not afraid of you, besides, who are you?”

I knew she placed me. I easily get provoked and that moment wasn’t any different.

My anger flared, I pinned her against the wall, but my hand instinctively cradled the back of her head, so she doesn't get hurt. Keeping my hand over her throat, I whispered to her ear, "I'm not usually this gentle, but, I'm trying to make an exception for you. So, don't provoke me. And for the record..." I leaned closer to her.

"I'm everything you need, darling."

A small gasp escaped her and I loosened my grip to her throat and brought her hand to my lips without moving my gaze from her face.

Releasing my hand from the wall, I stepped aside for her to go back to her class.

She stared at me for a second before leaving without looking back for once.

*God, I completely lost my composure in front of her, something I never do. What is she doing to me? I had made out with millions of girls and never remembered their face again. But this, this is different. I lost my poise in front of her. That's not good for me and it's searing me.*

*Cause, she had broken through every barrier I had built.*

## EVELYN

It only had been a month of my freshman year.

*What the hell was that?!*

Staying away from that devil was the oath I made to myself and the worst nightmare just came true when Aden touched me and my soul had left my body. That was totally new to me.

I was so terrified that I couldn't process that in my head.

"Are you okay, honey?" Hannah asked me from downstairs, tensed.

I inhaled a little air, "I'm alright. Just got bored in the class."

I was taking a shower, but his voice was echoing and wouldn't leave my head,

*I'm everything you need.*

I tried to avoid it and lay down for a nap. But I fell asleep from exhaustion.

The next morning, I woke up from sleep and didn't feel like going to college under the circumstances.

I just couldn't get him out of my head. He would be the last guy on earth for me to choose.

My phone buzzed, "yes?"

"Why aren't you at college?" Shayla asked.

"I don't really feel like going. Would you give me the noted later?"

"I will. Only if you come to college," she said, challenging me.

I hung up on her, ghosting her.

I went to college later on, but stayed off the radar so Aden wouldn't be able to see me.

I hadn't seen him in last four hours.

Just as I was about to head home, he emerged from nowhere and intercepted me.

I was invisibly shaken by his sudden appearance, "Oh, my!... Jesus! Can you stop doing that?"

"There's no point in shunning me, you'll see me everywhere you go, Darling."

He narrowed his eyes and whispered in my ear.

"However, you're invited to my party. I'm really looking forward to seeing you there," he added, pointing his finger at me.

"Sorry, Mr. Pattersen, parties aren't my scene." I brushed him off with a shrug.

“That wasn’t really a request. I demand you to be there, or you’ll have one of your friends hurt because of you.” He leaned and closed the distance between us.

His giant body moved from my side as he was leaving. I could feel the tension leaving my body.

His scent hung in the air, a clean, simple manly aroma. His attempt at intimidation didn’t sway my decision to skip the party.

Then again, he was a maniac, he might hurt them.

Ana and Shayla wouldn’t stop persuading me to go there. They insisted on me going right after Aden got out of sight.

“You have to come, no one enjoys staying home more than they’d enjoy a party.”

“I do.” I met her gaze.

She said with a heavy sigh, “Eve...”

“Okay, fine. I’ll go with you guys. Stop it now and pick me up at eight,” I interrupted her as she wouldn’t stop convincing me.

They both jumped in joy and hugged me, “yes!”

“Get a hold of yourself,” I pushed them, as I didn’t have much cravings for physical touch.

---

## CHAPTER 2

### EVELYN

“Absolutely no!” I snapped, as Ana handed me a red dress that barely reached my knees, a style I wouldn’t have chosen for myself.

“This is ridiculously long,” Ana shouted, as I was denying the dress. But she made me wear it anyway...

They’d both worn dresses that barely kissed their asses — that was the norm for them.

We reached the party and I waved Ana and Shayla bye as they wanted to hit the dance floor and drink.

That wasn’t really my typical way of acting.

I kept myself in a corner, nursing a few sodas and suddenly my jaw dropped when I caught the sight of Aden making out with two women on a couch.

“That blew your mind, already?” A five feet, ten inches tall guy stood next to me, who’d clearly noticed my shocked expression.

“Not that I didn’t anticipate, but seeing it myself kind of feels gross,” I confirmed him.

“I’m Max, you must be out of town.” He sat next to me.

“That’s obvious, huh?” I took a sip of my soda.

“No, I didn’t mean to...”

“That’s alright. Yeah, just moved here. I’m Evelyn. In case you didn’t catch my name.”

I interrupted him as he tried to confront me.



“Why are you not dancing and drinking with the others?” he asked me as if I was all by myself there.

“No offense, but it’s not really my cup of tea. I was almost dragged here by my friends.” I let out a forced smile to appear polite.

“None taken.” He smiled. “So what does a beautiful girl like to do anyway?”

I ignored him and tried to go to another room, “I’m sorry. It’s a bit overwhelming here, I think I’m going to find a quieter spot.”

I bolted from there.

I went to a room filled with books. It was a whole library. Just the kind of place I preferred to be in.

I was looking at a book, and when I looked up, I saw Aden standing right behind me, closing the gap between us. “Holy shit! You scared me.”

He trapped me against the bookshelf planting his hand right beside my head. As he looked down to meet my gaze, I had to crane my neck and angle my gaze sharply upwards to meet his.

“Isn’t that a literal dirty word for you, darling?”

“Says someone, who makes out with every girl and doesn’t remember their faces the next day,” I mocked him without moving my eyes from him. “Says someone who can’t live without having intentions of a devil.”

“You’re right and I’m having one right now.” He placed his hand on my knee and tried to pull my dress up. I threw his hand off!

He grinned like a grumpy devil and his voice was very tough, but he seemed gentle with me at the same time.

Suddenly he leaned in, clearly exhausted, and let the full weight of his body rest against me.

I tensed. “Are you alright, Mr. Pattersen? Should I call someone?”

“No,” his voice vibrated as his lips touched my bare neck.

“Just stay like this,” he implored, his voice full of despair, sounding so desolate and lonely.

I felt a strange void in my heart. When I decided to push him away, he suddenly tightened up his grip around my waist. I wanted to leave him. I just couldn’t quite.

I could feel his skin and hear his heartbeat so steady and even.

I didn’t like physical touch. I hated it, let alone anticipating it from a guy.

*Why is it so different and oddly peaceful?*

I moved my hands to his cheeks and he stood back steadily, “let’s get you to bed.”

He sighed, “let’s get out of here. Just us.”

“Sorry, I can’t. I have to be home by twelve,” I said apologetically.

“We still have half an hour. Let me take you somewhere my favorite. Then I’ll give you a ride home,” he said looking at his watch.

I wanted to say no. But for some reason, I couldn’t and agreed to go with him.

We had gone outside and he climbed into his deluxe bike and instructed me, “Hop on.”

“Oh this? I’ve never ridden on a bike. Besides, it’s dangerous.” I said, alarmed.

“Get on,” his voice firm.

*Grumpy!*

I rolled my eyes at him and jumped in.

The engine roared to life, “you need to cling onto me firmly or you might fall and hurt yourself, darling.”

Not knowing what to do, I hesitated at first. But, then I had managed to wrap my arms around his stomach tightly.

He let out a smirk turning his head half at me, “you’re mine now. Prepare for demolition, darling.”

“Yeah, in your dreams,” I said mocking him.

I had handled the situation. But, he wasn’t good for me. I felt something being that close to him. Something, I never felt before.

As he accelerated, the world had become a blur. Even with a helmet, the wind was too intense, it forced tears as dust went inside my eyes, effectively robbing me of my sight.

“Can you slow down?”

“What?” he screamed.

“Never mind.” I knew he wouldn’t have slowed down.

His voice, muffled by his helmet, was barely audible as he turned his head, “Are you enjoying this?”

I burst out laughing with pure joy and laughed until my sides ached with happiness, “so much. I’m literally on top of the cloud.”

“Best night!” I squealed and hollered with delight.

My laughter drew a pleased grin from him. I didn’t need to see him smile loudly to know he was happy; my own joy was enough to confirm it.

The bike rolled to a halt within a dense and overgrown forest after a while.

Stepping inside the tree line, we met with a sight that stole my breath. A beach of such profound loveliness, it felt beyond description.

Fireflies twinkled all around us and the wind rustled to the trees.

I was in such a state of elation that I instinctively sprinted for the beach leaving Aden to follow.

I glanced back at him and yelled jubilantly, “It’s so stunning. It’s breathtakingly pretty.”

My explosive excitement seemed to please Aden immensely, as he had only seen the quiet, more unassuming version of me.

Before he could utter a word, I had spontaneously run and thrown my arms around him, “Thank you so much for this. It’s the best.”

I moved away from him before he could even hug me back.

I started to walk back towards the beach, but paused midway and flashing him a quick mischievous grin, “By the way, Happy birthday, Mr. Pattersen,” I called out as I didn’t wish him earlier.

## ADEN

*Evelyn De Jones would be the death of me. I lost control around her. Which I couldn’t afford to.*

I remained silent as she wished me for the birthday. Though it meant so much to me, only because it was from her.

But, I was still processing that hug of a nano second.

I never let anyone touch me. Even when I had sex, I had never let them touch me. They were just whores and so obedient to me.

I kept my eyes fixed on her. The beach was my favorite place. But, I couldn’t move my gaze from her like an innocent child craving her mother.

We sat in the cool sand side by side. Our bodies were so close, just soaking in the view.

Suddenly she sighed, “Ahh, it’s gorgeous.”

She had a slight British tone. I wondered where she had gotten that from. I looked at her with so much passion that, had she

noticed, she would have thought I was almost in love with her.

“You know what else is gorgeous?”

“I’m looking at it right now,” I said, my gaze fixed on her.

Evelyn’s face broke into a beaming smile that seemed to cast a spell on me.

Evelyn was a temptation I couldn’t have. My path couldn’t intertwine with hers; the risk was too great.

But I yearned for a little moment with her even though it could be savored as our finale.

As my gaze fixed on her, I swiveled toward her, placed my hands on her waist, and pulled her into my embrace, guiding her to face me.

Startled, Evelyn’s eyes looked at mine, her expression speechless.

My head dipped towards hers, captivated by the undeniable invitation her lips held.

With our foreheads pressed together and eyes at each other’s lips, her rapid pulse thrummed against my ears.

A trace of fear lingered in her expression, but she yielded to the kiss.

My lips almost touched her till she said, “Aden, I don’t think...”

I cut her off, “Don’t worry, I won’t move forward until you give the word.”

I moved to her neck, brushing my lips against the hollow of her throat.

I whispered in her ear,

**“IF YOU WERE MINE, I’D NEVER LET ANYONE SO  
MUCH AS LOOK AT YOU THE WRONG WAY, LET  
ALONE CAUSE YOU PAIN.”**

I pushed myself back from her, before she had a chance to absorb what I'd said.

"Get up, let's get you home."

"But, we've still got time," she softly said.

Little did she know, being with her was the only thing I truly wanted in that moment.

I gave her a hard look, my voice devoid of warmth, "I said, we're leaving. Let's go."

She had no room for argument, so she did as I told her to.

She maintained her silence throughout the drive.

I had dropped her off at her house and bid her goodnight, but she had simply walked away without looking back.

The logical part of me knew, this was for the best, but my heart ached for her to glance over her shoulder.

As I left, her voice carried out on the wind, echoing, *Aden*.

*Wait, she'd never addressed me by my name before. It was a first.*

I never really adored my name until now.

But, part of me knew, she was that elegant flower in the garden I couldn't lay my hand on, cause it was so delicate that I might kill it.

She was too fragile for my touch.

She could never see me the same way again, if she knew the full extent of my actions in the past.

---

## CHAPTER 3

### EVELYN

The next week, he was missing from the college. Probably busy in his work.

But I had known, he'd come tomorrow as he had a football match with the rivals. He wouldn't miss it for the world.

I was enthusiastically backing him and eagerly looking forward to his game.

I woke up the next morning, with flutter of excitement in my stomach, to attend the game. Well, it had nothing to do with the game itself and everything to do with watching Aden win.

I got ready and my phone lit up, "shay." Shayla was picking me up. She had been picking me up for last few days, as I refused to get my driver's license. Edward had to be going early as well.

"You're late, you're supposed to be waiting on the road." Shayla stressed and yelled at me impatiently.

"I know, I'm sorry..."

Shayla forgetting her anger and capturing a more youthful and excitable tone, "OMG, girl, are you wearing makeup today?"

I gave a clumsy shrug and I stammered looking at her rearview mirror, "what? No, tha...that's completely preposterous. I..."

Shayla's previous frustration vanished, replaced by a frenzied excitement. "Oh my-my. I know that look! You've got a crush. Spill. Who's the fucking lucky guy?"

Before I respond, "God, are you guys already fucking?" I pressed my hand over her mouth, but her indignant protests had

still come through in muffled shouts. My jaw tightened, “just shut up, and drive the freaking car. Or I’ll put my foot where it shouldn’t be! God, how could you think that!”

A tap on my hand signaled her agreement to stay silent, so I released my grip.

Though she wore a mischievous grin throughout the whole drive, that teased the hell out of me. But I didn’t react.

Reaching to college, I took a place in the front row of the gallery, watching Shayla and Ana preparing their routine for the game.

I went to grab a bottle of water, a girl rammed her shoulder into me with deliberate force. I knew she had done that on purpose.

“Hey, you bumped into me!” I snapped.

She cast a glance back at me, “I didn’t see you coming, sorry.”

*Liar.*

The words were hollow, I knew it was meaningless.

I showed a weary shrug, “don’t worry about it.”

Cara Laren, captain of the cheer. Dates the hottest guys of college. Apparently, bosses all the girls around. Couldn’t boss me.

So, I presumed that was the basis for her animosity toward me, putting that thought aside, I went back to my seat and awaited the start of the match.

## EVELYN

My eyes suddenly landed on Aden, as he ran to the field. His silky hair bouncing and catching the sun like a halo of gold. A smile formed on its own as a wave of thrill washed over me. The very same feeling of nervous excitement Ana got in her stomach.



The match kicked off and even though the players were performing expertly, my focus remained solely on Aden.

As I had foreseen, our college had won the game. In the aftermath, the crowd had lifted Aden onto their shoulders in celebration.

I finally caught his eyes, but just as I prepared to offer a sly smile, he quickly broke the contact and looked away.

Nonetheless, when he started to walk toward the gallery, I got my hopes up that he was heading for me.

*Although, why would he do that? That's bullshit.*

Until my eyes fell on Cara as she sprinted to him and Aden proceeded to kiss the living daylights out of her.

Stunned and numb, I was frozen in the spot, completely at a loss for how to respond. Despite being pushed around by the departing crowd, I was too weak to even flinch.

I was devastated by his intentional deception; I'd had a clear picture of his character, yet I chose to believe his words, and it completely backfired.

I felt such a searing pain in my chest that I instinctively reached for a handle to keep from collapsing, a single tear escaping my eye.

Upon seeing Aden, I immediately donned my sunglasses.

It was silly of me to get upset, over someone I had nothing with. I was embarrassed that I had some kind of expectation, that was never going to be met.

He had seen me as another conquest for the evening.

The sight was almost too much; their kiss was too fervent that it appeared as though they were practically absorbing each other. Almost felt intentional for me to notice.

Shayla suddenly ran and squeezed me in a triumphant bear hug, “we won, Eve. We won.”

She broke through my daze, I turned to her with a force, “yeah.”

Though I just wanted to cry my heart out there.

Later on, I talked with no one and comforted myself, alone in the room.

## ADEN

I knew the pain I caused Evelyn was undeniable, yet I rationalized my actions by believing it was for her own good. A damaged person like me would only corrupt her.

But, I couldn't escape the memory of her tearful eyes, a sight that haunts me relentlessly. The fact that I was the cause And that would be my biggest regret.

And it's something I'd never be able to move past.

In a fit of rage, I lashed out at the wall, injuring my hand so severely that my fingers had bled.

Erina, the housekeeper, rushed to my room, her whole body stiff with alarm, and asked, “what was that noise? Are you alright, Mr. Pattersen?”

“I need some solitude, Mrs. Craine. Thank you for your concern.”

Following my mother's death, her caring presence was all that I had. Before Evelyn, she was the only person who heard a kind word from me.

Erina, sensing my need for solitude, then withdrew. That night sleep was impossible and I could only gaze at the ceiling until dawn broke.

I was haunted by the thought how I spent a week observing

her in secret, never showing myself until the game just to cause her pain.

The following day, rather than seeking her out myself, I discreetly called a friend of hers at college.

“You wanted to see me, Aden?” Ana preened herself. My teeth locked in a punishing grip, “one more move and that conceited look, and I won’t be able to guarantee you’ll see tomorrow.”

Luke placed a steady hand on my chest to soothe me and then took over, addressing her himself, “Ana, I was wondering if you knew where Evelyn is?”

“Back to her country, England,” Ana replied bitterly.

“Wait, what? What do you mean her country?” Luke stammered completely taken aback.

Ana’s harsh demeanor eased slightly and she was enlightening Luke about Evelyn. Though the shimmering anger I felt towards her behavior hadn’t subsided, “Eve’s an Englishwoman, relocated to Virginia with her family after her father’s death when she was a child. Later, they moved here because of her brother’s job. He apparently teaches in here.”

Luke, still grappling with the revelation, finally responded, “Right, I know that part. So, for how long will she be gone?”

“Two months,” she said concisely.

“Two freaking months? Son of a bitch,” I shrieked, the shock of the news hitting me fully.

“You can go now and don’t tell anyone about anything we asked.” Luke sternly warned her. As if I cared.

*One week without her was absolute torture, how will I survive eight more?*

Yet it was a necessary choice for her well-being.

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# CHAPTER 4

ADEN

TWO MONTHS LATER

Evelyn's absence had been a torment. I felt as though I were trapped in a constant state of agony without her.

She had become the axis of my world, a fact I never consented to be in her absence, everything felt disconnected and hollow. My devotion to her safety had come at the cost of my soul.

But, I needed her. I couldn't survive without her. I'd had enough. England was the answer. With a private jet the plan was simple.

"We're flying to England, tomorrow morning." I blurted out to Luke on the phone.

"Hold on, but ..." Luke began, his voice laced with confusion.

"No buts!" I interrupted firmly, my command unwavering.

The following morning, we had boarded the jet and after a rough flight of approximately seven to eight hours, touched down in England.

Evelyn's home was in Manchester so we proceeded there and had taken up residence at a place my father owned for corporate purposes or maybe he'd been bringing his alleged girlfriend here.

I was absolutely drained that day, leaving me without the strength to go out.

Luke's hand fell on my shoulder as he looked closely at my face. Asking with a strained voice, "Are you alright?"

Lifting my head, I had managed a slow nod, "yes, I'm a little

beat. Get your ass to your room. Good night.” I ordered him to leave.

I was so high-strung that my tension was visible to him. Something never happened before.

“Good night.” Luke left, doubtful, glancing at my face as I sat with my head down on my bed.

## EVELYN

Two months had already passed since we had come here, it was almost the time to head back to New York.

Encountering Aden was something I wasn’t emotionally prepared for.

However, being in here and going to places I’d visited with my father as a child, provided a much-needed solace. Though it only made me sad.

“Mom, I’m off!” I called out, leaving for the familiar, dense woods and river where Derek and I used to go.

A jolt of alarm ran through me, I could swear my heart had left a beat when I spotted a large, muscular man in front of our house garden.

Alarmed and startled, I almost whipped around, but my legs gave out as I collapsed and I had crumpled to the ground.

Turning my head, my eyes widening in disbelief when I saw Aden standing there with a devilish smile.

My mother burst out of the house, the moment she heard me hit the ground. Her expression was one of intense anxiety as she fired off questions, “what was that? Are you alright, Eve?”

Her voice trailed off as her gaze followed mine, settling in Aden, whose eyes were already fixed on me.

He shifted his attention to Hannah, and spoke in a steady and

businesslike tone, “Mrs. Jones. I’m here for Eve. Do you mind?”

His straight forward manner didn’t bother me in the slightest. Him charming or buttering his words would have been a shock.

“Who...” Hannah began in confusion as she didn’t know Aden.

I stepped in before any more words were out, “No, she doesn’t. Let’s go.”

Then my mom kissed my forehead.

Aden encircled my waist with his hand, asserting a claim as if I belonged to him. I endured it until we were out of her view.

“You didn’t have to hurt yourself to get my attention, Darling.” Aden chided mockingly.

I finally dislodged myself from him.

“Yes, I know, I deserve that,” he said, lifting his eyebrows as he gazed down at me.

I hadn’t said anything, instead gave him an inquisitive, searching look.

“So, what brings you here?” I asked, my voice betraying nothing.

“Vacation with the girlfriend, huh?”

His hands from his pockets became a crushing force, pinning me to the tree, his grip tightening on my neck. He brought his face within an inch of mine, his voice a low, hostile sneer, “listen up, I’m not so good, don’t do that, darling. I’m not really gentle. At least not around you. And I definitely don’t date.”

He shoved himself off and turned his back, one hand on his hip, the other raking across his face in a desperate attempt to regain control.

I didn’t realize what had gotten into him, his effort failed and with a sudden roar he punched the nearby tree trunk. My body gave an involuntary twitch.

Turning back to face me, he offered his hand, his voice now gentle, “come on,” he said softly. “Let’s go where we were going.”

## EVELYN

I didn’t give him my hand and walked. Although his rage frightened me more than anything else.

Reaching there, we settled on the wooden board, that led to the water and my feet swaying peacefully over the water. He didn’t sit like that. He simply sat on the board, his legs bent.

Fixing my eyes at him, I confronted him, “If it’s about the match or that night, know that nothing was there between us. I know who you are. So no need to feel guilty-by-association. I had just called it a day and I’d suggest you do the same.”

*It wasn’t just nothing. But I couldn’t tell him. I knew, it was nothing for him.*

Typical Aden — invalidating my words and asserting his dominance — he moved his gaze to me, “Trust me, you’re not even close to know who I am. And you think I’m guilty? Jeez, Evelyn. Grow up a little.”

I drew my feet from the water into the board and reacted with an annoyed grunt. “Why is it that you can’t let me live? You don’t want this, but you wouldn’t let me get away either? What is wrong with you?” I got frustrated.

With a blink of an eye, he lifted me onto his lap, my legs circling his waist, his fingers cradling my jaw as he forced the words out in a harsh whisper,

“No one on this earth could desire you the way I do. I am a demon, too brutal for you to endure. I’ve tried to shield you from me, but the more I fight, the deeper I fall. I fear I’ll destroy you, yet I can’t be without you. You’ve got me under your control and

that terrifies me, my touch could harm your fragile skin... but, you're mine. You belong to me, and if anyone even dares to set eyes on you, I'll rip out his sight so he'll never be able to see this beautiful world again."

With his head lifted and eyes closed, he leaned in, resting his forehead against mine.

I didn't know how to react, torn between a thrill and a tremor of fear.

Slowly, almost unwillingly, I lifted my head, "uhm... what?" I said.

Without answering, he rose, pulling me up with him. In one swift motion he set me in the board and commanded, "let's go, we're heading to New York."

Stunned, I could only gasp, "W-what?... what about my family?"

"They can come with us," he said, so effortlessly, as if it were the simplest truth in the world and required no thought at all.

"No!" I blurted out. My chest tightened as panic clawed at me. "They are not leaving until a few more days. They have some business to handle."

"Then you shall come with me," he murmured, his words heavy with ownership and dark promise.

"No, I'm not." I shot back. My voice sharp, "you can't just command me. I live by my own rules."

"Listen, Eve. Take a step or I'll lift you into the car myself. I'm serious every time I make a statement." His tone sharp and unyielding, hand gesturing with authority.

"You wouldn't do that," I snapped, my hands pressed firmly over my chest.



“And, I’m not leaving for New York. This is my homeland, you can’t act as you please here.”

“Of course, why didn’t I think of that?” he mocked, his tone so casual and sharp I had almost believed he agreed.

Until he hoisted me effortlessly onto his shoulder, before I could protest.

He carried me to the car and set me inside in the back. Without a word, he signaled the driver and the engine roared.

As I tried to open the door, Aden locked my wrists with one hand steering them behind me. His voice was ice, “If you so much as twitch, you’ll regret it as I would put you to bed and the next thing you’d know is that you’re not able to sit for a month.”

*What? What did he mean by that?*

I stayed silent the entire way. Swallowed by the tension between us, until we reached his jet.

Luke’s voice rang across the tarmac, “woo-hoo! That’s my boy!” He yelled. Oblivious to my protests, Aden carried me toward the jet. My arm thrashing as I struggled to escape, since his grip was unyielding.

## ADEN

The entire flight passed in silence, Evelyn didn’t utter a single word, still simmering with anger, while I barely glanced her way, absorbed in business calls on my phone. But I had the flight attendant look after her.

“Your brother’s been told you’re flying back with me,” I murmured.

Eyes sharp, rolling her eyes, she said, “he didn’t object, well... he knows what I’m like.”

“As a hookers’ partner?” she scoffed, smirking, “that’s rich.”

Clearly enjoying the Jab, her voice carried a teasing edge.

I leaned in, close enough so she could feel the heat of my presence.

I let my voice lower and words drip with warning, “don’t fret, darling. I’ll handle this properly later. It ought to have been clear to you,

*NO PROVOKING.*

”

Without a word, she rolled her eyes at me, “you’ve just made another mistake,” I said, my finger pointing sharply at her, every syllable edged with slight warning.

Later on, we landed safely in New York City. Felt fresh to be back. Mark stood ready to take us home from the airport. He had been at my side as a trusted chauffeur for eight years. He opened the car door with his usual grace and greeted me warmly. “Mr. Pattersen, welcome back.”

“Thank you, Mark,” I said, offering him a faint nod of gratitude.

After a while, Evelyn realized we weren’t heading toward her home. She lifted her head, peered out at the unfamiliar road and then turned to me with confusion in her eyes, “This isn’t the...” she started softly.

“I know,” I interrupted gently. Though my voice carried a quiet firmness. “We’re going to my place. I can’t just leave you to stay there all alone.”

“I...” she began, then froze knowing her words wouldn’t count. Her gaze locked on mine, sharp and piercing eyes squeezed shut for a brief second. Lips tightening in silent fury. Almost as if she could punch me with nothing more than a look. Then, with a

deep exhale, she turned away.

I adored her anger. I couldn't help but notice how much she reminded me of myself, almost identical, except she held hers inside.

Reaching home, I showed Evelyn her room and asked Erina to look after her. Exhausted, I didn't linger and went straight to bed.

Next morning, I woke up to find Evelyn already waiting at the breakfast table. I greeted her in my usual, measured tone, since happiness wasn't something I wore often. "Good morning, Eve."

That was my first time calling her like that.

She returned my greeting softly. Her voice gentle as always, "Good morning."

"Did you sleep well?" I said, lifting the glass of water into my lips but never breaking eye contact with her.

"It was alright," she replied, her fork moving idly through her food, without glancing my way.

## ADEN

I set my glass down with a quiet clink, finishing the last bite of toast before speaking. "Get ready for college," I said firmly, brushing the crumbs from my fingers. "You've got your classes to attend and it's my graduation day as well."

She froze mid-bite, the fork slipping from her fingers with a soft clatter against the plate. Turning her full attention to me at last, her eyebrows furrowed with surprise, "what? I thought you had another year left."

"Technically I did, but extra credits helped me graduate the 'MBA' with, well...my seniors basically, ones who are anyway frightened by me," I said, letting my hand brush across the table

as I leaned back slightly, the corner of my mouth twitching in a faint, almost teasing grin.

“Sure they are,” she said, a small knowing smile tugged at her lips. Her eyes flickered towards me.

For a moment, I almost felt like, she wanted me to stay in the college longer. With the faint hesitation in her smile leaving from there.

I waited for her, one hand braced against the doorframe, the other tucked into my pocket, legs crossed, she descended the stairs, the soft sway of her simple but elegant purple dress and the faint sheen of lip gloss drawing my eyes and yet, it wasn't just that. It was everything about her in that quiet moment. My voice dropped slightly as I said, “you're gorgeous.”

She lowered her gaze, a slight blush coloring her cheeks, but after a moment of hesitation, she extended her hand as I offered mine. Letting our fingers meet in a quiet reassuring touch.

Without letting any emotion show on my face, I felt a surge of delight inside, as if she embodied everything I had ever longed for.

We got into the car and Mark started the engine, I reached over to fasten her seatbelt. As I tightened it, she let out a soft sigh, lifting her head slightly as a shiver ran down her spine at my touch.

I moved my hand away from her and looked straight ahead.

“We're going to the graduation party tonight,” I said, my voice steady though I could feel a quiet excitement building inside.

She stayed silent.

“Everyone is staring at us,” Evelyn whispered, her cheeks tinged with pink as she tried to edge slightly away. I kept my hand firmly around her waist, guiding her through the crowd, letting

her feel my presence without letting go, a quiet reassurance mixed with the heat of the moment.

“I’m pretty sure, they’re looking at you,” I said, tightening my hold around her waist. “They’re intimidated by your beauty.” I tried to sound comforting, but in the back of my mind, I wanted everyone to know exactly who she belonged to.

“Hi, son. I’m happy you made it,” Henry said, his smile warm as he approached in front of the auditorium. I nodded politely, but inside I reminded myself, I hadn’t come here for him. I had come because I wanted to. Doing things he wanted me to do would be the last thing I do in this world.

“Who’s this pretty young lady?” he asked, taking Evelyn’s hand and pressing a quick, polite kiss to it. Assuming she was my girlfriend.

“It’s so nice to meet you, Mr. Pattersen,” Evelyn said, her voice polite and measured, “I’m Evelyn.”

Before Evelyn could finish her introduction, I stepped in, my voice firm yet controlled, “That’s enough, dad. Take your seat back,” I said, placing a hand lightly on Evelyn’s back as a subtle cue to pause.

Both Evelyn and Henry nodded with polite smiles and he returned to his seat and Evelyn’s eyes stared at me as if I committed a crime.

“Being nice to your father wouldn’t have killed you.” Evelyn’s voice tinged with a teasing, condescending tone as she sat in the front row with me and leaned back sightly. Arms crossed loosely.

“Sure,” I replied, letting out a soft sigh, shrugged my shoulders looking around.

I felt a wave of discomfort wash over me, everything about this was new. The biggest moment I'd had before this was singing in front of people at my high school.

But, this- this was unfamiliar. Glancing back, I caught sights of my friends, their jaws dropping in disbelief, eyes wide. Their lips moved in unison, almost like a chorus, "Aden Pattersen is the man? You little bitch."

A sudden wave of shyness made me glance away, my stomach tightening with nerves. The chatter around me, dimmed as a clear voice rang out, "Aden Pattersen, you're requested to come up on the stage."

The crowd erupted, screaming their heart out as Aden stepped onto the stage. The claps and cheers were deafening. I found myself clapping along for him.

He cleared his throat, letting his voice carry over the applause. "Good morning, everyone. Just to be clear, we are all the same here. And I'm not up here to tell you to study or follow rules, just do whatever you want and to the bullies, I'm leaving, but don't think this is your kingdom now. I'll always be watching."

It was classic Aden Pattersen, even in his speech, he managed to throw a subtle threat, that made me smile from a corner of my lips. The crowd roared in response, chanting along with his words.

Later, we had come back, "Be ready by eight for the party."

Aden firmly said heading for his room. It was so like him, ordering around every time.

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## CHAPTER 5

### EVELYN

I made sure to be ready before eight, as he was a man of discipline and his temper flared easily.

But when I stepped outside, the driveway was empty. A hollow stillness hung in the air where I had expected him to be.

“Ms. Jones,” Aden’s personal driver called gently, catching my searching eyes, “Mr. Pattersen had to leave for an emergency. He’ll meet you at the party instead.”

“Thank you, Mr. McCall,” I murmured, stepping inside as he held the door open with practiced grace.

The moment I arrived, my friends descended on me, squealing and tugging at my arms before I could even catch my breath, “Evelyn De Jones, oh my God!” Ana shrieked. “Spill it! You’ve been dating Aden Pattersen?”

“He’s never shown up with a girl at a function before!” shayla said, elated.

I raised my hands, trying to settle them down. “Guys, calm down. We’re not dating. He was just keeping me company since my family’s still in England. There’s nothing between us.”

Even as I said it, I could feel the uncertainty curling in my chest. I wanted them to believe me, but the truth was:

I Wasn’t entirely sure what Aden and I were either.

Ana threw her hands in the air, half laughing, half exasperated.” Shut up! He’s in love with you, I’ve never seen him

like that with anyone. Ugh, we're going to miss him so much. I Can't even believe he's leaving."

"Eve, come here, I need you."

Before I could react, Aden appeared as if from nowhere. His movements were deliberate and confident, he closed the distance between us in a few long strides, his hands reaching out to gently but firmly take mine. Without a word, he guided me toward the dance floor, his grip steady, almost possessive, yet not harsh. Every motion carried the ease of someone completely in control, drawing me along with a quiet insistence that left no room for refusal.

He was no gentleman, he didn't ask for the dance. Instead, he slid his hand confidently to my waist, guiding me without hesitation, and I found my own resting naturally on his shoulder. There was a commanding ease to him, a quiet assertion that left no question about who was leading.

As the music swirled around us, his other hand gently guided mine along his chest, and every subtle movement carried an unspoken promise-an intensity that made my heart quicken. The world outside the dance floor faded; all that mattered was the press of his hand, the steadiness of his hold, and the way he seemed to anticipate every small motion, making me forget everything else.

"I couldn't be there to pick you up like a gentleman," he began, his voice low, edged with a quiet intensity. "Maybe because...I'm not one. But I really meant to..."

Before he could finish, I interjected, "No, it's fine. Mr. McCall is a good person..."

His eyes darkened, and a low growl escaped him.



“Let me finish,” he said, his jaw tight, clearly irritated by my interruption. There was an almost magnetic pull in the way he leaned slightly closer, his presence pressing in around me.

“I wanted to pick you up,” he continued, his tone softening just enough, “but something really important came up, so I had to leave. Did you have any trouble getting here?”

“No, it was absolutely fine,” I whispered, tilting my head up slightly to meet his gaze, offering a soft smile. My heart thudded in my chest, each beat echoing the unspoken tension between us, something heavier than words, a magnetic charge that neither of us dared to name.

His phone buzzed insistently in his pocket, but he didn’t reach for it, as if he assumed I wouldn’t like it.

“You can take it, it’s fine,” I said, forcing a casual smile. “I could use a moment with my friends anyway.”

“No. I’m not leaving you now. It’s not that important,” he replied, his voice firm yet gentle, trying to stay with me.

“It’s alright. Take it,” I insisted.

Reluctantly, he stepped aside, leaving me with my friends. But he didn’t disappear—he lingered at the edge of the room, eyes never leaving me. Even from the corner, the quiet vigilance in his gaze made me feel safe, as though nothing could touch me while he was there.

## EVELYN

As I chatted with my friends, a drunk man reached from behind and grabbed my thigh. “What’s a lady like you doing standing here without a date?” he slurred. I shoved him away, and before I could even glance at Aden, he appeared from behind, delivering a swift kick that sent the man sprawling. Aden struck

him once, then kept punching relentlessly until the man collapsed to the ground.

I tried to intervene, but against Aden's massive frame, I was powerless. He twisted the man's right hand; the one that had touched me, "How dare you lay a fucking hand on my girl?" Aden yelled twisting his hand much harder.

When I grasped his hand, trying to steady him, Aden rose to his feet, lifting himself upright. Before I could process anything, he turned to me, placing his hand on my throat in a powerful grip, and pressed his lips to mine, possessive and unyielding. He kissed me as if I were his alone, and in that instant, my heart seemed to leap from my chest.

My breath caught in my throat, and a wild mix of adrenaline and heat surged through me.

For eight or nine long seconds, time felt suspended. My knees weakened, and a strange trembling coursed through my body-I wanted to pull back, to scream, yet every instinct whispered to stay. His hand at my waist held me firmly grounding me even as the world spun, and a confusing thrill-equal parts fear, desire, and disbelief-raced through me. When he finally pulled back, I was gasping, my chest heaving, my mind struggling to catch up to what had just happened.

"You're mine. All of you is mine." His voice dropped into a low growl, every Word vibrating against my skin.

"No one can touch you. If anyone does, he'll regret it for the rest of his life. You belong to me; every part of you."

Before I could even open my mouth, the words hung between us, dark and possessive, heavy enough to steal my breath.

Everyone around us looked stunned, even frightened by his outburst, everyone except my friends. Their eyes sparkled, almost

giddy, as if they were thrilled to see him so fiercely possessive over me.

Then he grabbed my hand and tugged me along. “We’re leaving. Right now.”

In the car, the silence was heavy. Aden didn’t speak a word, his gaze fixed on the passing lights outside the window. My hand still rested in his, but it felt like a fragile lifeline in the midst of the tension. My heart pounded, a mix of nerves and something else I couldn’t name.

I stole glances at him, wondering what storm was brewing behind his calm, unreadable expression. Part of me wanted to break the silence, to ask what he was thinking, but another part feared disturbing the dangerous edge I could feel radiating from him. Each passing moment stretched, the quiet pressing in, making the world outside the car feel distant and unreal.

## ADEN

Reaching home, I didn’t spare a word for anyone and left Evelyn at the doorway, fury tearing me apart from the inside.

After freshening up, Evelyn knocked softly on my door. “May I come in?” she asked, while I sat hunched over, both hands clamped over my mouth, trembling with rage. I gave her no answer, but she entered regardless. “Eve, you should leave. I can’t talk right now,” I forced out, while inside, I ached for her, aching for the prison of her embrace, for her to hold me so tight it hurt, and never release me.

She sank onto the couch beside my bedm

“I just wanted to see how you’re doing,” she said, her voice tight, almost fragile.

Her eyes flicked to my hand, and in an instant, she was at my side, her fingers brushing mine. “Oh my God...you’re hurt,” she breathed, panic threading her words. “Let me get the first aid kit.”

“No... stay,” I whispered, my voice rough with need. “I don’t need anything.” I rested my head against her shoulder, letting the weight of my anger and longing settle into her.

She wrapped her arms around me, her touch soft, a whisper of comfort. “It’s okay. You’re okay,” she murmured.

“No,” I breathed, my voice breaking against her shoulder. “I’m never okay when I’m around you. I lose control. That’s how deep you’ve sunk into me. That’s how much power you have over me. I can’t not want you. If I told my heart to stop yearning for you, it might even stop beating, leaving me stranded, Eve.” I pulled back just enough to look into her eyes. “I’m not okay.”

Before she could speak, my words cut through the air like a blade. “He touched you. He wanted what’s mine. He’s lucky to still be breathing, to still see the world. Nobody dares to have you. You’re all mine.”

“Okey... It’s Alright. Just rest a little,” Eve whispered, her voice low and trembling as she held me tighter, pulling me so close I was almost lost against her chest.

I gently loosened her hold and drifted toward the window, bracing myself with both hands against the wall as though I might shatter without the support. Slowly, I turned, just enough for her to catch the torment etched in half my face. My voice was raw, trembling between love and restraint. “If you only knew what I dream of doing to you, and how much it destroys me to hold myself back.”

“If you only knew how hard it is to resist myself around you... That’s why I never wanted you in my room at the first place, just you and me, no rules. I’m afraid of what I’d do to you.”

“Maybe...I want you to,” Evelyn breathed, her voice soft but trembling, the words more a plea than defiance. Fear flickered in her eyes, though her body betrayed her with the way it leaned toward him.

“What?” I rasped, leaning closer, certain I couldn’t have heard her right.

“I said...do it. There’s no one here to stop you,” she whispered, the tremor in her voice betraying the terror beneath her words.

Before letting her finish, in a flash, I was on her, pressing her into the bed with a force that was almost too much to contain. My shirt fell to the floor as a low, feral growl escaped me. “No one can stop me anyway, not even me, darling,” I murmured, the edge of restraint barely holding back what I wanted.

## ADEN

I kissed her like I had kissed no one before, her soft skin pressing against my roughness. She felt almost fragile, like something too delicate for this world- no man deserved her, not even me. I trailed over her body to her neck, feeling her shiver under my lips. A soft moan escaped her, almost a plea for more, unaware that every motion, every kiss, was me silently begging; begging only for her touch.

I wasn’t built for gentleness, and yet for her I’d tear the world down. I wanted to be soft with her; I tried, but some part of me only knew how to burn. I forced myself to breathe and asked, “Have you ever... done this before?” Her answer came, almost a whisper, fragile and honest, “No.” The word landed like a vow I

meant to keep or break, I couldn't tell which.

I froze, shock threading my voice. "You've...never had sex? Why?"

Her eyes met mine, hesitant, vulnerable, yet burning with something untamed. She swallowed and whispered, "I never trusted anyone. never could. You... you were my first kiss, too."

The words hit me like fire and ice all at once, fragile, sacred, and impossibly hers.

"Oh, Eve...what do I do with you?" I murmured, pressing my lips to hers, feeling her nails dig lightly into my back. As I trailed lower, I caught the tremble in her eyes; a mix of fear and anticipation. My voice dropped, low and possessive. "Don't worry, darling... I'll go slow and steady."

A flicker of something crossed her lips, a smirk, tiny but undeniable, and I swore it made my heart skip, even as desire twisted through me like fire. I saw the tremor in her eyes.

I had never been like this with anyone. Her bare body pressed against mine felt like both a temptation I couldn't resist and a treasure I feared to break. After an hour of fevered closeness, it still wasn't enough for me, but I restrained myself, not wanting to overwhelm her fragile perfection. Every gasp, every shudder that escaped her lips drove me deeper, and when I moved inside her, it was as if the world had ceased to exist, leaving only us, consumed by need, tethered by desire, and bound by the fragile intimacy that made her mine in every way that mattered.

As she was settled over me, She pressed her lips to my chest, and her eyes lingered on the scar." What happened?" she whispered, her voice trembling with concern.

I drew a slow breath, feeling the weight of memories I didn't want to share. "Nothing... just a scar from childhood. I don't

really remember.”

The truth was far darker then I was letting on, a bullet meant for my mother had pierced me through her body, leaving more than just a mark on my skin. I couldn’t let her know that yet. Some scars, I realized, were mine alone to carry, but having her here, so close, made the ache of hiding it almost unbearable.

She kissed the scar one last time, lingering as if trying to press herself into the memory of me. When she lifted her head, her eyes searched mine with an innocence that made my chest ache. “Have you ever been in love, Mr. Pattersen?”

I let out a bitter laugh, tasting the edges of my own regret.” Love?” I murmured, dark and low.” It’s a dangerous for me... I’ve lost everything I’ve ever dared to love. Everything.”

“So, who do you love the most in the world?” she asked.

I scoffed, “who else?...me.”

But she felt the pang inside me, Then she pressed herself against me, hugging me tighter, as if holding on to every piece of me she could. Slowly, she relaxed into my chest, letting sleep claim her, but I stayed awake, haunted by the ache of wanting her and the danger of feeling this close.

## ADEN

When I woke, the space beside me was empty. For a heartbeat my stomach dropped, a pulse of worry tearing through me. I threw on a shirt and went downstairs, only to find her in the kitchen with Erina, sunlight spilling over her like it had chosen her.

I couldn’t describe the moment. My chest clenched with something sharp and nameless, then slowly unwound into a

strange, quiet happiness just from seeing her. I leaned against the doorway, whispering under my breath,

*What is she doing to me?*

“Good morning, Mr. Pattersen,” she said, her voice soft, carrying the warmth of the morning.

“Good morning, Eve,” I murmured, leaning down to press a gentle kiss to her forehead, lingering just enough to let her feel how much of me was already hers.

“Your brother has landed and asked me to send you back home. But... you can stay here with me,” I said, trying to mask the pull I felt toward her.

“No,” she replied, a playful glint in her eyes. “I think I’m going to stay at my place, with my ordinary and normal family...beside you’re dangerous for me.”

She leaned in, brushing her lips against mine in a teasing kiss, and I felt the delicious mix of warning and temptation that she always carried with her.

“You’ll anyway staying with me,” I said, my voice low and dangerous as I arched an eyebrow across the breakfast table, “other than just...not sleeping here and that’s enough for me, I can live with that. Or you could just sleep here, if you want.”

The words hung between us like a quiet claim, and I could feel the tension coil in the space where desire and control collided.

“No, Thank you,” she said with a slight grin.

Later, I drove her home, and before stepping out, I pressed my lips to hers. The kiss lingered, a quiet promise, leaving a heat between us that neither words nor distance could cool. I pulled back reluctantly and walked away, the memory of her still burning under my skin.



She wasn't just someone I wanted; she was everything I needed. When the world pushed me to the edge, she was the calm that kept me from exploding, a force I could never control yet craved desperately. She had power over me in ways I'd never known, and I was falling- headfirst, recklessly for her.

Love had always been an unknown, a concept I'd never dared to touch. I had only ever loved my mother, and that love was simple, familiar. But her death had given me nightmares everynight. And, *This...this was different. Dangerous, consuming, and entirely hers but a nightmare I craved myself.*

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## CHAPTER 6

### EVELYN

Ana crossed her arms with a teasing grin, leaning against the classroom doorframe, “Look who finally decided to show up after a decade.”

I scratched the back of my neck and gave a sheepish smile, walking toward her. “Ha-ha-ha, it’s good to see you guys too.”

Ana shook her head, rolling her eyes but still pulling me into a quick hug before shoving my shoulder playfully.

Shayla leaned over the desk, her voice bursting with excitement. Her hands flew up as if she couldn’t contain herself. “So, you’re dating Aden and he’s hitting people for you? That’s ravishing, girl!” She shook your arm with a wide grin, practically glowing with delight.

“I mean... yeah, maybe,” I sighed, rubbing my temple before folding my arms across my chest. “I don’t know, guys, it’s complicated. He doesn’t say what we are. He was the guy I swore I’d stay away from at the beginning of the year, and now...” Shayla let out a short, frustrated laugh, “and now, you guys have been fucking for a month.”

I rolled my eyes, My arms tightened against me as I shrugged. “So, I don’t know what we are.”

Ana smirked, nudging my side with her elbow. “You’ve been away for three months. Two in England, we get it. But we all guessed the other month was spent in his clubs. So, trust me, we know you guys are fucking.”

My arms crossing before I even registered what she said. My brows shot up. “Wait, did you just say clubs?”

My face scrunched in confusion. “Why would I be in his clubs?” I asked, tilting my head at her.

Ana arched an eyebrow, lips curling into a sly smile. “Well, because that’s where he sleeps with girls... unless he didn’t, with you.” She dragged out the last words, Watching me closely for a reaction.

“Yes, because I was in his bed, in his room,” I said firmly, folding my arms like I’d just dropped the final word.

Ana’s jaw practically hit the floor before she clapped a hand over her mouth. “Oh. My. God. He’s in love with you. I’m a thousand percent sure now.” Her voice pitched higher with each word as she leaned closer, eyes wide. “He literally never took anyone to his house. Let alone his bed. Like, I thought he would never, well, at least not in this lifetime. But he took you.” She pointed at me dramatically, grinning in disbelief.

“Okey, stop it. You’re thinking way out of the box,” I said, waving my hand as if to shoo her away, but my fingers trembled slightly.

Still, my mind refused to settle. All through class, I kept thinking about it; if he really was in love with me. I twisted the strap of my bag nervously, biting the inside of my cheek. It felt absurd. He can’t be in love with me.

Yet, deep down, I knew I was falling for him. My chest tightened just thinking about him. He would either be my scarred knight, the one who saved me, or the biggest heartbreak I’d never be able to bear I hugged my arms to myself, trying to keep the storm inside at bay.

Aden's face lit up on my screen. "Hi, Eve," he said over FaceTime.

"Hi, Mr. Pattersen," I whispered, glancing around the classroom. "Uhm, I'm actually in the middle of class. I'll talk to you later."

"I'll be back by next month," Aden replied, his tone casual but steady. "Got a few meetings to attend to. I'll see you, bye."

The call ended, leaving his image frozen in my mind. He was in L. A., busy with something tied to his company. The Patterson Holdings Group Inc, meant everything to him, it was his mother's legacy, and he carried it like armor.

But it was stronger than ever after he took over.

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## CHAPTER 7

### EVELYN

The month had finally passed; Aden was coming back today. I could hardly sit still, happiness buzzing through me. I had missed him more than I wanted to admit.

After college, I went straight to his house, clutching a small bouquet of lilies and tulips as they were something I was fond of and he didn't like any particular flower.

My heart raced with every step up the driveway. I'd told him I'd be here, waiting.

"Mrs. Craine, are you home?" I called softly as I stepped inside.

"Hi, Ms. Jones."

I nearly jumped out of my skin; Erina's voice came from behind me, making me spin around in surprise.

"oh my... jesus!" I gasped, pressing a hand to my chest. "Sorry, you just startled me a little."

She chuckled softly, folding her arms with a knowing smile. "Didn't mean to, dear. You looked so lost in your thoughts."

I exhaled, clutching the flowers tighter, my cheeks warming.

"Is Mr. Pattersen home yet?" I asked, lowering myself onto the couch in the living room. My fingers toyed with the flowers in my lap, petals brushing against my thumb.

"No, not yet," Erina's voice floated in from the kitchen, the faint sound of clinking dishes following her words.

I leaned back against the cushions, trying to steady the flutter in my chest. The wait already felt endless.

“He was supposed to be back by now,” I murmured, worry slipping into my voice as I pulled out my phone.

I dialed Luke, chewing on my lip while the call rang. Aden hadn’t picked up any of my calls, and my grip on the phone tightened with every second of silence.

“Luke, hi, where are you guys? Mr. Pattersen was supposed to be here by now, where are you guys now?” I asked quickly, my voice low but trembling.

There was a pause on the other end, heavy enough to make my stomach twist.

“There was an accident,” Luke replied, his tone rushed. “But we’re fine. We’re just outside of Aden’s house.”

Before I could even respond, the line went dead; he had hung up.

My hand froze around the phone, the flowers slipping slightly from my lap as my heart dropped.

The phone slipped in my hand as a cold chill ran down my spine. My heart pounded.

I didn’t even know what I felt at that moment. My whole body froze, rooted to the couch, while my heart sank under a weight I couldn’t name. It was nothing like the rush of a football match day; this wasn’t adrenaline, it was dread.

I didn’t know how to feel, what to do. All I wanted was to hear Aden’s voice, just once, to know he was alright. To hear him call me “Eve” in that steady tone that always anchored me.

“Ms. Jones?” Erina’s voice cut through my thoughts. I jumped slightly, glancing up. She stood in the doorway, concern written

all over her face. “Do you... do you want some water? Or maybe get some refreshing air?”

Her presence grounded me slightly, reminding me I wasn't entirely alone. But the phone call, Luke's words-they still echoed in my chest.

## EVELYN

The elevator chimed and the doors slid open.

Aden stepped out, lifting his head despite the blood trickling from a cut on his forehead and scrapes on both hands. Time seemed to stop.

I couldn't move my body frozen in place. And yet, something unexpectedly soothing washed over me. Relief, gratitude, and fear tangled together as tears streamed down my face. I sank onto the couch, letting my sobs shake through me.

He limped toward me, but I couldn't look away. Seeing him, battered yet alive, was the only thing that mattered.

He wrapped me in his arms, holding me tightly, and pressed a gentle kiss to my forehead. I couldn't even hug him back; instead, I rested my face against his chest, sobbing uncontrollably.

“Miss me, darling?” he murmured softly, his voice low and teasing, but there was concern under it.

I sobbed a little louder, the sound muffled against him.

“Hey, hey, I'm okay,” he reassured me, lifting my chin slightly so I could see him. A small, crooked smile tugged at the corner of his lips. “See? Fit as ever.”

The warmth of him, even injured, anchored me. For the first time in what felt like forever, I could breathe again.

Something inside me was back.

I sat next to him after he'd taken a warm shower carefully tending to the scrapes on his hands and arms. The faint scent of his cologne mixed with the warmth lingering on his skin, making my heart race.

He leaned back slightly, eyes soft but sparkling with mischief. "Did you just cry for me, darling?"

I felt my cheeks flush and quickly hid my face, tucking it into my hair. "What...No. something just went in my eyes. I don't cry," I whispered, my fingers trembling slightly as they brushed over his bandages.

He chuckled, low and warm, and gently reached out. Lifting my chin so I could

meet his gaze. His thumb brushed across my cheek, tracing a soft line down to my lips. "You know you don't have to hide it from me, I like it when you care for me. That's something no one has ever done for me," he murmured, voice thick with something I couldn't name-something tender.

I swallowed, my heart pounding, as our eyes locked. The teasing in his smile softened into something deeper, and for the first time, I let myself just be close to him.

Changing my tone, I asked, "So, what exactly happened?"

His jaw tightened, but his voice stayed steady. "Mark was driving," he began, his eyes narrowing as though replaying the moment. "Suddenly this psycho, drunk off his ass, swerved right into our lane. He hit us head-on."

He lifted his hand, showing a faint scrape across his knuckles, then shrugged as if it meant nothing. "He was hurt pretty badly, but thank God, nothing serious happened to the three of us. Luke and Mark are fine. I just got a couple of little cuts."



“Okay, Mr. Pattersen, I think you should get some rest,” I murmured as I slipped off the edge of his bed.

Before my feet fully touched the ground, he caught me, pulling me against him with sudden strength. In one swift motion, he lifted me; my legs instinctively wrapping around his hips. My back pressed against the wall, the cool surface sending a shiver through me, while his hand slid behind my head to shield it from the impact.

He leaned in so close I could feel the warmth of his breath mingling with mine, his eyes burning into me. “I don’t need rest, darling, what I need right now is beyond your imagination,” he whispered, his voice low and rough, before crashing his lips onto mine, kissing me hard, urgent, and unyielding.

*He is absolutely good.*

## EVELYN

Still kissing me, he shifted and rolled us onto the bed, keeping me close as if he couldn’t bear even an inch of distance. His arm braced against the mattress, protecting me from the weight of his body, though his warmth hovered all around me.

I felt his breath brush my lips as he pulled back just enough to look at me, his forehead gently resting against mine. My hands slid up his chest, fingers curling into his shirt as though holding him there could stop time.

“You don’t know how much I missed this, us, in Los Angeles, darling,” he whispered, his voice rough but tender. His thumb grazed my cheek, and his eyes softened, carrying both hunger and vulnerability.

A shaky breath left me as I cupped his face, my own lips brushing the corner of his.

“Damn it, Eve...what do you do to me?” he said, almost as if confessing a secret before pulling me back into another kiss; slower this time, as though he wanted to savor every second.

“I almost live for this now, my heart longs for this.”

“Shut up... and kiss me,” I whispered, tugging him closer.

His eyes darkened at my words. Without another second’s hesitation, his mouth claimed mine; hungry, consuming, as if he’d been starved of me for centuries.

His hands roamed my body with urgent reverence, pulling at fabric until there was nothing between us but skin and heat.

Each time his lips found a new place, he murmured against me, low and rough, “Like this?”

My breath hitched, a soft moan escaping as I whispered back, “More...kiss me more there.”

He obeyed with maddening slowness, every touch deliberate, every movement reminding me of his strength and restraint. My fingers clawed at his shoulders, urging him closer, deeper.

Pinned beneath him, the world outside ceased to exist. His forehead pressed to mine, his voice broke into a growl, “Told you, Eve... I can’t be gentle.”

I cupped his face, meeting his gaze with equal fire, my voice steady despite the tremor in my chest. “I don’t want you to be.”

His lips crashed into mine again, and the rest was nothing but heat, shadow, and the sound of our breaths tangling in the dark.

when the fire inside me became almost unbearable, I whispered, “Aden... stop.”

He froze for a heartbeat, then slowly turned, his eyes smoldering like molten glass. He lifted me effortlessly, seating me on his lap as if reclaiming me, just like he had at the very

beginning. His arms wrapped around me tightly, pressing me against the warmth of his chest, holding me with a possessive intensity that made my heart race.

“Sure, anything you want,” he murmured, his voice low, rough, yet almost tender. “I wanted pleasure for us, not pain for you.”

I leaned into him, feeling the power and protection in his embrace. His large hands framed my face, thumbs tracing along my cheeks as his gaze drilled into mine.

“I want you to call me... my name, just like you did. You feel more mine then,” he said, each word a soft command, each pause a promise of something darker.

I swallowed hard, letting my voice catch. “Mmm...hmm.”

A slow, dangerous grin curved his lips, eyes glinting with mischief and heat. “Shit. did you just turn this bed into a mere ocean?” he breathed, pulling me closer, his body enveloping me as if the world outside had vanished.

I could feel the electricity between us, a storm of desire and longing, and even in the darkness, his presence was all-consuming-possessive, protective, and intoxicating.

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## CHAPTER 8

### ADEN

“Later, darling,” I murmured, pressing a soft kiss to her lips before stepping out of the car. The morning sun caught the edge of her hair, and for a moment, I lingered, just taking in her presence. Then, reluctantly, I let her go and drove away.

Moments later, my phone buzzed. I glanced at it to see Luke’s name flashing on the screen.

“Luke...what’s up? Why did you call me so urgently?” I asked, trying to mask the curiosity and a little unease in my voice.

“I need you here,” he said, his tone sharp but tinged with urgency.

“On my way,” I replied, already moving toward the office, my mind racing with questions.

The instant my foot cleared the threshold of the office, Luke lunged into my path.

“Shean Erling,” he rasped, his voice low and tight, betraying a frantic urgency. His hand, a white-knuckled vise, clamped down on my forearm, arresting my forward momentum. “He’s trying to reach you.” His eyes, crumpled under pressure.

“What does he want? Is he in town now? I’m anyway gonna kill him.”

I shoved forward, my momentum aiming for the door, but Luke’s grip became iron on my elbow. “No, wait!” he hissed, pulling me back with a sharp jerk. “He isn’t in the country. He’s trying to threaten you from afar. Listen to this...”

He fumbled with his phone, the silence between us thick and ringing, before pressing play. A voice, calmly menacing, filled the air, “Aden, if you don’t want people around you dead too, give me what I want.”

My breath hitched-a soundless, ragged thing.

“What a fucking lunatic, talking like a cat from afar! Tell him to give it a try,” I spat, the words tasting like ash. A cold, surgical rage replaced the hot flare of my temper. I pictured him, not dead quickly, but dying little by little, with so much pain. He’d be writhing and grovelling, begging for the sweet release and mercy of death. And I’d grant it to him, eventually. But not until, I witness the fracture of his spirit, until I heard the wet desperate sound of his heart cracking from the inside. He had taken what I loved the most in this world.

He killed my mother.

He had taken what I loved the most in this world.

“Calm Down, Aden. You know what a psychotic idiot he is. He doesn’t care about anyone, but him,” Luke urged, his voice softening, a fruitless attempt to apply logic to a screaming bad wound.

I ripped my arm free from his grip, the sudden movement knocking a file folder off the corner of my desk. The sound was swallowed by my voice, which had dropped to a dangerous, vibrating whisper, “Don’t fucking tell me to calm down. He fucking killed her, Luke! My mom.”

My chest heaved. I clenched my fists until my knuckles were white. My gaze pointed to some devastating point in the distance. “It still haunts me how I couldn’t save her.” The confession was ragged and exposed the scar of my failure and pain.

“Yeah, I know, Ad. I know. But you know what he’s aiming for, now. Evelyn.”

The name hit me like a physical blow. My eyes flew wide open in shock. Evelyn. I hadn’t thought about her. Not like this.

She was something I started fresh. The bright fragile centre of my life now. She was all that I had left.

*I couldn’t lose her.*

“What? That’s bullshit,” I stammered, the rage in my body momentarily dissolving into cold dread.

“I know, Ad,” Luke insisted, his voice steadying mine. “He knows he can’t even touch your hair. Evelyn is what he’d go for.”

## ADEN

The dread instantly ignited into a scorching, focused fury. I snatched his collar, the cotton bunching in my fist, yanking him close until our noses nearly touched. “Shut up. I will tear him up if he even lays his eyes on her.” My threat wasn’t just words; it was a guttural promise, powered by a blinding, protective instinct.

Luke held up a hand. “Calm down, Ad,” he said, his expression unreadable as the fabric of his shirt crumpled in my fist.

Then, my tension snapped. I shoved his collar away, the force of the release more about letting go of my own rage than pushing him.

“I’m calm,” I ground out, taking a ragged step back. My gaze turned hard and distant, already plotting. “And I’ll protect her 24/7, no matter what it takes.”

Luke smoothed the wrinkles from his collar, his eyes never leaving mine. “You and I both know it’s not possible, Ad. She won’t even be safe in her own house if she’s with you.”

He was right. I knew that. The truth was a heavy, cold anchor

settling in my gut. I was selfish enough to keep her for me. She was the only good thing happening in my life; I couldn't just let her go. Letting her walk away would feel like another failure, another death.

I met Luke's gaze, my resolve hardening into a steel-edged certainty. "We'll see about that," I said, my voice quiet now, the anger replaced by a dangerous, firm decision.

The whole day went into a literal disaster. Luke and I spent hours mapping out every angle, every resource, because Erling said the name of the prize: My company.

Shean and I were best friends in childhood; our fathers were best friends, and the Erling Holdings and Our Company were started together. My mother took over after Dad was away on other businesses, and that's when everything fractured. Our company was awarded "Best in the Town." We were only thirteen. Something vile twisted inside Shean.

He shot my mother because their company couldn't be number one.

I always knew it was a setup planned by his father, but later, Shean tried to kill me, too. Some of his people even got what they deserved. I made myself the demon I was because of them. I tore their heart apart before I shot them and pitied them. Before I could do anything about Shean, before I could touch him, he left the country, vanishing into the shadows he clearly belonged in. I could have killed him if I wanted to. But I was determined I would be the one to tear his throat out in this very soil. Where he did the dirtiest sin of his life and now he had to live like a coward, in fear of me.

EVELYN

My breathless utterance, “Hey, you!” fractured the air as I bolted toward Aden, who stood outside the collegiate gates, a rich bouquet of tulips a bold splash of color against his dark coat.

His deep voice was a velvet rasp against my ear as he caught me, “Hey, darling,” and his mouth claimed mine in a devastating kiss. “come here,” he commanded, crushing me against his chest in a powerful, possessive embrace.

“I haven’t heard from you since yester...” I began, pulling back slightly. My gaze snagged on the figure of Max, standing nearby. “I know, I’m sorry, something had bothered me in the office,” Aden stated, his expression hardening when he felt me freeze. “What’s wrong?” he demanded, his

eyes tracing the line of my attention to Max. “No, that’s Max, I met him in your party, he just looked at us and seemed unhappy as we kissed.”

Aden’s eyes, sharp as obsidian, fixed on Max, who immediately turned his head away. “I know who he is,” Aden rumbled, his large hand settling like an iron brand on my hip, anchoring me to his side as he started us walking. His voice dropped to a lethal whisper. “Apparently people want what’s mine. Sad for him.”

I offered a skeptical, lingering look before conceding, “What’s yours?”

The seductive tension of the moment shattered as Aden’s gaze, dark and intense, abruptly shifted forward. He held my eyes for another charged second before his focus snapped to the busy street.

“We’ll be going somewhere next weekend,” he stated, his voice a low, firm command, a subtle shift in tone that implied the matter was already decided. “Thought we could use a little respite from the mundane.”



“Really? Can my friends come?” I asked, a sudden spark of excitement overriding the previous darkness. The thought of a shared escape brightened my mood.

A faint, almost reluctant smile touched his lips. “Yeah, if you want. Besides, Luke insisted he and Maddie want to go as well, only if you don’t have any problem. Or I’ll tell them no.”

“No, absolutely! They can come,” I beamed. “Okay, settled. Get in the car. I’m dropping you home.” He opened the passenger door for me with a possessive sweep of his arm.

“Okay.” Though I wanted to spend more time with him, I knew his schedule was unforgiving, and he had to leave after dropping me home.

He waited until I was settled and buckled in, leaning over the console. His expression had darkened again, the possessiveness returning, stark and undeniable. His words weren’t a request; they were an order wrapped in velvet. “Don’t leave home before informing me, alright?”

I arched my eyebrows in confusion at the abrupt, almost paranoid tone. “Sure.” He seemed weird; a little unhinged, but I simply guessed, It’s just him.

I stormed through the front door, the possessive intensity of Aden still clinging to me, and went straight for my brother’s room. I flung the door wide without a thought. “Eww, guys, gross. You could’ve at least locked the door,” I snapped, recoiling instantly as I caught my brother in a deep, private embrace with a girl I didn’t recognize. I slammed the door shut and stood there, heart hammering, until a moment later, they emerged into the living room, both looking ruffled but attempting a semblance of dignity.

“You could have at least knocked, Don’t I have any privacy?” my brother challenged, his voice tight with irritation.

“Since when? You had always yelled at me for knocking, and you never knocked on my door,” I shot back, folding my arms. The retort was instantaneous and effective. He immediately looked disarmed.

“Well?” I prompted, demanding an introduction and an explanation.

“Uh, this-this is Helen Roger, she’s a friend of mine,” he stammered, awkwardly gesturing toward the woman.

Helen extended a hand, offering a polite but strained smile. “Helen.”

“Evelyn. Sorry, It’s awkward but nice to meet you,” I replied, shaking her hand, sensing the deep discomfort radiating from her as she awkwardly forced a smile, ” No, It’s alright.”

I turned my back on the awkward pair, the image of their hurried embrace seared into my mind. I took a few quick steps, and once the door to my room swung shut, I released a vehement whisper into the empty space, *Who fucking does that, yuck, so gross.* I flung my bag onto the desk, still shuddering at the lack of boundaries.

I crossed the room and fell onto my bed, the image fading, replaced now by the unsettling intensity of Aden’s gaze and his strange command, *Don’t leave home before informing me, alright?* He was dominating, yes, but that particular instruction felt less like romance and more like an invisible chain.

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## CHAPTER 9

### EVELYN

A loud knock fractured the routine.

“Coming,” I yelled, already moving toward the door. Pulling it open revealed Aden. “Aden!”

He was there unannounced that day.

“Hi, Eve,” he murmured, leaning down to give me a soft kiss.

“Are these for me?” I asked, eyeing the elegant bouquet in his hand.

“Yours are in my car, darling. Erina said it’d be nice if I brought flowers for your mom as I was coming to see you,” he explained, shrugging with a hint of awkward shyness, a rare display given his usual composure. He wasn’t accustomed to such social formalities.

“Wow, how thoughtful, Mr. Aden Pattersen, I’m impressed. Well, not that it was your idea,” I teased him, folding my arms.

“Who is it, Eve?” Hannah called out, already approaching the entryway.

Aden turned, his demeanor instantly shifting to one of respectful formality. “Hi, Mrs. Jones.”

“Hi!” Hannah responded warmly. “Come on in, why are you standing outside?”

Aden extended the bouquet. “They are for me? Wow, they are very pretty, thank you, honey. Sit,” she said, accepting the flowers and gesturing toward the living room. “Stay for dinner today, it’d

be nice to have you for dinner.” she offered kindly, already moving toward the kitchen.

“Yeah, I would love to, but not today, Mrs. Jones,” Aden replied smoothly, standing tall and respectful. The change in his demeanor from the dark, possessive man at the college gates to this polite suitor, absolutely jarring. “I just wanted to ask you to let Eve- Evelyn come with me. I’ll drop her by midnight, safely.”

Hannah paused, considering his earnest request. “Midnight is fine. Just be careful.”

“Thank you, Mrs. Jones. I appreciate it,” he said, the corner of his mouth turning up in a genuine, charming smile.

I scoffed, “yeah mom. He’s way too careful.” My voice was teasing and playful.

“For the record, I have a personal driver. You don’t have to worry.” He was firm and I knew he meant it for me.

He wasn’t someone who typically asked for permission; he usually took. It was so unexpectedly nice of him to show this deference. He’d often just throw me over his shoulder and carry me off whenever the mood struck him. He was softening, or perhaps, this was a calculated, completely different side of him, a gentle veneer he only used when seeking favor. The contrast was fascinating, and utterly disarming. Cause, the Aden I knew was never built for formalities. But I was quite happy with it.

As we settled into the luxurious confines of his car, my eyes caught a stunning, overwhelming display in the seat: multiple, extravagant bouquets, far more than just a single bunch. “They are exquisite,” I gasped. “Glad you like them, there are more in the trunk.” He let out a half sleek smile. “They’re my favorite and I love all flowers.” I shrugged.

“Guess where we’re going?” Aden asked, a rare, genuine spark of delight in his eyes.

“Maybe one of your favorite, secluded places?” I ventured, thinking of the quiet, exclusive venues he preferred.

He scoffed, a deep chuckle rumbling in his chest. “You’re so wrong. I detest everything about something like this, but I know you love it. Taylor’s concert. Her tour is in New York City tonight.”

My breath hitched. “Oh my god, you remembered! Thank you, thank you so much!” I launched myself across the center console and threw my arms around his neck, “I’m so freaking excited, it’s literally my first time seeing her in person.”

He pulled me close, his intensity instantly returning as he captured my mouth in a sudden, deep kiss. He had given me a gift that meant the world to me, but the look in his eyes promised that the night would ultimately be about his possession of me.

## ADEN

The deafening, vibrant pulse of the arena throbbed around us, the concert already in full, spectacular swing.

Eve was shouting something over the music, so I leaned in, my ear close to her mouth. “This is called Ready For It?” she explained, trying to enlighten me about the minutiae of this Taylor phenomenon. I had zero knowledge of her music; I rarely listened to any songs, and frankly, I never danced. The most movement I managed was a slight sway only when I was with Eve, and she knew perfectly well I couldn’t dance to save my life.

“In the middle of the night, in my dream, you should see the things we do, baby” Eve sang along, her voice a sweet, enthusiastic counterpoint to the stadium speakers. She looked directly at me, her eyes shining with the stage lights. I pulled her

from behind, my hand a chain or more like a steel band across her middle and breathed with my voice a dangerous, possessive whisper that only she could hear over the roars, "Other than me inside you in plenty of different positions? Or you bent over in front of me? We do what makes a devil like me blush too. It's clearly not love that we make, it's a total ruin and FYI, I gladly enjoy being buried inside you." I let go of her. I knew she felt something. She was blushing.

She was utterly lost in her joy, enjoying the view of her idol, and I was utterly lost in mine. God, she was a goddess, literally fallen from heaven and standing right here, incandescent with delight.

Evelyn vibing with Taylor looked at me, tilting her head, a mocking smirk playing on her lips, one eyebrow slightly raised in challenge, "you know, this is what girls cry over, not men."

I leaned forward, a lazy confident grin spreading across my face. I gave a slow, deliberate shrug, "well, I've seen many of them cry for me, baby. So, not convinced."

She rolled her eyes, letting out a small incredulous puff of the air, but the corner of her mouth twitched upward, "Sure you did."

"Don't blame me, love makes me crazy, if it doesn't you ain't doin' it right," Taylor's voice boomed, turning into a growl just as Evelyn's finger pulled on my black shirt, the tender tug of fabric and electronic thread, her half lidded almond eyes, a silent, playful attempt to seductively closing the distance.

I didn't hesitate. I leaned into her space, my voice low and dark, cutting through the music like a razor. "Baby, trust me, you make me go crazier than you can ever imagine," I murmured, my hands finding their inevitable place, settling firmly on her lower back, staking my claim in the most public of places.

Evelyn moved her sight back to the stage with a dazzling shy smile.

I saw it happen. Even from the elevated VIP lounge, Taylor Swift's eyes-trained on the crowd-flickered up and met Evelyn's gaze. A subtle, practiced smile curved the superstar's lips, and she gave a quick, unmistakable wave directly at Evelyn.

Her reaction was explosive. "Oh my god, she waved at me! This is the best night!" she shrieked, jumping right there in the confined space, utterly unselfconscious.

I'd never witnessed such unbridled joy from her; it was a dazzling, infectious sight, and the genuine delight radiating off her made the entire, ridiculous concert worth the price of the tickets and the agony of listening to the music. I was genuinely happy to see her so euphoric.

## ADEN

We lingered a few more minutes, letting her savor the climax of the show. But the time was finite, constrained by a promise.

I eventually placed a firm hand on her waist. "It's time, darling," I murmured. I had given my word to her mother to deliver her home early, and a man like me never breaks a promise, especially one concerning the safe return of what's mine.

"I can't believe she looked at me," Evelyn sighed, her eyes wide as her fingers lightly brushed the fabric of my sleeve as we walked toward my car.

"Your gorgeousness lit up almost the whole concert, darling." My voice was low and warm as I gently took her hand in mine. My thumb tracing the curve of her knuckles.

"It wasn't her fault, she couldn't help but look. She was simply basking in the reflected light." I gave her hand a soft reassuring

squeeze.

“Yeah, right. She’s so beautiful isn’t she?” Evelyn mused, her head tilted slightly as her eyes briefly held mine, a touch of uncertainty there.

” She’s nice.” I conceded, my hand naturally rising to gently cup the side of her face, my thumb brushing her cheekbone;

“But nothing compares to your elegance.” I leaned in, pressing a tender kiss to her hair, inhaling the familiar scent.

Her eyes softened and a warm, genuine smile bloomed on her face. But the last of the uncertainty didn’t melt away as she might have thought I was complimenting her and only because I wanted to make her happy. But only if she could’ve seen her from my sight. She would have realized her beauty was capable of lighting up the whole world.

The concert high had long evaporated, replaced by the hushed solitude of the drive back. Eve was curled against me, her head resting on my shoulder, a weight of perfect contentment. She was a sleeping beauty, and I allowed myself a rare, purely appreciative moment. I loved that look on her, so innocent, so kind. It was a stark contrast to the burning desire she ignited in me when she was awake.

We finally reached her home, the silent street a perfect cloak for our late return. She was still dead to the world, a heavy, trusting weight in my arms. I didn’t wake her; the moment belonged to only us. A secret held close.

“Mrs. Jones, she fell asleep in the car. So, I kept her that way.” Hannah opened the door with a surprised gasp at the sight of her daughter nestled against my chest.

“That’s so sweet of you, thank you.” Her relief, a gentle pressure in the air.



I held her gaze, a small knowing smile touching my lips. “It was no trouble. After all, she’s mine.” The words a low possessive rasp. It was a claim, not a question and it hung in the air, leaving Hannah speechless. The shock faded, replaced by an unsettling, perhaps satisfied recognition of the truth.

I carried Evelyn through the quiet house, the scent of her hair a dizzying comfort. Laying her down felt like parting with a limb.

I leaned over her bed, my shadow falling over her face, and pressed a slow deliberate kiss to her forehead. My breath brushed her as I finally confessed the truth, I guarded like a weapon. But it was consuming me from inside little by little.

“I love you, Evelyn Jones, I can’t help but fall for you even more when I try not to. I’m a whole of a different person when I’m around you. But, one bitter truth and you’ll never look at me in the same way.

“I know. But, I’ve discovered I can’t live without you. Either It’s you or the hell I had been in before you.”

I stood there watching her breathe and memorizing the stillness of the room. I nodded briefly to Hannah on my way out. I didn’t let myself look back at her, I was afraid I wouldn’t be able to move from there.

Sitting in the backseat as Mark was driving, I pressed my thumb hard into the corner of my eye, stopping a single, unwanted tear before it could fall and betray the absolute hold she had on me.

I left her to sleep that had no idea of the depth of my obsession.

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## CHAPTER 10

### EVELYN

“Aden, can you pick me up for class before you head to the office? Edward’s gone, and Shayla was completely clueless,” I murmured into the phone, the words feeling fragile.

A low, resonant chuckle answered me. “Yeah. Just open the door, darling.”

My heart jumped. *He already knew. How does he always know?*

“Hey, you. How...how did you know I was even home?” though a thrill ran through the suspicion. He must have tracked my phone. That was so like him.

“I know everything about you, Eve,” he said, his voice dropping to a seductive rasp as he stepped across the threshold, filling the space with his presence. His eyes, dark and all-consuming, held mine. “Well, except for the bathroom breaks. And even that wouldn’t be a mystery if you just moved in with me.” A slow, predatory smile touched his lips, a promise and a threat entwined.

“Let’s go,” he stated, the command absolute. As we settled into the leather-scented quiet of the car, I let the question that had been haunting my sleep slip out. “I fell asleep so hard yesterday. So, who... who put me to bed?”

His hand, warm and heavy, found my thigh and gripped it; a claim, not a gentle touch. “Who do you think?” he breathed, his gaze unwavering as Mark started the engine. “I did.”

“Yeah,” I replied, a shiver chasing the heat of his touch. “Never had a doubt.”

The university entrance was a sudden, unwelcome rush of bright light and noise. Just as I stepped onto the curb, a cold, heavy hand clamped down on my shoulder from behind.

“Aden, uhm...” I began, my nerves already taut. I spun around, and my words died.

It wasn’t him. It was a stranger-tall, indistinct in the morning crowd, with eyes that seemed to rake over me without seeing. “Excuse me? Do I know you...?” I asked, a knot forming in my stomach.

His hand dropped instantly. “Nothing. Sorry,” he muttered, turning away and melting into the stream of students, vanishing before I could register his face.

## EVELYN

Aden was beside me a second later, his shadow falling over mine. “What happened?” he demanded, his voice a low, dangerous rumble, instantly shifting from controlled affection to sharp aggression.

“Nothing, there was this creepy guy,” I said, trying to shake off the unsettling touch. “He must have just mistaken me for someone else.”

Aden didn’t believe me. His jaw was clenched, and his dark eyes were already sweeping the crowd, searching, hunting. His focus was so absolute, so tense, that he didn’t even register that the man was long gone. I tried to distract him, launching into a nervous recap of the mundane details from the night before, but he was miles away, lost in some dark calculation.

“...Hello?” I finally stopped, waving a hand in front of his face.

“Are you even listening to me?”

He didn’t blink, dragging his attention back to me, but the tension didn’t ease. “Yeah, sorry. Listen to me, Eve.” He grasped my face between his hands, his touch possessive and urgent. “You go inside. You call me the second your classes end, understood?”

“Okay, but...”

“And please, don’t do otherwise. Do as you’re told.” It wasn’t a request; it was an order delivered with absolute finality. “Bye.”

He crushed his mouth onto mine in a demanding, breathless kiss that wiped away any protest. Then, he was gone, peeling away from the curb in a spray of gravel, leaving me standing there. He was always bossy, but this was different-it was the deep, frightening tension of a man who believed danger was closing in. I knew, he was terrified with the thought of anything disastrous even coming towards me.

## ADEN

“Luke, he fucking dared to reach for her. I’m going to make him bleed so much that he’d fucking beg.”

I stormed into the office, the rage a black tide that threatened to drown me. My hands were balled into fists, the knuckles aching with the restraint required not to shatter something. Luke looked up, his brow furrowed with familiar concern. “Easy, Ad. Breathe. Tell me everything, slowly.”

“She was right beside me, right there,” I spat, gesturing wildly. “And some ghost- some shadow of a man, crept up, presuming a vulnerability that wasn’t there. He reached for her, thinking she was alone, but then he must have seen me. That coward slipped away like a rat.”

Luke sighed, a heavy, frustrating sound. “That’s what I keep

telling you, buddy. If you want her safe, truly safe, you'd cut the anchor. You'd let her go."

I moved on him fast, bridging the distance until our noses were separated by a single, charged breath. My eyes were locked on his dark and promising violence. "Say that one more time, and I swear I will watch the light leave your eyes. Her safety isn't in the distance; it's in me." I backed away sharply, turning to stare out the window, the cityscape a blur of indifferent light.

"Ad, I know you're furious. I'll stand with you, whatever the consequence for whatever you choose. But you know, we both want what's best for her." Luke trailed off, sensing my shift in focus.

"I love her," I said, the words a rough, unexpected confession torn from my throat.

"What?" Luke asked, his voice cracking with shock.

"I said, I love Evelyn."

"How do you know?" he challenged, skeptical, "Love isn't a switch you just flip when you're cornered."

I turned, taking slow, deliberate steps toward him, the truth settling on me like a beautiful, terrifying weight. "I know, because the thought of losing her is a cold, crushing fist in my chest, a pang so violent it steals the air and makes me feel like my own heart is tearing free of my ribs. I know because when she smiles, it's not just a physical reaction; it's like the sun finally breaking through a century of storm clouds inside me. And I know," I paused, my voice dropping to a dangerous, low grate, "because the mere idea of another man's hand, even the air around his hand, touching her skin doesn't just anger me. It turns my blood to molten poison, and I don't just want to kill him, I want to strip

the world bare and burn it down so she's the only thing left standing."

The silence that followed was suffocating. "O-okay," Luke finally managed, swallowing hard. "You have a board meeting. It's waiting. We will...we will talk about the apocalypse after."

I didn't acknowledge him. The meeting was a hollow farce. I walked straight to the conference room, my mind a storm of devotion and destruction. The whole time, the cold terror of that near-touch and the fierce, consuming fire of my love for Evelyn eclipsed every chart, every projected number, every word spoken. She was all that mattered.

## ADEN

"What?" I barked through the phone, the word a gunshot, a vestige of the dark fervour that had consumed me during the meeting. I was still vibrating with the desire to find the man who had the audacity to touch her, who I knew was sent by Erling.

"Hey, it's me. My classes have ended," Evelyn murmured. Her voice, soft and bright, was an impossible intrusion of light into the dark, violent space my mind occupied.

"Hey. I thought it was someone from the meeting, sorry," I forced out, the apology thin and meaningless. The thought of the man who had dared touch her sent a renewed spike of adrenaline through my veins. "And yeah, I'm already on my way. Stay inside." The command was immediate, stripped of all politeness.

"Okay?" Her confusion was audible, a tiny, helpless sound that only fueled my need for absolute control.

"Are you alright, Aden? You seem a little... distant," Eve murmured, her hand reaching out but hesitating before it touched my arm as I met her outside the towering, gothic stone of

her college. The air was thick with the scent of damp leaves and unsaid things.

“Hey, Aden?” A voice, brittle and sharp, cut through the quiet. A girl I barely registered, was there, her eyes too wide, too knowing, fixed on me. She looked like a cheap ghost. “The name is Mr. Pattersen, and who the hell are you?” I demanded, my voice dropping, the name a cold shield. The sudden shift in my tone made Eve stiffen beside me.

“Yes,” she whispered, shrinking under my gaze. “I just...I wanted to talk to you about that night.”

A muscle twitched in my jaw. “Talk to me about what? I don’t know you.”

“I’m Cara, from the football match... remember?” she pleaded, taking a desperate step closer.

My eyes narrowed, a dark promise hardening them. The memory of that night, the reckless abandon, sleeping with a girl, the thrill was a poison kept carefully contained. “Get. Out. Of. Here. Now. Or this won’t just end badly for you. Go.” The threat was low, a velvet-wrapped steel blade. She fled, the sound of her frantic footsteps swallowed by the shadows.

I turned back to Evelyn. Her beautiful, intelligent

eyes were fixed on the vanishing girl, but not on me. A cold, quiet anger settled on her features, like the first frost of a long winter. The old football match, a casual night of chaos almost a year ago, felt like a lifetime, a thousand sins ago.

“Eve? You were saying,” I began, my voice deliberately softer, laced with the rough silk of an apology I wouldn’t speak. “No. I mean, yes, I’m alright. It was just... the meeting. It was intense. I just want you to be careful. That’s all. Nothing else.”

I reached for her then, pulling her against the expensive wool of my coat, burying my face in her hair. It was a possessive gesture, a claim. But she remained rigid against me, untouched by the sudden warmth.

“Okay,” she answered, the single word dryer than dust, a clear, sharp dismissal of my rushed explanation. She didn’t look at me as she walked toward the car waiting for us, carrying her silent resentment like a beautiful, fragile weapon.

She was clearly pissed about Cara, and about the darkness she glimpsed, the darkness that was me. And I knew, with a certainty that was both chilling and exhilarating, that I loved her anger, but I was afraid of this.

## ADEN

The air in the car was a suffocating blanket we both needed to shed. She didn’t speak a single word until her hand was on the door of the house, bathed in the sickly yellow of the security light.

“Eve.” The sound was a raw thread pulled from my chest.

She paused, turning back into the shadow, her eyes glittering with a dangerous, unspoken challenge. “Yes?”

I moved into her space, a deliberate invasion, my hands rising to anchor themselves around the sharp points of her jaw. “There is nothing but you. You are the fire and the fracture in my life.” I leaned in, my voice a grave promise meant only for her ears. “I made a bloodied mess of things, yes. But understand this; I’ve burnt every other bridge, watched them turn to ash. You are not a choice, Eve. You are my last compulsion, the only truth my bones still remember.”

I pressed my lips to hers, I kissed her softly, my eyes falling shut as our breaths tangled. Her hands rested over mine, warm



and trembling slightly as I cupped her cheeks, drawing her closer. The world went still, only the taste of her, the rhythm of her heart, and the seven endless seconds that felt like forever, “Gather what you need. Saturday, we’re leaving.”

A ghost of a smile touched her lips, a dangerous, knowing thing. “Too bossy, can’t.”

I smiled from the corner of my lips, “what am I gonna do with you, darling? So, if you’ll do me the honor of getting your things all packed up for Saturday, I’ll be blessed, darling.”

“You got it,” she scoffed. “You sound so funny.”

Her defiance had melted, replaced by a darker, more potent agreement. She wasn’t simply not pissed anymore; she was bound. I was happy.

I kissed her forehead and headed back.

The tension I felt was the fear of losing what is mine. But, one thing I had known was, anyone who touches her will find themselves up against a love that is less a feeling and more a predator’s instinct. I wouldn’t just kill them; I would ensure their very existence is erased for daring to cast a shadow on my sun.

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## CHAPTER 11

### EVELYN

“Hi, I’m Maddie,” she offered, her voice a little thin in the echoing space as we reached the tarmac. She was flying with us, following the shadow of Luke.

“Hey, I’m Evelyn. Cara’s friend, the cheerleader?” I asked, my voice cool and even.

“Yes,” she confirmed, fidgeting with the strap of her small bag.

“Yeah, I saw you cheerleading.” She took a careful half step forward, dropping her chin slightly. “Look, I know Cara can be rough, but she’s just trying to secure something for herself. Please don’t let it bother you.”

“No, it’s fine,” I replied, the dismissal sharp and final.

My own friends finally arrived. I moved instinctively to Ana’s side, my eyes locked on the strange boy accompanying shayla.

“Who is he?” I whispered, my gaze narrow. “I have no idea,” Ana hissed, her arms crossing tightly over her chest. “Maybe a hook up who wouldn’t leave? I don’t understand why she’d bring a stranger here.”

“Okay, let it be,” I murmured, the drama fading as a more significant tension took hold. I barely gave Ana a distracted wink. “She’s having fun.”

The jet’s powerful engines began to thrum beneath us. Then, the pilot’s voice cut through the sound: “...we’re expecting a smooth flight and anticipate an on-time arrival in Switzerland at 10:05 PM.”

My breath hitched. “We’re going to Switzerland? Oh my god!” The gasp was raw, and I spun to face Aden, my disbelief and utter joy undisguised. “This is amazing!”

He was already looking at me, his expression unreadable, yet utterly focused. He took one deliberate step closer, bridging the space between us until the heat radiating from his large frame was all I could sense. His hand rose slowly, not to touch, but to hover, the shadow of his fingers tracing the line of my jaw before falling away.

“I’m glad you like it,” Aden said, his voice a low vibration that seemed meant only for me. It was not a casual statement; it was the quiet, possessive fulfillment of a wish, a silent promise that the entire journey will be an extension of his will for my pleasure.

My friends were cheering wildly, a chorus of distant noise, but all I felt was the intense, magnetic pull of the man who had just delivered the world to my feet.

The sky was a canvas of impossible beauty, stretched out in vast, breathtaking swathes below us from thousands of feet in the air. I had left Aden alone in his seat, drawn by a magnetic pull toward Ana. She was across the aisle because Shayla was, quite scandalously, engrossed in a make-out session with that odd fellow. He felt oddly familiar, a shadow from a forgotten memory I couldn’t place. Aden had been clearly against his presence, but Shayla’s pleading had been persuasive enough for me to agree, which then swayed Aden.

“You’re welcome to join us,” I offered, noticing Maddie sitting by herself while Luke and Aden were talking nearby.

Her eyes lit up. “Really? I’d love that, thank you.”

“Don’t mention it. Come on over,” I encouraged.

The energy shifted instantly as Ana began to playfully antagonize Shayla, belting out songs and dramatically acting out the lyrics. “Say my name and everything just stops!” she sang loudly, her exaggerated, self-teasing movements sending us into fits of laughter.

“I genuinely think you’re a good person, Evelyn,” Maddie confided softly, her gaze earnest.

“Thank you, Maddie,” I replied, meeting her look.

“Guys, seriously, can you make her stop?” Shayla finally emerged, a flush of annoyance on her cheeks.

“Are you done puckering-mwah, mwah?” Ana teased, mimicking a kiss with her hand.

It was a joy to have everyone gathered. Maddie, I realized, wasn’t like Cara at all; she possessed a truly kind spirit. Every moment of that flight, suspended between the clouds and the world below, felt perfect.

The air shifted from the recycled atmosphere of the plane to the fresh, crisp scent of Europe as we disembarked in Zurich, Switzerland. It was the middle of June, marking the conclusion of the spring semester—a swift end that meant I’d soon have to pivot and prepare for my sophomore year.

It felt unbelievable that I had just spent nearly a full year in New York City. I vividly remember landing there in July, mere days after my birthday; time truly does accelerate with astonishing speed.

However, this was the quintessential moment to arrive in Zurich. The start of summer brings with it a delightful pattern of occasional, refreshing rain showers interwoven with brilliant, sun-drenched days, perfect for exploring the city’s pristine lakeshore and the stunning natural

landscapes surrounding it. I was filled with anticipation, eager to discover every part of it.

The exhaustion from the journey finally caught up with us that evening. After a much-needed meal, we collectively collapsed, surrendering to sleep. Only Ana was left to navigate the quiet hours of the night by herself.

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## CHAPTER 12

### ADEN

“Good morning, bird,” I murmured, watching Evelyn slowly stir back to consciousness. The nickname felt natural, capturing her lightness.

She pushed up against the pillows, her eyes still heavy with sleep. “Bird? where did that come from?”

“From a mile up, actually,” I quipped, trying to lighten the serious edge of the early morning. She scoffed a small, playful sound. “Very amusing. Why are you even awake? It’s practically still night for you on the weekends.”

“A few obligations. I had to clarify some details regarding their work,” I admitted, my voice dropping slightly. “More importantly, I was looking into Jake Halder.”

“Who?” she frowned, momentarily confused. “The one Shayla brought. The parasite I already told you I despise,” I clarified, the name leaving a bad taste.

“Oh, that guy. What about him?” she asked, a spark of wariness now in her eyes.

“Nothing yet,” I said, a dark certainty settling over me. “Just keep your distance. I don’t trust him, not one inch. And you will tell me immediately if you feel anything, anything at all, is wrong. Understand?”

She slid off the bed and onto my lap, a comforting weight, wrapping her arms around my neck. “Yes, I will. Don’t worry,” she promised, her voice a soft assurance against my ear.

“Trust me, if you had any idea, how hard that is,” I confessed, the underlying tension finally breaking as I kissed her—a deep, possessive kiss that was both a promise and a warning. “Alright. We’ll face the light after breakfast.”

“Yes,” she breathed, a genuine thrill in her voice. “I’m utterly excited for that.”

The expanse of Lake Zurich, the fifth largest jewel among the Swiss waters, was our dominion for the moment—a vast, shimmering canvas that offered not just beauty, but a raw, desperate kind of peace. Here, we could truly breathe, watching time itself slow down and dissolve around us.

“This is utterly exquisite,” Evelyn whispered, her gaze riveted by the view. In that instant, nothing else held substance. The rest of the world, the other people on the shore, were just vapor. She was the sole gravitational pull.

“The lake is merely the prelude,” I stated, my voice low and decisive. “Now, we claim the water. We will take the yacht.”

A hint of fear crossed her face. “But I can’t swim. A fall means I’d simply succumb.”

I pulled her closer, the sheer absurdity of her concern almost insulting. “Do you truly think I’d be here if I couldn’t command your safety? If I couldn’t haul you from the deepest dark? Furthermore, I will be navigating the vessel. I possess the required license to pilot this yacht, regardless of residence.” I emphasized the last word with a deliberate, dark wink, a silent boast of my ability to always control our circumstances.

She countered with a defiant eye-roll. “Naturally. I would be genuinely shocked if you didn’t possess every conceivable license known to man.”

“Be careful, darling,” I warned, my tone

shifting to a low, seductive threat as I helped her step onto the yacht. “Either you cease that insolence, or you will certainly regret it.” I guided her firmly to the top deck, settling her into the place of honor.

Evelyn gasped, truly seeing the panorama now. “God, it’s supernatural. It feels utterly divorced from the real world.” The vista was breathtaking: the historic, stoic skyline of Zurich, its ancient churches and rooftops, cradled by the formidable slopes of the Albis and Pfannenstiel, with the snow-crowned, distant majesty of the Glarner Alps serving as an elegant, silent sentry.

“Stop immortalizing me,” she commanded, noticing the device I held.

“Can’t help it,” I countered, my eyes lingering on her through the lens. “My view is infinitely superior to yours.” Yet, she was already lost-mesmerized, truly and beautifully delighted-and I let the camera drop, content to merely witness the genuine rapture on her face.

My whole day passed by with the sight of hers.

## EVELYN

“Today was... exhilarating. Marvelous,” Maddie breathed, her hand settling on my shoulder; a weight I felt deep in my chest. Her fingers, cool and possessive, lingered.

“I know,” I whispered, the word a husk in the velvet dark of the hotel hallway. “The Limmat. Seeing it flow...it felt like time itself was rushing past us, indifferent.” My own memory of the river, a dark, churning ribbon beneath the iron bridges, was less awesome and more ominous.

A sharp, almost predatory voice cut through the shared intimacy. “Hey, Evelyn.”



Jake stood with Shayla by their door, his eyes holding a calculated glint that made the air suddenly thin. “Hi?” I managed, greeting a brittle chip of ice.

From the oppressive silence behind me, a deep, resonant voice, the only one that ever truly mattered, stirred. Aden. He moved like a shadow detaching itself from the wall leaving Luke, an inert, forgotten detail behind.

“Is there something wrong, Eve?” His voice was a low, seductive rumble, laced with an unnerving intensity that promised both danger and salvation. He wasn’t asking; he was stating a fact, his gaze cutting past Maddie’s hand on my shoulder to bore directly into my soul.

I straightened, the phantom chill of the Lake Zurich breeze suddenly nothing compared to the chill he cast. My response was a lie, a protective reflex, but in the echoing hall, it sounded like a fateful decree.

“Yeah. It’s nothing.” I sounded like a fateful decree as my voice echoed in the hall.

The hotel room felt like a polished cage of apathy that morning. While the others scattered like bright, meaningless distractions, I stayed, anchored by a quiet, self-imposed isolation. When Aden returned, he brought with him a tide of dark, restless energy that demanded obedience.

“Get ready,” he commanded, his voice a low, gravelly current. It wasn’t an invitation; it was an ultimatum.

“Where are we going?” I asked, a sliver of defiance against the inevitable surrender.

His lips curved into that devastating, calculated smile, promising a secret as dangerous as it was intimate. “You’ll see it when we’re swallowed by it.”

The Uetliberg was a shocking, colossal wall of nature, its sheer scale humbling my recent anxieties. “God, the mountain,” I breathed, feeling exposed by the sheer, untamed expanse of green. “It’s magnificent. This... this feels like Covington, a familiar ache of home, except here, the air is thick with the pulse of the city, not the dead silence I remember.”

“Let’s climb the tower,” I decided, a sudden, desperate urge for a vantage point, a delusion of control.

Aden watched me, his gaze heavy, a shade of contempt flickering for the effort I was about to expend. “You’re sure? I could just carry you, if you’d rather save your strength.”

“What, no.” The refusal was sharp. “I have my own feet.” I started the torturous ascent, but the structure was a brutal, vertical gauntlet.

“I can’t. It’s too much,” I gasped, after a while, the protest barely made a sound before his hands were on me. He scooped me up with an unnerving, effortless power, a predator claiming his prize. I laughed, a sharp, genuine, reckless sound of delight and terror. “It’s not my fault if you faint from the exertion,” I teased, resting my head against the granite hardness of his chest.

“Worry less, darling,” he murmured, the vibration of his voice a promise of possession. “This weight is less than my usual burden.”

He carried me, a conquered artifact, to the very top.

“Proud of you, kid,” I said playfully, challenging him.

He arched an eyebrow almost as he wanted to eat me alive.

The panoramic view was a desolate masterpiece. Below us, Zurich was a scatter of shimmering lights and quiet lies, and the world felt contained, small. “The mountain looks better from up

here,” I said, my voice quiet against the wind. “Like we’ve finally escaped.”

“I knew you would love it. That’s why I brought you.” His words were a low, possessive hum. “I have no real interest in these monuments. My only anchors are my pool, my room, and the unobstructed sight of you.”

I offered him a wall of blankness, a carefully constructed lack of reaction. “Sit,” I commanded, gesturing to the cold, unforgiving stone.

“When are you going to finally tell me about your father?” Aden didn’t waste a breath, his tone instantly becoming a brutal, uncompromising instrument.

I drew a deep, cold breath, steeling myself. “Right after you tell me about your mother.”

He gave a dry, dismissive sound that was less a scoff and more a knife scraping stone. “There’s nothing for you to know about her.”

“Tell me,” I insisted, a dangerous thread of curiosity pulling me into his storm. “I demand to know.”

He shrugged, “She was the only person I ever truly permitted myself to love in this whole, corrupt world. She was the absolute architect-the one with the vision. She ran the empire with a terrifying, flawless grace, and we dominated the city.” The muscle in his jaw jumped, a tremor of suppressed violence, “she died the day our company was awarded the best and shot by another businessman who eventually wanted to snatch the company from her. All that I know is that he made some offer and she didn’t take it, so... yeah.”

A hollow, familiar ache settled in my own chest. “I’m sorry, Aden. You hate pity, I know, but that was a cruelty she didn’t

deserve, and a grief you shouldn't have carried."

He turned, and the blackness in his eyes was deeper than the night descending over the city. "You have no idea. what I deserve, Trust me, Evelyn. I am a monster more elaborate, more damaged, than you could ever begin to conceive!"

"Why?" I challenged, the question absurd yet necessary. "Did you kill someone?" I cracked the joke. "I'm sorry. Just kidding. Forget I said it," I whispered, but his face remained a mask of absolute, terrifying composure.

"Well?" he prompted, daring me to meet his truth with mine.

I took the dare. "I didn't lose him. I don't even know if he's alive." The truth was a shard of glass in my throat. "I was a child, by the river. He was there, then he took a call, a secret whisper and said he had to leave, that he'd be back 'soon.' I waited."

My eyes found the distant, coiling black ribbon of the Limmat river. "I waited until the light died. He never came back. Not for me. Not for my mother. I feel this furious, empty rage for a betrayal I didn't earn. And now, he never could come back, even if he wanted to. We burned our lives in England and fled to escape the fallout of his absence." I let out a sharp, final exhale. "It is what it is. A history carved in smoke."

I stood up, pulling myself from the heavy intimacy of the confession. "It's almost eight. Let's go back."

As we stepped back across the threshold of the hotel, leaving the summit's cold truths behind, Aden's voice was already asserting dominance.

"Do you want to go shopping?" he asked, the phrase itself sounding less like an offer and more like a necessary administrative detail.

“No. Why the sudden necessity?” I countered, already annoyed by the presumptive nature of his question.

“Tomorrow,” he stated simply, his finality absolute.

“I won’t go. I told you, I need nothing. I refuse to accumulate more possessions,” I insisted, drawing a line in the opulent carpet.

“We are going tomorrow morning,” he repeated, his eyes darkening. He didn’t raise his voice, yet the words were a chain snapping shut. I didn’t respond. My silence was the only weapon I had left.

He was stretched out on the vast bed, a figure of dangerous, sculpted repose, when I emerged from the bath. I stood before him, the distance a fragile shield.

“Come here,” he commanded, his voice a low, gravelly lure.

“Why? Do you suffer from the cold?” I asked, a sliver of teasing defiance thrown across the space.

“Yes. Perhaps I could utilize your presence for a little heat, Eve. Come on up.”

I succumbed, sinking into the curve of his body, my head resting in the dark, warm hollow beneath his shoulder.

“This is...essential,” he murmured, his breath stirring my hair.

“Do you ever contemplate the formality of marriage?” I asked, the question a sudden, jarring intrusion into our quiet. “You’re twenty-six. That’s an age where one is expected to be shackled.”

He tensed slightly beneath me, his hand moving over the column of my neck. “No. Marriage is a tedious structure. Furthermore, I have an absolute disdain for children. They are chaotic and complicate everything, and that covenant only increases the probability of their arrival. They are simply too much to control.”

“You are an impossibility,” I whispered, shaking my head against his chest. “Who could harbor a genuine dislike for children?”

“I do,” he confirmed, the statement final and devoid of regret.

“Very well. No marriage, then,” I sighed, letting the dream of a conventional future die a quick, quiet death.

Aden half-sat, leaning back against the cool leather of the headboard, pulling me securely against his chest so that I was nestled, watching the television.

“Do you have any capacity for something as saccharine as Twilight?” I asked, knowing the answer was already a brutal negative.

“No,” he instantly dismissed. “It was a foolish question. I’m utterly convinced you’ve never endured a single scene.”

“And you are entirely correct.” “Hence,” I announced, meeting his eyes with sudden, wicked resolve, “we are enduring the entire collection tonight.”

“Or,” he countered, his hand moving with a sinister grace, attempting to slip beneath the fabric of my nightdress, “we could engage in something infinitely more diverting.”

“Absolutely not,” I stated, catching his wrist, my grip surprisingly firm. “We are watching the movies, and that is the final decree. What I say, dictates.”

And we did. We were consumed by the melodramatic flicker of the screen until, hours later, I finally lost myself to sleep, utterly safe and strangely sheltered in the grasp of my beautiful, terrifying captor.

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## CHAPTER 13

### ADEN

The breakfast room was too bright, too loud, a jarring contrast to the silence in which I'd last held her. The pleasantries felt like a calculated offense.

"Guys, what is the grand agenda for today's motions?" Luke's girlfriend, a creature of unnecessary optimism, chimed, her voice sharp in the civilized dining hall.

"Address the architect of our fate," Luke drawled, a man resigned to the current power structure.

"No, seriously, what is the plan, huh?" Her eyes flickered to Evelyn, seeking an answer that only I could authorize.

"I told her," I stated, deliberately drawing the interaction back to the two of us. I carved a piece from my steak with cold, ruthless precision. "We are going shopping."

It was then that Eve, with an act of defiance masked as simple courtesy, shattered the tension I had cultivated. "So, you guys can accompany us, too. I mean only if you want."

The words tasted like ash in my mouth. My jaw locked. Of course I didn't want them. Every moment I was forced to share her, the focus of my obsession—was a direct, painful infringement on my right to her solitude. I watched the casual ease with which she offered up my time, a small, yet profound rebellion. But the

sentence was out, irreversible. I despised the interference; it was a poison in the precious, fragile construct we were building.

With a silent, furious command, I finished the last of my meal. The moment the plates were cleared, we rose. All of us were now bound for the mall, an entire morning of my claim sullied by the presence of others. The hunt had been made public. I simply hated all of them for that. But Evelyn wanted it. So, as she said, she dictates.

“I’ll anchor myself right here, my love. You are free to take everything you desire,” I told Evelyn, a possessive warmth in my voice as I released her into the bright expanse of the mall. “Just keep your precious self within the border of my sight, understood?”

Her friends trailed with her. Luke was somewhere else, occupied by that tiresome character, Jake. The arrangement suited me; I could never focus my own search with people cluttering my space. I prefer the clean, silent geometry of a solo hunt. I settled into a velvet chair, accepting the cool, iced glass the attendant silently offered.

“What do you think?” Eve emerged from the curtained recess, turning slowly to face the mirror.

I rose, my gaze locking onto her reflection. “It’s short, isn’t it? It barely kisses the curve of your bottom.”

She countered with a playful, low laugh, meeting my eyes in the glass. “No, it’s perfect. Perhaps, you’re just becoming boring, which is why you object.”

“I am absolutely fine with the dress,” I countered, the firmness returning to my voice as I stepped closer. “No one here is audacious enough to look at you, anyway. Besides, a hemline like



that simply makes it easier for me to reach inside when we are finally alone...”

Eve’s hand shot out, a silk-gloved shield over my mouth. “God, can you keep your voice down? They will hear you.”

I pulled her hand away, a slow, deliberate movement. “Do you think I care? And You should not have invited them.”

“Fine. I’m changing it. Now, you will be quiet,” she demanded, her eyes glittering with challenge.

“No. Don’t,” I said, my hand catching her arm gently but firmly. “Buy this one. Buy them all. You look magnificent in every single thing you wear, because you are mine.”

“Then enjoy waiting for me,” she whispered. She surged up onto her toes, wrapping one arm tightly around my neck, and the kiss, a fleeting, intense promise, wiped everything else away. She vanished back behind the curtain, leaving me with a faint, perfect ache.

“After lunch, we’re heading straight to the beach for something fun, since you seem to think I’m so boring,” announced as we stepped out of the mall, walking toward the car.

Evelyn’s head tilted, a playful challenge in her eyes. “Fun for you, or fun for me?”

I reached out, my fingers briefly tracing the curve of her jaw. “If you’re willing, we can certainly make it fun for both of us, darling.”

“No, thanks my perception of fun is entirely my own,” she affirmed, a triumphant smile blooming.

Later, in the quiet of the hotel room, I stood by the door, ready. “Ready to go?”

“Yesss!” she chirped, leaping up after retouching her lipgloss, her excitement contagious.

The air hung heavy with approaching evening when we arrived. “Wow, it’s so peaceful here,” she sighed, her shoulders relaxing as she took in the nearly deserted stretch of sand. “I love that there’s barely anyone else. Where’s the fun part, though?” she asked, turning her gaze back to me, an expectant curve to her lips.

Just then, she spotted two figures approaching, leading bicycles. Her eyes lit up. “Cycling! Now, that’s fun,” she exclaimed, her eyebrows arching high.

“Thank you, guys,” she called out to the men, genuinely enthusiastic. I, however, simply offered a curt, dismissing nod, a silent command that sent them on their way. She was sweet to everyone; I wasn’t.

We rode along the hard-packed sand, the air cool and quiet. We both savored the peaceful rhythm. Then, without warning, the sky broke. The rain began, heavy and sudden.

Evelyn laughed, immediately dropping her bike to the sand and turning her face up to the sky. I stopped, planting my feet on the ground as I leaned the bike on my hip. My gaze lowered, taking her in: her dress already clinging to her, her eyes closed in pure enjoyment.

“I know, I’m terrible at this,” I murmured, approaching her slowly, extending my hand, palm up. “But may I have this dance?”

She smoothed her damp dress down with one hand, her other meeting mine. Her grip was soft, her smile breathtaking. I closed the distance, gathering her close. I kept her weight balanced on my left forearm, guiding her small, bare feet onto the tops of my shoes.

A soft sigh escaped her lips as our chests

pressed together. I began to shift my weight, a tiny, slow motion that forced her to follow. I kept our movements minimal, just a slight rock and sway, until I abruptly transferred my hold to her waist and gave her a sudden, sweeping twirl.

She hadn't anticipated it. Her body arched back, and a laugh-full, loud, and utterly unrestrained, erupted from her. That sound swallowed everything else. Nothing in the world mattered more than the sight of her pure joy. I wanted forever, knowing even that wouldn't be enough. Her wet hair, her drenched smile, it was everything. It was her or nothing.

I pulled her back, smoothly catching her as she stumbled lightly, lowering her backward until she was resting against my supporting arm. Then, I sealed the moment, leaning down and kissing the love, the chaos, and the promise right out of her.

When she stood straight again, I immediately cupped her face, my thumbs grazing her cheekbones. Her hands rose, resting on top of mine, holding my gaze captive. Our foreheads gently touched, forehead to forehead.

"You're the only thing that matters to me," I confessed, the words rough with emotion. "You make me crazy and so nervous that it only makes me want you more. I truly don't know how to exist without you now, without making love to you, without the taste of yours. I'd basically live being dead. You're the brightest light in my darkest world. The dreamy gem I don't deserve, but I'm selfish enough to keep you for myself anyway. I had no heart and it's something I was proud of. But, then I grew one when you came into my life and trust me, it only beats with the thought of you being mine;being by myself from the beginning of forever. Cause, I'm entirely incapable of not spending each and every moment without you. Life without your moments equals ash. I

want the whole of you... I love you, Evelyn De Jones. I love you with every bit of me.”

She rose onto her toes, the gesture both delicate and urgent, and pressed her lips fiercely to mine. Our eyes were squeezed shut, not against the rain, but against the sheer force of the feeling, as if trying to hold the entire universe between our eyelids. In that space, there was only the fierce, wonderful reality of us. This was a depth of devotion I had never consciously sought, never planned for, and yet here it was, undeniable. I had never loved anyone-could never love anyone, the way I loved her.

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## CHAPTER 14

### EVELYN

In the brilliant flash of contact, a single, devastating truth settled over me: I loved Aden too.

The entire history of our journey, every shared glance and argument, surged forward, and the memories of Aden—my Aden—flooded my mind. I never expected this declaration. He had always claimed he wasn't made for love, that it was a vulnerability he feared. But here he was. Right now, he meant everything. I wished the rain-soaked world would simply freeze, that this moment could last forever. It was my entire world.

We finally broke apart, held hands, and headed back toward the hotel to prepare for the night's party. It was a gathering hosted by one of Aden's closest friends, Oliver Johnsson, a Swiss transplant. The next day, we were scheduled to visit Oliver's family; his mother, who adored Aden, had personally requested he come and introduce me. Oliver didn't live with his mom and stepfather. But he'll be there too.

"Hey, buddy!" Oliver roared, leaping onto Aden the moment we walked into the buzzing, crowded club. He paused his drinking, his attention immediately drawn to me.

"Who is the marvelous lady?" He pointed at me, then in a flash of exuberance, he spun me in a brief, dizzying twirl.

Aden's hand shot out like a whip, yanking Oliver back toward him. "Put my girlfriend down, or you won't be leaving this club tonight," Aden said, his voice flat, dangerously possessive.

“How do you deal with this man, Eve?” Oliver asked me, his expression a mix of awe and exasperation. I simply offered a shrug.

“It’s Evelyn!” Aden corrected firmly. “I’m Evelyn,” I confirmed, offering Oliver a smile.

“I’m Oliver Johnsson, and this guy here, is my best friend,” he announced, pointing at Aden, then punctuated the greeting with a kiss to the back of my hand. Aden visibly rolled his eyes.

“Let’s go inside, Eve,” Aden prompted, pulling me away from the commotion.

The music was loud, the room pulsing.

Shayla, Maddie, and Ana were already in the thick of the crowd, dancing. I joined them, watching as Aden, Luke, and Oliver immediately fell into conversation. Luke’s bizarre new friendship with Jake continued to develop—a strange sight, but one I was grateful for, as it kept them occupied.

“I simply can’t believe Aden’s your man now,” Ana murmured, leaning in close so her voice became a secret shared just above the pulsing bass. We were swaying in place, my hands lightly circling her neck, as Shayla and Maddie moved in their own orbit nearby. “We only ever gazed at him from afar, harboring that impossible desire all this time.”

“I adore him,” I breathed, letting my eyes soften as they found Aden across the room, feeling an anchor drop in my chest. “Truly, I do.”

Ana sighed, a low, gentle sound of pure contentment. “I’m genuinely thrilled for you, Eve. You know my love for you runs deep, right?”

I hugged her closer, a wave of warmth washing over me, my cheek briefly finding comfort against her shoulder as our slow,

intimate dance continued. “Yes. I cherish you both, too,” I whispered.

The moment was fractured by a sudden, joyful impact as Shayla and Maddie tumbled into us, embracing us from the side. “Hello! Did you two just forget the rest of the coven?” Shayla teased, a high, melodic laugh escaping her. We all dissolved into a symphony of giggles, holding onto one another. This was the quiet fulfillment I had always yearned for: friends I could wholly trust. They were the living definition of my chosen family.

We eventually drifted toward a quieter sanctuary, a low, cushioned banquette in a darkened alcove-settling in with our drinks. I sipped my soda, content to watch the others.

“So, Shay,” I began, shifting my body to give her my full attention. “The Jake dynamic? Where does that stand?”

She offered a nonchalant flick of her wrist, raising her glass to her lips for a deliberate sip before answering. “Excluding the occasional nocturnal visit? We maintain a very agreeable casual status.”

I tilted my head, pressing her gently. “Meaning he’s merely a pleasant diversion, nothing more?”

Shayla threw her hands up, her expression conveying a playful frustration as her eyes searched the crowded space, eventually landing on the focal point. “Yes! I mean, not everyone secures a treasure like you have. Honestly, just look at Aden. The moment he’s in view, the entire room just blurs into inconsequence.” She accentuated her point by rolling her eyes dramatically and sweeping her hand out, as if dismissing the rest of humanity.

I felt a familiar heat rise in my cheeks and lightly thumped her arm with my soda can.

Maddie leaned over, nodding sagely and wide-eyed. “Undeniably. I couldn’t agree with that sentiment more.”

“Alright, enough, you two,” I laughed, palms held out in a mock sign of surrender. “Stop staring a hole through my boyfriend.”

They both erupted into delighted laughter,

“Guys, come on, that’s our song!” Maddie declared, her excitement bubbling over as she practically yoked us from the quiet corner. She pulled everyone toward the dance floor, then made a beeline for the boys. She reached for Aden’s arm, but he flexed his hand away, a familiar, stubborn reluctance hardening his expression.

I leaned in swiftly, catching Maddie’s ear just as she was about to protest. “Don’t mind him,” I murmured, giving her a reassuring pat on the back. “He just doesn’t like this stuff. I’ll get him.”

Turning my focus to him, I grinned. “Come on, get up. We’re dancing now.” I wrapped my fingers around his forearm and gave a firm tug, pulling Aden out of the alcove and into the vibrant pulse of the crowd.

“Seriously, dance a little,” I challenged, meeting his gaze. “Look around, everyone is moving. Shake it off, or I’m going to go dance with Ana.” I pivoted, exaggerating my movement and sashaying a few steps toward my friend. Ana was singing the lyrics of The Weeknd song loudly and dramatically.

Just as I took another step away, Aden’s hand shot out. He pulled me back with a sudden, forceful twirl that left me breathless. I lost my balance for a heart stopping second and stumbled directly into his chest, my palms instinctively flattening



against the solid warmth beneath his shirt. His intense gaze immediately locked onto mine.

"You can't go anywhere until I tell you to," he stated, his voice a low rumble, the noise of the party suddenly fading around us.

He didn't just spin me back; he snatched me into the orbit of his body. Leaning in so close that the hot puff of his breath scorched my ear. "I only move like this in my bedroom," he ground out, the words a low, vibrating snarl against my skin. "Do you want me to take it there, darling?" His voice wasn't harsh; it was a firm, non-negotiable command.

A violent tremor of desire, not fear, rocked my core as his lips grazed my earlobe.

One hand clamped possessively on my hip; the other burned a brand into my ribs. My voice was a useless, choke-off sound. "Yes." The single word was a humiliating confession of how completely, desperately, I craved his power.

He didn't pull me; he dragged me from the pulsing crowd, shoving me backward into the cold steel of the waiting elevator. A ragged gasp tore from my throat. Before I could process the sudden drop in temperature, his large hands caged my wrists above my head. His grip was iron-firm, pinning me in an excruciating arch

His kiss was not just a kiss; it was an attack, deep, devastating and savage.

His tongue ruthlessly collided with mine, a desperate breathless duel for air. I was drowning, my lungs screaming for a fraction of a breath he wouldn't grant. Slowly, deliberately, the hand at my waist abandoned its post, fingers sliding downward and then inside with agonizing intent. A raw, choked moan clawed its way out of my throat, louder than I intended, "Aden."

He paused, his chest heaving against mine, eyes dark with effort, and didn't release my wrists. Before, I could form a reply, he followed it with a lethal whisper:

"If you don't want the whole building to know what we're doing, stop screaming my name, darling."

Then he plunged back in, driving the moment forward until the gentle chime announced the arrival of the next floor.

A man stepped in, and the atmosphere instantly solidified into thick, knowing silence.

The man didn't need to look at my wildly disordered hair or my desperate gasping chest to know exactly what had been happening.

Aden didn't seem to stop. He merely shifted his focus, his mouth leaving mine to brutally claim the exposed skin of my neck, right behind the unwitting witness.

I bit down hard on the inside of my cheek, straining every muscle in my body to strangle the sound trapped in my throat.

God, I didn't just love his touch; it was a fatal addiction. The pleasure was so deadly, so consuming.

I felt my pupils vanish into the back of my skull, leaving nothing but a helpless exposed expanse of white.

He finally pulled away, a triumphant predator, just as the doors slid open on the ground floor.

But nothing could have stopped him. Not the sudden intrusion of a stranger, not the harsh glare of the fluorescent lights and certainly not the remnants of my own fading resistance. I didn't just know this; I shamelessly yearned for it. I wanted him to be the force that broke my control, the intensity that burned away all my carefully constructed barriers.

He marched me into the shadows of the parking lot. His hand, a familiar, possessive weight, never left the curve of my spine, pushing me forward.

A silent declaration that I was his possession for the next few devastating hours.

The knowledge of my desire was a sharp, sweet agony in my chest. He wasn't just my boyfriend; he was my gilded cage, my most dangerous obsession. Every frantic beat of my heart was a prayer that he would never release me. I didn't only just trust him; I had laid my entire emotional world at his feet. His arms were the only safe harbor I knew; a dark, tempestuous solace where logic ceased to exist.

This was the terrifying, exquisite pact I had made, if he were the one to shatter my belief in love, then I was willingly ruined. If this beautiful, brutal man became my undoing, I would consider the destruction worth the price. I was willing to sacrifice, walking into the dark, magnetized by the promise of the ruin only he could deliver.

In the cool, echoing silence of the concrete basement. I stopped fighting his push and leaned back completely, melting against the hard lines of his body. It was a wordless invitation, a final, total surrender.

*Take me. My body screamed silently,  
Break me here and make me whole again.*

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## CHAPTER 15

### ADEN

“Hey, Evelyn!” Oliver called out, bounding toward us. With a swift, exuberant twirl, he lifted Evelyn into the air.

“Hii! Put me down, put me down!” Evelyn cried out, her surprise melting into a delightful, ringing laugh.

“Hey, buddy,” Oliver said, finally putting her down and turning to greet me. I threw my arms around him in a tight hug; more of a punishment for he knew what, nearly choking the life out of him. He coughed, and I immediately released him.

“Hi, Ollie,” I said, a little sheepishly. He shot me a playful, sidelong glance—a reminder of my near-lethal embrace-before turning back to Eve. “Let’s head inside, sister-in-law.”

“My word, she’s a goddess!” Kira exclaimed, rushing over to embrace Eve.

“It’s very nice to see you too, Mrs. Johnsson,” Evelyn replied, offering a radiant, warm smile.

Kira then turned and pulled me into a hug. “Oh, honey, it’s been ages since you last visited!” she declared.

“I was here last year, Kira,” I corrected her gently.

“Hush,” she dismissed me, her gaze fixed on Eve. “Just look at her! She is so beautiful.”

“How come Mom gets a hug for saying that, and I almost get killed for saying the exact same thing?” Oliver grumbled, and the entire group erupted into laughter.

“Everyone, take a seat! It’s time for lunch,” Kira announced.

I gently placed a hand on the small of Evelyn’s back and guided her toward the living room to find a comfortable spot.

We settled around the table, the rhythmic clink of cutlery against porcelain accompanying the start of the meal. Kira, fork poised mid-air, leaned slightly across the centerpiece, her gaze warm and direct as she addressed Evelyn.

“Evelyn, honey,” she asked, a gentle smile tracing her lips, “what are you studying?”

Eve took a moment, carefully chewing a bite of salad before responding. She dabbed her mouth with a napkin—a picture of composure—and met Kira’s eyes.

“I just finished my freshman year of college,” Evelyn replied, her voice soft but steady. “After this vacation, I’ll be diving into the preparation for my sophomore year. I’m aiming to complete some coursework early, well before the whole semester concludes.”

I moved my hand to her thigh, giving her a little peace. She sighed. I playfully smiled from the corner of my lips, only visible for her.

Across the table, Luke speared a piece of roast potato with almost surgical precision. He paused, lifting a skeptical eyebrow as he chewed slowly, a wry smirk spreading across his face.

“Well, well,” he drawled, pushing a small, half-full glass of water aside to make room for his elbow. “Look who we have here. Some serious academics at the table after Aden.”

Evelyn left out an uncomfortable laugh.

## EVELYN

The pleasant atmosphere at the table began to thin. I paused,

tilting my head slightly as I formulated the question that had been on my mind. “Where’s your husband?”

Kira set her wine glass down with a negligible thud-a sound that seemed overloud in the dining room. She offered a quick, practiced explanation. “Uhm, he said he’s eating out with his colleagues,” she answered, her voice maybe a touch too bright. “But he swore he’ll be back soon to meet you guys.”

The effect of her words was immediate and palpable. Luke and Aden seemed to instantly recede from the conversation. Luke, who had been leaning back in his chair, suddenly sat bolt upright, his shoulders tense. He picked up his knife and began methodically slicing his chicken into uniform, tiny pieces, his eyes rigidly focused on the plate. Aden’s gaze low and fixed on the rim of his plate.

The silence that followed was heavy, broken only by the clatter of silverware and the sound of chewing.

It felt entirely wrong. And then there was Kira. As she met my eye, she gave me a dry, fixed smile—one that didn’t reach her eyes and felt more like a porcelain mask than a genuine expression.

It’s probably nothing, I told myself, trying to dismiss the knot tightening in my stomach. Yet, the energy in the room was irrevocably altered. They were stiff, withdrawn, and different. We finished the rest of the meal in this subdued state, the sweet course of dessert doing little to lift the suddenly oppressive mood. Once the plates were cleared, we gratefully retreated to the living room, seeking refuge in the softer chairs and the hope of an easier rest.

A sudden jolt broke the subdued quiet of the living room—the sharp, insistent ring of the doorbell Kira immediately rose, the fabric of her dress rustling as she hurried toward the foyer.

“Hi, honey, you’re back,” we heard her coo, her voice resuming its earlier, overly bright warmth. “Yes, they are here.”

Though her husband’s muffled response was indistinguishable, Kira’s words were crystal clear, setting my pulse racing with anticipation. I was genuinely excited to finally meet the man.

A moment later, the man stepped into the living room, Kira’s hand lightly resting on his back.

I couldn’t breathe. Every thought, every quiet assumption I’d made about this trip, shattered instantly. My heart seemed to seize in my chest, a frantic bird battering against my ribs. I was instantly frozen, time congealing around me as he embraced Luke, then shook hands with Aden. But in every deliberate motion, his gaze was magnetically fixed on mine, and mine, in devastating recognition, was locked on his.

It was shocking and heartbreaking, yet, tragically, it wasn’t impossible. A single, scorching track of a dry tear escaped my left eye.

“Excuse me,” I choked out, using the hasty motion of wiping my face to finally break the paralysis. The moment I felt strength return to my legs, I bolted from the house.

I heard the frantic scraping of a chair behind me. “Eve, wait! Listen to me!” Aden’s voice was a desperate shout, but I didn’t slow. I was moving too quickly, propelled by pure adrenaline and shock. The air outside was raw and chilly, the usual evening rain having left the pavements slick. Goosebumps erupted across my skin, and I shivered violently as I hurried down the street.

Aden’s speed surpassed mine in only a few strides. He reached me and grabbed my arm, his fingers closing tightly above my elbow. “Listen to me, Eve!”

I whipped around. “You knew!” I sobbed, the accusation tearing out of me. “You knew this whole time!”

His head bowed, his eyes fixed on the wet concrete. He offered no defense, only silence.

I wrenched my arm, desperate to break free,

but his grip was iron. “Let me go, Aden!” I screamed, the hysteria rising. “Fuck, let go of me!” I struck his chest and shoulder repeatedly, frantic, useless blows against his solid frame.

“No, I’m not letting you,” he insisted, tightening his hold. I kept thrashing, “Are you done?” he growled. “We’re going back to the hotel. We’ll talk about this there, okay?”

“There’s nothing to talk about! Just let me fucking go!” I thrashed harder, but he was immovable. In one swift motion, he crushed me against his chest, his arm pinning me in a tight embrace across my shoulders. My own hands dropped uselessly to my sides, my resistance instantly quelled by the sheer force of his hold.

He steered me steadily back towards the car. Back at the hotel, the moment his grip slackened, I sprinted for the elevator, reaching the room and slamming the door shut before he could follow.

I curled by the window, my back pressed against the cool pane, drawing my legs up to my chest. My arms wrapped tightly around my knees, and I buried my face, the position a desperate attempt to become small and invisible. Tears spilled silently and incessantly onto my denim, a steady, soundless deluge of grief.

The door clicked open, and Aden slipped inside. He came toward me slowly, then gently pulled me upright, enveloping me in a tight embrace. The dam of control I’d held since leaving the



dining room burst. I couldn't stop it; I cried my heart out, deep, shuddering sobs that shook my entire frame.

"He abandoned us," I choked out, my voice thick with betrayal as I pressed my face into the soft fabric of his shirt. "I forgot years ago what a father looks like, and he was happy here with his family! But what did I do? What was my fault? I was still a child. He never loved me."

"Shh," Aden murmured, rubbing my back firmly. "It's alright. You know we only went there because he wanted to see you."

I pulled myself forcefully out of his arms, anger instantly eclipsing the sorrow. "No," I spat, wiping my wrist across my tear-streaked face. "He doesn't get to do that now! He wasn't there when I needed him the most. He was gone for almost ten years. Long gone. Why would I want him now, just to break my trust again?" I stabbed the air with my index finger, my eyes burning. "I was a mistake for him, so he left me. I'm not needed, and neither do I want to be."

Aden took a hesitant step toward me. "Eve—"

I cut him off, staring directly at him. "I want to go back to New York. As soon as possible."

He paused, registering the cold finality in my demand. "Yeah. Sure. As you want."

## ADEN

Her eyes were swollen and bloodshot, staring at me with a raw intensity. I had never seen such pure, contained anger radiating from her, and it hit me with a physical force. Seeing her pain—that devastated, betrayed look—hurt me deeply. I knew she hadn't deserved any of this; in that moment, I honestly wanted to kill her father.

But I couldn't. I knew the truth: underneath the rage, she still loved him more than anything. The betrayal was painful because of that enduring love, and I wouldn't take the choice of that relationship away from her.

I anyway had enough dark truths; if only she knew, she would never look at me in the same way she did.

But, seeing her hurt, I didn't want to care why her father did so. My blood boiled. I wanted to take his heart out of his body.

But I couldn't; knowing it would only make it worse.

The next morning, the room was quiet save for the persistent drum of rain outside. I was settled on the couch, finishing up some official work, when Evelyn shifted on the bed.

"Hey, you're up," I said, turning to face her. Her expression remained blank, guarded.

I forced a gentle, careful tone. "So, uhm...We can't leave for a few days because of the rain. I don't want to risk the trip." I gave her the control she desperately needed. "You can just stay inside the hotel room and not go anywhere;it's totally up to you."

She didn't react, didn't even flinch. She simply whispered, "Okay."

We were stuck there for what felt like an eternity, the silence in our room thicker than the clouds outside.

Finally, the weather broke, and we headed back to New York.

During the entire journey, Evelyn didn't

exchange a single word with anyone else. With me, she only spoke the bare necessities; a quiet request for water, a confirmation of the travel time. Her silence was louder than any outburst. I could clearly see the pain had settled deep within her, turning her into a remote shell of herself.

But I wouldn't leave her there. I was going to fix this, or at least help her heal from it. I knew I would.

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## CHAPTER 16

### ADEN

“Anybody home? Mom?” Evelyn called out, the sound of her backpack hitting the floor echoing slightly in the foyer.

A sudden, sharp “Happy birthday!” exploded from the living room. Her friends and family surged forward, a bright, chaotic wave of smiles and noise. I stood back slightly, my arms crossed—that kind of loud enthusiasm didn’t suit me.

Evelyn’s hand flew to her chest, her eyes wide. “Oh, my!” she gasped, a genuine startled look on her face. “You guys scared me!” Everyone descended on her, a flurry of hugs and excited chatter.

But even through the laughter, I caught the subtle stiffness in her shoulders. Her smile, though wide, didn’t quite reach her eyes after the initial shock wore off.

I moved through the crowd until I was close to her, waiting for a small opening. I caught her gaze, and she softened immediately.

“Happy birthday, love” I murmured, pulling her in and kissing her forehead just where her hair met her skin.

She sighed into my shoulder. “Thank you, Aden. You shouldn’t have done all this.” She pulled back a little, her fingers finding and fiddling with the silver chain around her neck. “I don’t feel like celebrating. It’s like all other days, except for the tag that I was born today, so blowing candles is a must.” Her voice was low, flat.

“Come here,” I said. I gently turned her and held her against my chest. I started brushing my hand around the nape of her

neck, slowly, rhythmically, and rested my lips lightly on her hair. I didn't like this quiet despair in her. She wasn't like me; I never craved love other than hers-it was all bullshit to me. But she needed it more than anything, specifically, she needed her dad's. She was way too delicate to hate someone. She was fragile.

"It's alright. You've got me, no matter what." I muffled against her hair.

She stood silent, knowing I'd never leave her. With almost all the faith she could ever have in anyone.

I was terrified of the day, when she'd know what I'd done before. I wouldn't even be able to meet her gaze, with the heavy truth, that she wouldn't even look at me with her grey, big eyes.

I loved her eyes the most, when the sun hit them and she looked at me raising her gaze.

She was the dream, I couldn't afford to turn into reality. But I was hoggish enough to not let her go; letting another man even look at her with the intention of kissing her, loving her, making love to her, having sex with her or even having her babies.

*Oh, god. What would I do to that guy? He'd be broken into so many pieces that the pieces of him would never be able to gather up back again.*

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## CHAPTER 17

### EVELYN

The silence here was a cruel imitation of home. I only ever sought out places like this, the deceptive calmness of the river, the water's gentle movement, the cool, woodsy breeze-because they were ghosts of the English countryside I'd gone with my father... I came here often; this place was almost an identical twin to the spot we'd visited years ago.

*What was that sound?*

A sudden rustle in the undergrowth-sharp, unnatural-shattered the peace. My heart slammed against my ribs.

*Please, let it not be something with teeth.*

I launched myself off the riverbank's low wooden board. My eyes darted around, my hand instinctively closing around a thick, broken stick, its end heavy and rough. I moved, not toward the river's safety, but toward the noise in the shadows of the forest stick, raising my stance rigid and low.

"Jesus Christ, were you going to execute me with that?"

The voice was rough, familiar, and utterly paralyzing. I swung the stick;a blur of desperate motion-but froze inches from impact, the sound of his voice anchoring me to the earth. The stick clattered instantly to the damp soil. I

stared, my chest heaving, unable to form a word. He stood there, older, lines etched deep around his eyes, but undeniably him.

“Mind saying hi to your old man?” Derek said, his hands raised in a gesture of weary surrender.

A primal instinct took over. I didn’t speak; I simply spun on my heel, my muscles screaming for escape, intent only on putting the entire forest between us.

“Bean, please, let me explain!” His voice was a raw plea.

A vice, like a grip clamped down on my wrist.

I stopped, yanked back, and slowly turned. The rage hit me like a physical wave, leaving my vision blurred. My eyes felt hot, reddened with immediate fury.

“No,” I hissed, yanking my arm hard. “There is nothing to explain. Frankly, I don’t even want you here. What are you doing here? My father died ten years ago. I survived, and I will continue to.”

The jerk freed my wrist; a traitorous tear escaped my eye and tracked a hot path down my cheek.

“I’m sorry,” he whispered, his own shoulders slumping, his gaze holding such profound, genuine remorse that I knew he meant it.

I gave a harsh, dismissive scoff. “Sorry? That’s something truly powerful, isn’t it? A single word that fixes a decade of silence.”

“Give me another chance, Bean. I promise, if I mess it up this time, you can do anything you want.”

“Do you think this is a game? huh? You lose and try again?” I snapped, my voice shredding on the last few words. “You abandoned me when I needed you the most, Mr. Derek Jones. You left me when I was a child.” I furiously wiped my cheeks with the back of my hand, a gesture of sheer defiance against the tears.

Then, I turned and walked; no, marched away. He didn’t try to stop me again. He knew I was a landmine, not ready for

proximity. But with every agonizing step, I felt the internal, hollow ache: I wanted to run back. I wanted a hero father, like the other girls had. Instead, I walked away from a man I hadn't even known was alive or dead for half my life.

I'd been devastated. The angry nine-year-old child had risen up in me again.

A girl who sought nothing but love from her father. But, she wasn't born that lucky to embrace father's love.

But, I didn't come out of that nightmare to have it back when I grew up. What if he left again and tore me down in pieces again?

### EVELYN

I finally let myself come back to it—I resurrected my music classes. It had severed that vital connection the moment college began, convinced that practicality demanded silence. But the truth is, I haven't just loved music; I've needed it.

It's not just a hobby; it is my sanctuary, the only place where the world's chaos dissolves. The very act of striking the guitar string sends a shockwave of pure, restorative peace through my body. The deep, vibrating thrum, the rhythm, is a physical sensation, a current that runs straight to my core. It's the most exquisitely perfect sound to ever hit my ear.

When the silence of my own thoughts became too loud, when the weight of the day threatened to crush me, I didn't just sing, I unburdened myself into the notes. My voice became the raw conduit for everything I couldn't articulate. It's a primal, desperate act of emotional alchemization. I poured my sorrow, my frustration, and my desperate hope into the melody, and it never failed. It didn't just work; it saved me. It is the one infallible system for survival I possessed.



“Evelyn, honey?” Celine placed a hand on my shoulder as I seemed absent-minded.

“Yes, Ms. Arthur,” I said, startled.

“You seem a little off. Focus honey,” Celine said. “Yeah,” I said.

She was my music teacher at the Royal Academy. Tall but sleek with natural curly hair. She was the sweetest soul.

When I looked at, I used to see a whole of her, filled with music. She felt music and flowed it to us. She was a total master. I loved her voice.

She had everything a singer needed.

And I wanted to be like her.

## ADEN

“...that should be done by today.” Luke’s voice, tight with stress, snapped through the closed office door. The frantic energy was familiar; the chaos had only deepened. “Arrange the conference call that was due, as soon as possible, Mr. Pattersen leaves in one hour.”

A brief pause, then Luke’s tone shifted, smooth and familiar. “Hey, bud! Yeah, he’s in his office.”

I heard the murmur of a familiar voice. “May I come in, boss?” The question was playfully challenging, muffled by the heavy mahogany.

“Come on in, Ollie,” I replied, recognizing Oliver’s swaggering tone instantly.

Oliver sauntered in, not walking, but gliding. He didn’t just sit; he slumped into my guest chair and immediately began twirling slowly back and forth, a picture of unnerving nonchalance.

“God, I missed you,” Oliver drawled, his eyes sweeping over my desk. “Given the explosive circumstances you detonated when you

left Switzerland.”

I leaned back, steeped my fingers beneath my chin, and let my gaze bore into him. “So, what catastrophe do I owe the city’s premier womanizer for this sudden visit?” I countered, the sarcasm thick.

Oliver stopped twirling, his expression becoming deceptively serious. “Funny. But I have updates on Erling.” He reached into his inner jacket pocket and casually tossed a sealed envelope onto my desk. “Seems he’s facing a corporate coup. He’ll have to return to the country soon, or lose the company’s vital foothold. Maybe not immediately, but the timeline is closing.”

Oliver was a private investigator, a mastermind of shadow and deceit, brilliant at excavating buried truths. But his news only confirmed what I already knew. I was ready. I was simply waiting for the perfect, surgical moment to execute my vengeance to rip his heart out in the exact same spot where he committed his worst sin.

I picked up the envelope, but didn’t open it. I cocked an eyebrow, letting the silence stretch, heavy and judgmental. “Okay. But that’s not why you’re here. Cut the performance.”

Oliver shrugged expansively, his hands flying up in mock innocence. “Well, yeah, I just genuinely wanted to visit you all.” He was a terrible liar.

I slammed the envelope back down, the sound sharp and final. I leaned forward, my face inches from his, my teeth grinding together so tightly my jaw ached. “Stop the nonsense, or I’ll gut you right here.”

“Calm down,” Oliver said softly, a flicker of genuine caution in his eyes.

I didn't back down. I delivered the accusation like a stiletto thrust. "It's about Ana, isn't it? You motherfucker liked her?"

Oliver's composure finally fractured. He shifted uncomfortably in the chair, a slight, guilt-ridden twitch in his lip. "Okay, fine. It's not that obvious."

"I know you, jerk. That girl is Eve's best friend. So for once, I care about someone else's stability. Be careful."

I looked at him, knowing his predatory pattern: he didn't keep a woman longer than twenty-four hours, max. He'd consume them, then toss them aside, only granting a repeat performance to those who truly impressed him in the bedroom. Ana didn't deserve to be another one of his fleeting conquests. Though that wouldn't have mattered to me. But it was about Evelyn. She would be hurt if anything wrong had happened to her best friend.

"I'm not that bad of a man," He arched his eyebrows. "Trust me, I know you more than you do. So, cut the bullshit. I'll kill you if Eve gets hurt for whatever you do." I threatened him though I knew he cared for her. Just not as my girlfriend, but as his half sister as well. I didn't like it though, it was what it was. Evelyn was mine anyways.

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## CHAPTER 18

### EVELYN

A clipped "...she'll be down any minute" sliced through the air as I descended the stairs. Hannah, a strange calm radiating off her, stood unnervingly close to Derek. "Hey, honey," she chirped, a hand settling lightly on his arm. Ten years. Ten years since his betrayal had scorched their lives, yet here they were, a portrait of strained domesticity. I couldn't fathom her placid absolution.

"Hey, I'm heading out. Meeting up with my friends," I announced, my gaze fixed pointedly above his head, ensuring my father registered his utter inconsequence to my immediate plans.

My mother's composure dissolved. "Absolutely not. You're going out with your father," she decreed, the command of an iron rod. She pivoted, a dismissive flick of her wrist. "Besides, I have a date, so I will be home late." She moved with brisk efficiency from the kitchen, ascending the stairs. I knew it was a lie. Because she saw the guy out of the country. So, she couldn't have a date.

I tracked her retreating figure, a knot tightening in my chest. "Mom?" I called out, a desperate plea.

"No excuse. Go have fun. I love you," she flung back, her voice echoing from the upper landing, her stride unbroken, never once looking back.

A guttural sound, "Aghh," tore from my throat, a frustrated growl.

We sat across from each other in the restaurant booth, the checkered tablecloth a battlefield. His voice, warm and familiar,

cut through my resentment. “Bean, what do you want?”

I was about to utter the sacred words-BBQ ribs-when he preempted me, his order was a swift, arrogant display of intimacy. “One full rack of baby back BBQ ribs, mac and cheese for two. I’ll have the red wine, and she’d like a soda, please.” He leaned back, a smug satisfaction creasing his eyes. “Do you need anything else, Bean?”

“No,” I spat out, my tone a sheet of ice. He knew me. That was the sickening, infuriating thing. He knew my soul-deep craving for those ribs. My hands were clenched beneath the table, my palms prickling with a desperate, incendiary rage. He was attempting a grand, belated performance of the father I’d been starved of for a decade. And my mother? She was unmoored from the past, sailing toward her own happiness. *They were both fine. They were both happy.*

He shifted, his hands resting on the edge of the table, a slight forward lean. “I know what you’re thinking. And you have every right to be this furious. But let me explain. I know I catastrophically failed back then. But I am here now, relentlessly trying to salvage this.” He spoke as we attacked our food, the mac and cheese a creamy, mocking comfort.

“Oh, do tell. Explain away.” I scoffed, my eyes glued to the plate, refusing to meet his earnest gaze.

“You knew I took those business trips to Switzerland. That’s where I met Kira. And... we fell in love, we had something I didn’t have with your mother. Things weren’t well that time with your mother,” he confessed, the words soft, almost reverent.

I recoiled, a harsh, dismissive sound escaping my lips. “Wow, fell in love while married to Mom. How charming. Continue.”

His shoulders slumped slightly. "I know. It was a monumental error. But I eventually told your mother. She said it would be cleaner, better, for us to sever ties completely. She insisted I leave. And I knew...if I were her, I would have demanded the exact same expulsion."

"Your pathetic love saga? I grasp it," I sneered, pushing my plate away. "But us? What was our crime? Why did we deserve to be abandoned without a single, truthful word? You vanished. For years, you were a ghost. Now, suddenly, you're trying to embody everything I ever desperately needed. Why?" My voice was no longer high; it was a tight, controlled hiss of accusation.

He dropped his fork, a sharp clatter against the ceramic plate. He sat back, his chest expanding with a ragged breath. "Go ahead. Yell, hit me, whatever you need. But I swear, I have always loved you both, Bean."

"No," I countered, the word sharp as glass. "You clearly haven't. I loved you, yes, beyond measure. And you forfeited that. I was an inconvenience to your grand, new life, so you discarded me. But she kept me. She fought for me. You didn't lift a finger. She worked day and night."

He reached across the table, his fingers tentatively brushing the back of my hand. "I'm sorry. But I am pleading for one final opportunity. Please, Bean."

I didn't utter a word. I couldn't. A sickening, unavoidable truth wormed its way into my soul: I still craved his presence. But trust? It was shattered. Yet, I knew, with a fatalistic certainty, that I was already capitulating.

He drove me home. We paused at the curb. He turned in his seat, his arms opening in a hesitant, pleading gesture. "Can I have a hug?"

My entire being ached for that embrace. I wanted to cling to him, to crush him in a fierce, reparative hold for every lost year.

But I held fast. My eyes met his for a long, devastating moment, then I wrenched my gaze away, turned my back, and marched inside, leaving him suspended, his arms still aching for an acknowledgment I couldn't grant.

## ADEN

I leaned back against the worn leather of the booth, the amber liquor in my glass catching the dim bar light. "I heard Mr. Jones is in New York," I stated, letting the name hang in the smoky air. "Is Kira here too?"

Oliver, unperturbed, took a deliberate swallow of his drink. He settled his glass back onto the coaster with a soft thud. "No, Mom's still in Switzerland," he replied, his shoulders relaxing slightly. "Look, I'm genuinely relieved he's back. Evelyn deserves this happiness, and frankly, she needs her father. He's a decent man, underneath everything. Everyone stumbles, Aden," he offered a small, forgiving shrug.

"Yeah," I countered, holding his gaze with a steady, unflinching intensity. "Some people's stumbles just happen to become endless avalanches."

Oliver paused, then threw his head back, a sharp, genuine laugh exploding from him. He turned back to me, his eyes wide and glinting with instant comprehension. "You're smitten, man!" he exclaimed, practically vibrating with excitement. He jabbed a finger toward my face.

I didn't flinch. I kept my posture rigid, my eyes deliberately fixed on the condensation tracing down my glass, avoiding his searching gaze. "I love her in a way that eclipses everything. I

never loved anyone like this, not even myself. I used to be a fortress of self-absorption. But now, she's the crucial synapse in my life; I can't draw a single breath without her existence perforating my mind." The words were an involuntary confession, dredged up from a place I usually kept locked tight.

I shifted, leaning an elbow on the bar, my voice dropping to a harsh whisper. "I detest this desperate craving I have for her, but then again, she taught me how to truly exist. I was a stranger to joy. Now, I find myself with a surreptitious smile plastered across my face whenever she's near."

Oliver sighed, a soft, audible release of breath, and leaned back, his eyes misting with sentiment. "God, I live for this kind of love. I love love, man."

"Yeah, you sound utterly mawkish. Shut up," I retorted, a sharp edge to my voice.

He roared with laughter, a booming, unrestrained sound that turned a few heads. Against my will, a faint, almost imperceptible twinge of a smile tugged at the corner of my lips.

He was one of the very closest people I had. Even he rarely saw me smiling. But the night was lit.

We were at the bar till midnight. He was drunk as fuck. Though, I had way too many shots. I had to be able to be the driver, as Mark was on vacation. The alcohol didn't have much on me. Maybe because it was the only thing I relied on since I wasn't even old enough to drink.



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## CHAPTER 19

EVELYN

“What are you doing here?” My voice wasn’t a question; it was a demand, cutting through the damp evening air as I rounded the corner of the Royal Academy. Edward stood, a sentinel of composed intensity, outside the heavy wrought-iron gates, his hands plunged deep into the pockets of his coat.

“I presumed I could give you a ride,” he stated, his gaze fixed on some point just past my shoulder, betraying a flicker of unease beneath the practiced calm.

The groan of heavy rubber on asphalt announced my commitment. “I already called Aden. He’s-”

Screech. A black car slammed to a stop beside the curb. “Look, he’s here.”

Aden emerged, his movements swift. He bypassed Edward, drawing me into a fierce embrace, his mouth claiming mine in a deliberate, territorial kiss. He then looked up, his eyes hard and cold, “Mr. Jones,”

“Just Edward and hi,” Edward’s reciprocal nod was just as measured. Just as sharp. Although, they knew each other before Aden had known me.

Edward shifted his weight, a subtle tremor running through him. “Aden, thank you for coming, but I was thinking I’d give her a ride today. I need this quality brother-sister time with her, we rarely get it.”

Aden's lip curled slightly, "Fine with me, if Eve wants the same."

He turned to me, his expression tightening, "I'll see you tomorrow, okay?"

"Yeah," I offered Aden a swift kiss, "I'll see you."

Edward's car didn't just swerve; it sliced through the night, leaving the city's electric buzz behind. He pulled off the main road and onto a stretch of gravel where the forest line choked out the moonlight. The silence that descended was thick and immediate, broken only by the engine's residual ticking.

"Hey, why did you stop here?" I asked, a knot of confusion and dread forming in my stomach. The lamp posts here were sparse, casting harsh, lonely cones of light between the encroaching shadows.

He didn't answer immediately. He simply killed the ignition and stepped out. He then walked around the hood and held my door, his eyes dark in the sudden gloom. "I thought we could use a little walk."

"Look at you, being all too the gentleman," I teased, forcing a fragile smile as I slipped out.

He closed the door with a quiet thud and started walking, hands now agitatedly scrubbing against each other. "So, how's everything? How are things with Dad?" The questions were a bluff, a weak smokescreen. His nervousness was palpable; every muscle in his neck was corded tight. This was the story of a man bracing himself to drop a bomb.

"You know how things are with him," I retorted, the old bitterness a familiar, searing taste. "I don't understand how you two are so unmoved by it all."

“I’m not unmoved, Eve. But he begged for a second chance. I yielded to it. People make mistakes.”

“Yeah, right. Well, good for you.” The words were clipped, an angry finality.

Edward stopped, his large hand clamping gently onto my arm, forcing me to meet his intensely concerned gaze. “Eve, let go of the anger. You and I both know how much he means to you.”

“Meant. Past. Not anymore.” The lie was sharp, stinging my own throat. The effort to forgive him had only lacerated the wound, reminding me how deeply I’d been abandoned.

“Okay, forget it,” he conceded, releasing my arm. “It’ll come around. Everything will be okay. You’ve got me.” He winked, a desperate attempt to dissolve the tension, but his eyes remained worried.

I stopped him mid-stride, planting my feet firmly. “I know this isn’t why you hauled me out into a gothic forest in the dark. So, let it out. No more bluffs.”

He let out a short, choked sound that might have been a laugh. “You know me too well, don’t you?”

“Yes, I do. Now, say it.”

His hands were still. He spun to face me, his features illuminated by a solitary, buzzing lamp—a mask of ecstatic terror. The breath caught in his lungs.

“I’m getting married.”

“What!?” The sound was a shriek of pure, confused elation. “Oh my God, I’m genuinely happy for you! When did this happen?” The joy short-circuited into immediate suspicion. “Wait, what? You haven’t known her for long. Are you certain?”

“Yes, I know, the timeline is insane,” he admitted, his shoulders dropping slightly. “But I know she’s the one. I see

myself spending every beat of my heart with her. She loves the person I was and the person I almost am. And I love her, Eve.” His voice was hoarse with the weight of the confession.

“Stop. Just stop. You’ll make me cry.” I turned my back, trying to control the rush of emotion, then spun back, my vision fractured through hot, sudden tears. “You know, if you asked me, I’d tell you not to. Because I had you only for myself all these years. Now you won’t be with me anymore.” The words were a choking accusation, raw and selfish.

His arms crushed me against his chest, a desperate, anchoring pressure. “You know I’m always going to be the same. And no matter where I go, you’ll be next to me. Your brother loves you more than anything, and that will always be the constant.” He kissed my hair, right beside my ear. I felt the shuddering tremor in his shoulders and saw the raw, unshed grief in the clench of his jaw.

“I love you,” I whispered fiercely against his coat, the fabric muffling my voice.

“Okay, that’s enough.” I pulled myself out of his embrace, swiping impatiently at my wet cheeks. “No more getting emotional. We are planning a lavish, ridiculous wedding ceremony. When is it?”

“Two months later,” he whispered, a huge, relieved smile finally breaking through the tension.

“I can’t wait. I’m thrilled.” He was my rock, the father I hadn’t had, the constant I could anchor my soul to. I wanted every fraction of happiness for the man who had stood guard over my life.

I knew I loved him more than anything.

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## CHAPTER 20

### EVELYN

The ceremony was a testament to impossible beauty, framed by the infinite horizon where the azure Mediterranean dissolved into the sky. The destination altar, carved from bleached driftwood and draped with billowing white silk, was an architectural dream. It was lavishly adorned with a cascade of pristine white *Phalaenopsis* orchids and deep green eucalyptus branches, providing a lush, organic contrast to the sweeping ocean backdrop. The air itself smelled of salt and sweet peony.

I watched Helen move, a vision of grace. Her white gown was a cascading torrent of silk and lace, its voluminous train sweeping the pristine white sand. The bouquet—a dense, exquisite globe of soft pink and ivory peonies, was clutched loosely in her hands. As she reached the final step, a blinding shard of sunlight struck her, and her eyes blazed with incandescent joy.

Standing among the bridesmaids, my posture was deliberately rigid to contain the surge of emotion. My burgundy gown, a sleek sheath of liquid satin, felt like a powerful second skin, mirroring the confident shimmer of Helen's two sisters beside me.

Edward, normally the picture of stoic composure, was visibly shaken. I could see the reflection of the sea and the sky in his eyes, which were glistening pools of raw, beautiful vulnerability. Tears of overwhelming happiness teetered on the very edge of his lashes, threatening to spill. It was a heavenly sight of pure, unrestrained affection.

I allowed my gaze a brief, necessary detour. Aden stood a short distance away among the guests, his silhouette arresting. His broad shoulders were perfectly set beneath a custom-tailored, shadow black suit. Every item, from his shirt to his polished shoes, was unrelieved obsidian, a stark and commanding contrast to the light, airy setting and his own fair, sculpted features. Edward had desperately wanted him as best man along with his friends, but Aden had arrived only this morning, flying in just to witness this moment.

Edward's voice was thick with emotion as he responded to the vows, his fingers interlaced firmly with Helen's. "I absolutely do," he stated, the words a solemn promise etched in time. Helen echoed him with equal conviction.

Then came the bouquet toss-premature, certainly, but wildly entertaining. I surged forward, reaching with a competitive instinct I didn't know I possessed, and the cluster of peonies was suddenly mine. But my heel caught the edge of the rug, and I began an irreversible, embarrassing lurch toward the ground.

A strong, steady anchor arrested my descent. A pair of powerful hands gripped my waist, pulling me back against a rock solid chest, saving me entirely.

"You don't have to break yourself to get my attention, love," Aden's voice, a low, resonant rumble, vibrated directly against the back of my neck.

My head snapped back and up, forcing me to tilt my chin, instantly finding the intense gravity of his gaze. A shaky smile bloomed on my face, a silent acknowledgment of his timing.

He didn't hesitate. His fingers hooked gently under my chin, tilting my head just enough before his lips claimed mine with a decisive, electrifying pressure. The world narrowed to the sudden,

bold intimacy of the kiss, even as a wave of collective gasps and cheers washed over us. It was utterly mortifying and somehow perfect.

We migrated to the center of the dance floor as the newlyweds took their first slow twirl. Aden's hands sank firmly to my lower back, guiding my movement. My arms encircled the powerful column of his neck.

"Do you know how graceful you are?" he murmured, leaning his mouth close to my ear. "It's almost like the sun went down just so you could rise incandescent, dazzling to light up the evening."

I looked down, feeling the familiar heat of shyness, but his fingers gently slid beneath my jaw, tilting my face up to hold my eyes captive. He cracked a soft, irresistible smile. "Only the old legends of Fairies describe anything close to your beauty. They were close, love. But not quite there." He then spun me backward with a playful, effortless force, the movement taking my breath away.

The spell was broken by my mother's voice. "Eve, darling! It's time for the speeches, go!"

Aden granted my release, but not before planting a warm, firm kiss high on the crown of my head, a silent benediction.

I stepped up to the microphone, feeling the unexpected confidence his kiss had given me. "Mic check, hello," I announced.

"Hi!" the crowd roared back, energized by the reception.

"Wow, look how absolutely adorable Edward and Helen are looking tonight," I began, my voice rich with warmth. "Though, I must mention Edward never quite achieved this level of handsome. He was, let's be honest, Mom's pretty little girl when he wore this." I clicked the remote of the projector, revealing a

slide of Edward in a childish dress, and a detonation of laughter erupted.

“Okay, maybe. That phase wasn’t that bad. Until, of course, Edward encountered a lizard in the powder room and, in his panic, his leg went...” I paused, clicking to the next slide, which showed an undeniably young Edward, his leg awkwardly propped on a toilet tank in terror. Edward’s outraged scream sliced through the air: “No! You did not just show that!”

“Alright, alright, he was a child then,” I conceded with a grin, before clicking to the truly devastating image: a close-up of him as a child, clearly engaged in a moment of nose-picking contemplation, “That’s absolutely not him,” I said sarcastically, “is it, Edward?”

The room collectively imploded with laughter. I let the noise wash over me, noting Aden’s face, which was tilted up, his lips curled into a rarity. Genuine smile, a sight that settled deep within me. “But jokes aside,” continued, my voice softening, “he has never, not once, failed to be the most steadfast and great brother to me, and a marvelous, devoted son to our parents. Helen, he loves you without condition or ceiling. I wish you both the happiness of a thousand lifetimes and the unbreakable promise of eternity. I love you, Edward.”

My voice hitched on the final words, and my eyes blurred. I saw Edward’s own eyes were just as wet. As I returned to my seat, feeling emotionally spent, Aden’s hand was instantly there. He hooked his arm around my shoulders and pulled me securely against him, his warmth instantly grounding.

“Aren’t you the silver-tongued orator, darling?” he said, the words a playful drawl, his eyes sparkling with shared amusement.



I rolled my eyes, leaning into his strength, but couldn't completely hide my smile. The night, and our story, had only just begun.

## ADEN

The collective roar of the dinner crowd was a dull, obnoxious hum I had long since tuned out. I detached myself from Edward, his cluster of back-slapping friends and Oliver, my focus laser-locked on the fluid grace of Eve's burgundy gown across the room. She was talking, smiling politely, and I couldn't tolerate the shared attention any longer.

I moved through the periphery, a shadow cutting through the light. I didn't announce myself. I simply executed the plan I'd been formulating all night: claim and retreat.

I halted inches behind her, letting my body heat act as a warning. My hand, a deliberate, slow caress, swept down the elegant, silk-covered line of her spine. Then, I dipped my head and placed a scorching, possessive pressure just below the point where her hair began, a silent brand on the downy skin of her neck. I felt the tiny hitch in her breath, the moment her pulse accelerated. It was a wordless directive. She was mine, and she was following.

I broke contact and slipped into the cool, swallowing shadows of the garden, a secret sanctuary where the air was thick with the scent of jasmine and salt. I heard the faint rustle of her dress as she murmured an apology, then the hesitant sound of her heels on the cobblestones, moving away from the light.

She reached the edge of our secluded darkness, where the moon slivered through the lattice of palm fronds, casting dancing, fragmented shadows. "Aden?" she whispered, the sound

a low, hopeful  
vibration.

I didn't answer. I materialized, my arms iron bands locking around her waist, and lifted her high, spinning us in a dizzying, reckless rotation.

Her breathless laughter, unburdened and pure, resonated through the heavy night air. "Hello, baby," she sighed when I set her down, utterly disarmed. Her smile-that real smile, not the public one, was enough to stop my heart.

"Hi, darling," I replied, my voice rough. I pulled her immediately into a tight, desperate embrace.

"God, I missed you," I confessed, the words raw and laced with the exhaustion of forced patience. "I've hated every second of this staged spectacle that kept me from you."

My kisses were urgent, punishing the space between us, marking every point of her face.

She pressed her palms against my chest, her voice low and dangerous. "You wouldn't ever really get married, would you?"

I answered by silencing her with my mouth. Kiss. "Maybe," I whispered. Kiss. "And perhaps, definitely not." The ambiguity was intentional; I wanted her bound to me, not to a piece of paper.

"What are we doing here, let's go inside?" she finally asked, her fingers kneading the black fabric of my jacket.

I tightened my arms, caging her movement, nudging her deeper into the dark recess of the cool stone wall. "And share you? With all those loud, thirsty vultures? No thanks, darling."

I leaned my head heavily onto her shoulder, my lips resting against the slope of her collarbone, and the words slipped out,

heavier than gravity. “I love YOU, bird.”

She pulled back abruptly, forcing me to stand straight. I watched her, waiting. She rose on her toes, her hands cupping my jaw, “don’t call me that,” she said before delivering a kiss of absolute conviction, a deep, consuming contact that spoke volumes of her devotion. I chuckled seeing her annoyed face with that name. It was enough. It was more than enough.

Yet, a primal part of me still craved the sound of the reciprocal vow. But it didn’t matter. I knew the truth of my soul: it was eternity with her, or nothing at all. I had always scoffed at the soft, saccharine images of typical romance, the slow dances in the moonlight, the gentle declarations. It was all nonsense until she was here, beside me, and suddenly, this dark, salt-laced night felt like a goddamn golden hour.

I gazed at the sight of her, the shadow draped figure that was my future. This possession, this moment of solitude with her, was the only thing I had ever truly wanted. Only her.

## EVELYN

The ceremony’s faint, dying light barely fought the ocean’s profound, suffocating darkness. The wind, a whip of salt-laced ice, tore at my skin. I loved the raw bite of the night, but now that Aden was gone, summoned away by Luke’s urgent, sharp summons, the vast, echoing stretch of the coast felt suddenly and completely vulnerable. He’d given me a quick, hard kiss -a promise to return-before he had peeled away for what was clearly an “important” crisis.

“Not a very good place for a pretty girl like you here.”

The voice, a low, smooth grit against the wind’s howl, came from the shadows behind me. I spun, the fine sand crunching

under my heel. “Jake.” The name was a stone in my throat. “What in God’s name are you doing here?”

He took a deliberate step that closed the distance. “Oh, Aden is not here, neither is Luke.” He paused, a cruel smile playing on his lips. “I’m not here for them. I came for you,” he purred. “Thought you’d be here, given your personal information about your interests.” The unnerving ease of his certainty, the chilling implication that he had been watching and waiting for this exact moment, sent a spike of pure, cold dread through me.

I searched his eyes, a striking, unsettling shade and recognition, ugly and undeniable, hit me like a physical blow. “It was you,” I whispered, the realization stealing my breath. “Outside the college that day. The hoodie, the mask... it was you all along.”

A slow, vicious smile spread across his mouth. “Wow. Took the great Evelyn this long to connect the dots. Yes, it was me. And your maniac boyfriend ruined what was supposed to be a very private exchange.”

My jaw clenched. “I don’t have time for your twisted games, Jake. Get out of my way.” I pivoted sharply, aiming for the safety of the main path, but his hand shot out—a steel vise clamping down on my wrist.

“Oh, I’m not done yet.” His laugh was a dry, rasping sound that failed to reach his eyes. He yanked me back, forcing me to stumble closer to the precarious, crumbling edge of the drop. “I pity you, Evelyn. You deserve better. Do you even understand the animal you’ve coupled with? What your psycho boyfriend truly is and the blood on his hands? You are utterly clueless, aren’t you?”

He released my wrist, only to start a slow,

menacing circle around me, cutting off any escape. We were pinned between the towering darkness of the land and the endless, black abyss of the sea.

“But he was dumb enough to leave you here, on the very lip of the abyss,” he spat, his voice dropping to a dangerous hush. “Not thinking twice that someone could give you a little nudge, and you could simply vanish off the cliff.”

“Stop this madness!” I backed up, my spine brushing against a rough, sea-worn rock. “Have you lost your mind? I’m telling Shayla —”

“That bitch?” he scoffed. “I don’t care about her. She wants something I don’t intend to give. I could give all of it to you, Evelyn, if you just —” He lunged, his hand reaching for my face, a repulsive gesture of false intimacy. I flinched violently away, the sudden movement nearly sending me over

the edge.

“Keep your hands off me!” His eyes, now alight with a frightening, manic spark, suddenly lost all control. The circulation stopped. He towered over me, the Wind carrying his next words, harsh and shattering, across the isolated beach.

“He killed my brother, you understand that? Your precious Aden murdered something priceless to me!”

He raised a trembling, accusatory finger, its shadow falling across my chest.

“And now... I’m going to take away something just as precious to him.”

“You.”

## ADEN

“What was so crucial, Luke, that you got me here?” I snarled,

stepping inside my opulent office, the sound echoing the rage already boiling in my gut. Luke didn't flinch. He was already seated, his face a grim mask.

"I think you might want to take a look at this," he stated, pushing the unread manila envelope, the one Oliver had given me, across the polished mahogany desk.

My hands ripped into the thick paper. The words swam for a moment, then coalesced into sickening clarity. "Holy hell! It was this Jake scumbag all along? He was running the show for Erling?" I spat the name like a shard of glass.

"Yes. And apparently, you killed his brother when the idiot tried to kill you. So now he wants blood for blood," Luke said, leaning forward, his voice a low warning.

I paced, my leather shoes silently grinding the expensive rug. "The hell he wouldn't even be able to touch me! Yeah, now it all clicks. I knew something about him wasn't normal, but I dismissed it as petty jealousy."

Luke's next words hit me with the force of a wrecking ball. "Aden, he is going for Evelyn."

My world didn't just spin; it fractured. Erling's chilling promise, that he'd dismantle the things I cherished, ripped through my memory. And it was Evelyn. Always Evelyn.

"He was outside Eve's college one day. It was him, right from the start. He was stalking her, gathering intel," I muttered, my palm slamming against my forehead. "God, how could I be so blind, so monumentally dumb?"

"Where is Evelyn right now?" Luke's demand was a hammer blow.

The realization was a punch to the gut: She was alone. Alone on that exposed, windswept bluff after the ceremony.

I snatched the Glock from the desk drawer, the cold weight a familiar, terrifying comfort and sprinted for the glass door. Luke was a blur behind me. We hit the parking lot running, the tires of Mr. McCall's waiting car screaming against the asphalt as we careened out.

I slammed my fist against the passenger

window, the glass rattling. "I swear to God, I will tear this motherfucker apart, limb by limb, if he so much as grazes her." I brought my hand to my mouth, my fingers touching my lips, tasting the ghost of the kiss I'd just shared with her, a vow of eternity now staring down the barrel of a gun. The drive was an agonizing blur of minutes. When the headlights finally cut through the coastal darkness, revealing the desolate bluff, I didn't wait for the car to stop. I exploded out, sprinting across the uneven ground toward the faint figures standing near the cliff's edge.

Jake was circling her, a predator over his prey. Evelyn stood rigid, her silhouette tiny and fragile against the crashing sea.

"Well, well, what do we have here. Little boyfriend came to play hero," Jake drawled, a vicious, theatrical laugh splitting the silence. He adjusted his stance, pulling Evelyn tight against his body, his arm a steel bar around her throat, a small, silver pistol pressed hard against her temple.

"If you take one more step, this bullet goes straight through her head and I'll push her right over the edge. You don't want that, do you?" he hissed. "Drop the gun, like a good little boy, Aden."

I skidded to a stop, the damp sand spraying my feet. My breath hitched, my chest seized. The pistol in my hand suddenly

weighed a ton, yet felt utterly useless. “Okay! Leave her, and I will let you walk away alive and untouched!”

“Shut up! You’ll do as I say!” Jake’s face contorted, pure hatred shining in his eyes. “Remember how you slaughtered my brother? Yes, Aden! You executed him! fucking. Killed. Him. You probably don’t even remember, because that meant nothing to you.”

The guilt was a physical sickness. Evelyn was paying the price for my brutal life, her delicate body trapped and trembling in his grasp. I watched Jake’s fingers digging into her arms, the pain visible on her tear streaked face, and I wanted to turn the gun on myself. I caused this. I was the problem. If it wasn’t for me, She wouldn’t have been in this problem where her life relied on the hands of a lunatic.

*How am I even calling him the bad guy? I am no better than him.*

“Okay, okay! Let her go! Just let her go, and I’ll give you anything you want!” My voice cracked, raw with desperation.

## EVELYN

The world was not spinning; it was fracturing. Everything dissolved into a terrifying, bright distortion around the ice-cold coin of the gun’s muzzle pressed against my temple. If I so much as twitched, the metal would kiss my skin, and the shot would blow my head away.

I was frozen. That humiliating, hated paralysis had seized me, a stone monument of terror on the cliff’s edge. I couldn’t think; I could only stare into the raw, animal fear in Aden’s eyes as the bullet remained a single, lethal second away.



But then, Jake made his fatal mistake. He shifted, his attention momentarily drawn to Aden's desperation, his muzzle dipping just an inch as he tightened his grip for another cruel threat. It was a fraction of a second, a breath of empty space that Aden ruthlessly seized.

The pistol in Aden's hand erupted, a sudden, blinding thunderclap that shredded the salt-laced night. The muzzle flash was the last light I saw before I was completely deafened and numb.

I didn't feel pain. I was alright. But when I shifted my eyes, the scene was playing out in agonizing, slow motion. The bullet had found its brutal, precise center: Jake's forehead. His head snapped back as the impact hit, the expression of vicious triumph instantly replaced by a dead, hollow surprise.

His body slumped instantly, releasing my arms with a terrifying finality. He fell in a heavy, lifeless heap, the silver pistol clattering and skittering across the rocks.

*A man is killed-executed-in front of me, and Aden had been the one to pull the trigger.*

The sight of Jake's still, bloody form paralyzed me anew.

"Luke, take him. Handle this." Aden's voice, rough and military-sharp, cut through the ringing silence in my ears.

Those were the last coherent sounds I registered. The world tilted and dissolved. I couldn't hold the weight of the moment, the terror, or the blood. I simply broke. I felt the solid shock of Aden's arms enveloping me just before I collapsed, surrendering to the absolute, consuming darkness.

## EVELYN

The room swam into agonizing focus. My head felt like a

grotesque, leaden anchor, a brutal weight dragging me back into the horrifying reality I'd just fled. I was in Aden's bed, a vast, rumpled expanse of white sheets that now felt tainted. But the space next to me was cold, violently empty.

The memories didn't surface; they slammed into me. The silver glint. The deafening shot, the sickening thud of a body hitting the rocks. A man, Jake, was killed by Aden. I remembered how I couldn't hold the weight of the moment, the terror or the blood. I simply broke. I felt the solid shock of Aden's arm enveloping me just before I collapsed, surrendering to the absolute, consuming darkness.

The door clicked open and Aden entered, "Eve, are you okay?"

The sound of his voice, calm and utterly incongruous with the carnage I'd witnessed was like a physical shock. I fixed my gaze on him, a desperate, searching stare that found no comfort. He wore a crisp, dark t-shirt, his posture rigid, shoulders squared.

I forced myself up, the sheets pooling around my waist, my movements jerky and uncoordinated. "You killed him," my voice cracked, thin and raw. "I was there, I was right there, when you murdered him." The words detonated in the sterile silence of the room.

I scrambled back towards the headboard putting distance between us, my breath catching in ragged, hysterical gasps. "You killed someone, Aden! Does that not register? You took a life!"

He didn't flinch. He walked slowly, deliberately toward the edge of the bed. The tension in the air was so thick. It felt like smoke, "I know that." His voice was a low, rough rumble. He knelt beside the bed, his knuckles resting lightly on the mattress edge, but he didn't dare to cross the physical boundary I'd erected. "I'm a monster. I deserve your disgust. But –"

The intensity in his dark eyes was overwhelming, a small, weary collapse of my shoulders and allowed him to sit on the edge of the mattress, the movement jarring the entire frame.

“If I hadn’t killed him, he would have killed you.” Aden ground out, his jaw tight, his eyes burning with a possessive fire. I suddenly feared. “I would have torched the entire world to stop that. His life meant less than nothing to me, when it threatened yours. I know you hate me, but he deserved it. Every. Single. Bloody inch of it.”

“You don’t get to deliver that judgement!”

I spat, the restraint, finally shattering. “You can’t kill someone and declare his death righteous! It’s not your place to decide who deserved what!” I looked away, the immaculate order of the room, the military precision of his folding, the severe, muted palette, mocking the utter chaos raging within me.

Then I turned back, a sliver of desperate hope, sharp as a razor, cutting through the horror, “Tell me. Tell me everything he said was a lie.”

Aden didn’t hesitate and that’s what killed the last flicker of light in my soul.

“It was all true. I killed his brother and many others of them. Because they had earned it.” The words were heavy and brutal.

“They killed my mom, the only person I had ever loved and the bullet hit me after getting through her. But that wasn’t enough. They had to try a hundred other times to kill me.”

He leaned in closer, his scent-a mix of expensive clean cologne and something elemental but dangerous, suddenly suffocating.

“I know you’re never going to look at me the same way. I don’t expect you to.” He shifted, his body language now radiating a bleak self-hating honesty.

“I know what I am. But I only killed them when I was forced to defend my own life. Except for the fact that I anyway wanted to. They attacked and died.”

I couldn't process it. He was a terrifying stranger, constructed entirely of cold-blooded secrets. A single, hot, unwanted tear tracked a burning path down my cheek.

“Don't do that to me, please don't cry.” He reached out, his hand hovering over my knee, the gesture of a man terrified to touch.

“I was never good. I never could be. I don't regret what I have done. I know hell isn't enough for me. But watching them die, slowly and painfully, I found peace, you know? They murdered my mom. Then tried me. I survived, they got unlucky that I lived.”

His eyes were glazed with a terrifying, righteous fury, the sheer, primal violence of his confession a physical blow to my chest. That wasn't the man I'd fallen in love with. He was a devastating illusion. I looked at him, completely numb. I had trusted him blindly and he had just shattered me with the biggest lie of all.

*Was I nothing more than a temporary distraction?*

I scrubbed the tears off my face with the heel of my hand, a gesture of finality. My voice was suddenly clear, devoid of hysteria, but laced with a chilling resolve. “I want to go home. Now, please.”

He reached out, his fingers brushing the air near my jaw, “Eve —”

“I said, now. Please.” I cut him off, my eyes locking onto his, a fortress of cold withdrawal.

He dropped his hand, the defeat in his posture immediate and total.

He looked down, the dark shadow of his confession. He knew insisting would only confirm his monstrosity.

He rose slowly, a weary titan of violence.

“Get dressed. I’ll take you.”

I looked back at him. Knowing nothing and thinking; *how is he so different?*

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## CHAPTER 21

### ADEN

The days that followed the execution felt like wading through glass. Each hour was a fresh shard of agony. I knew, with the cold certainty of a man facing a firing squad, that Evelyn would never forgive me. I didn't blame her. I deserved her hate. A beast so steeped in blood and violence deserved only isolation. She deserved some fairytale prince, a man untainted by the shadow of death and I was a poison that would only guarantee her pain.

The thought of her near me was a grotesque vulnerability I could no longer tolerate.

My office was a minimalist cage of steel and smoked glass, high above the city. The panoramic view felt like dominion; now it felt like a prison. I was hunched over the polished mahogany desk, its surface empty save for a single, half-empty tumbler of neat whiskey.

Luke entered without knocking. The soft thud of the glass door closing failed to break the ringing silence in my skull. He stepped cautiously into the room, his hand crossed over his chest.

"Ad, are you alright?" he asked, his voice low.

I slammed the tumbler onto the desk, the heavy crystal striking the wood with a sharp crack. I didn't turn. "Do you understand that she could have died, because of me, Luke?" The words were pulled from my chest. Raw and ragged. "I don't really care how deep her hatred is. If that's the price of keeping her alive, I'd rather her think me a monster than have her dead."

Luke's expression hardened, his eyes mirroring the grim logic that ruled my own life. He moved around, leaning against the corner. His posture was the Military briefing stance. No room for sentiment. "Yes. And you know what the consequence is. You know what you have to do to make it stuck. It's the only path that keeps her safe."

I finally turned, swiveling my chair to face him, my own gaze leaked and lethal. "I can't just abandon her," I snarled, the denial tearing at my resolve. The chair squeaked against the floor, a jarring protest against the weight of the decision.

"It's for her survival. You know you have to cut the cord."

I closed my eyes for a long, aching moment. He was right. I was a magnet for carnage. If I didn't create an insurmountable distance, the wolves would find her through me and they'd finish —.

"Yeah, I know." The admission was barely a whisper, the death of my last hope.

Luke straightened, shifting abruptly into his professional veneer, signaling the end

of the personal conversation. "Right. So, the quarterly press conference is scheduled. You'll be peppered with the usual fiscal queries, interests, profitability, growth strategies. Standard corporate theatre. But, there's a rider this time."

He paused, letting the weight of the next words land. "They'll inevitably ask about your love life. Your commitment status and I expect you to handle it. You always do."

He was great as the COO. I looked out at the vast, indifferent city, the millions of oblivious lives moving below. Handle it. I handled war, death and betrayal. But this, the deliberate, public execution of a relationship I desperately clung to, was the one act

of violence I wasn't prepared for. For the first time in my calculated, brutal existence, I was not ready.

I didn't feel ready. I needed her. I wanted her so badly, that it hurt to even try not to think about her. She was everywhere.

## EVELYN

The silence in my room had been a suffocating blanket, a routine as relentless as the ceiling I stared at. Days bled into weeks since I'd last spoken to Aden. It was a self-imposed exile, a desperate need for space to heal from a trauma still festering beneath the surface. College, once a path, felt like a distant, irrelevant planet.

My parents were ghosts of worry, their fear a palpable but secondary discomfort. Dad's few appearances were fleeting. His concern about a muted drumbeat I barely registered. Edward was blissfully ignorant, wrapped up in his honeymoon, worlds away.

The jarring shriek of my phone shattered the morbid stillness. I didn't move immediately. My world was a horizontal plane, my back glued to the mattress.

"Hey, sweetpea," Ana's voice finally pierced through, thick with a clumsy, forced empathy. "I'm really sorry, how are you doing?"

"I'm alright...I'm fine," I lied, the words tasting like ash in my mouth. "Aden's a jerk. How could he do this to you?"

The casual accusation was a jolt of pure confusion.

*Wait, what? The Only "incident" Ana knew about was Jake's horrific fall from the cliff.*

The deeper, more agonizing truth about Jake, what had been done was a secret between Aden, Luke and me.

*What had Aden done to me that she knew about?*



“Wait, you haven’t watched the news yet?” Her voice was laced with frantic disbelief.

I stumbled out of the bed, my legs heavy and unfamiliar, my bare feet hitting the cold, wooden floor. “I don’t watch the news,” I muttered, fumbling with the remote, the bright-red digital clock flashing an accusatory glare. “What happened?”

Her voice dissolved into a distant drone as the TV screen blazed to life. The phone slipped from my nerveless fingers, clattering onto the floor, the sound muffled by the growing thunder in my ears. A cold, paralyzing wave of dread washed over me, chilling me to the bone.

On the screen, Aden stood poised, shielded behind sleek, designer sunglasses, the flash of cameras a binding strobe around him. The press were a hungry pack.

“Everybody’s aware of your success, tell us about your girlfriend, we’ve seen you with someone multiple times now.”

His voice, amplified through the mic, was a sharp, clinical blade. “I don’t do girlfriend and all. For me, it’s nothing. My work is my top priority. Girlfriends are only a distraction to all of this.”

“What about the girl?” a reporter pressed.

The ensuing words were not just a rejection; they were a scorched earth declaration. “She’s a nobody. I have various appetites and interests outside business in various sexual activities. But, it doesn’t always have to be constantly the same person. Somebody just got lucky and lasted more than usual. But, that doesn’t mean anything. No one but me means all to me. Thank you.” His tone was harsh, firm, utterly devoid of remorse.

I stood there, rooted to the spot in the center of my room. My breath caught in my throat like a shard of glass. I watched him publicly, ruthlessly dismantle me. He had done the very thing he

swore, promised he would never. He had taken the private, the cherished and exposed it as a vulgar sport.

But the blame, in that sickening moment of clarity, wasn't his. It was me all along. Everything from his side had been a calculated deceit. He hadn't just wanted to leave; he had wanted to annihilate me. He deserved a Standing Ovation actually.

"...you there, Eve?" Ana's voice was a weak, vibrating hum from the fallen phone. I finally moved, wiping the hot, unwelcome tears from my face. Tears I refused to shed for a man who saw me as a disposable collateral. I snatched the phone, "yes, I'm here. Uhm...about that, don't worry, it was mutual."

I forced out, my voice a thin, brittle wire.

"I was the one to tell him to do that. We don't belong together. So I thought it's for the best."

I tried to sound strong, but the terrible tremor in my voice betrayed the lie.

"It's going to be okay, sweetpea. I'm always going to be here for you. You know I love you right?"

"Yeah, I'll talk to you later. I gotta go." I disconnected the call before the dam could break, cutting her off, cutting off the world.

I didn't make it to bed. I collapsed onto the floor, my cheek pressed against the unyielding, cold wood. The pain was a physical, crushing weight, far worse than the bone deep ache I'd felt after Jake's death. The pain was an implosion, originating in my chest, a white hot agony that felt like my heart was being pulverized.

The sobs tore from me, ugly and rugged, echoing in the sterile room. I wanted to cease to exist at that very moment. It was the same cruel, repeating pattern, I extended my trust and they returned it in shards.

But he had been different. I didn't regret the trust I'd given. I regretted the result. I was simply done with love. But maybe I needed a lesson and it showed me what I did and gave me every reason to never do it again. I low-key needed that.

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## CHAPTER 22

### EVELYN

The echoes of the past, the weight of people who'd once mattered, might shape me, but they no longer dictated my existence. I hadn't seen Aden in a while. Life had a relentless forward motion and the realization that something wasn't meant for me was a painful, yet necessary truth. I was ready, even eager to step into a life unburdened by what was lost. I didn't want his constellation anymore.

It was this newfound resolve that led me to the narrow, slightly grungy back entrance of the student union building. A sign, half-peeled and flapping. Simply written "Band audition-last spot."

I spotted a lanky guy amid a distant thrum of bass music, "Is the audition for the band happening here?"

I gave a light rap on his shoulder, aware of the local buzz about a new musical group seeking their final piece.

He turned, the movement quick, his eyes bright with a flash of surprise. "Hi!" he said, a genuine smile spreading across his face.

"Evelyn!" The name was an exclamation, a burst of recognition. "Max, right?" I confirmed the name setting into my memory.

"Yes, what are you doing here?" He adjusted the strap of the heavy case. His posture shifted from hurried to keenly interested.

"I wanted to audition for the band." I watched his face light up further.

“Yeah, absolutely.” He practically beamed. He gestured with a tilt of his head towards the door. “Guys...hey! We have Evelyn here. She’s a great vocalist. I think she could be the one,” he called into the dim hallway, his voice ringing with excitement as he waved the others over to meet me.

A few minutes later, after the other members, cool, collected and slightly intimidating, had asked me to sing a few impromptu lines, a girl with fiery red hair and a dazzling smile swept towards me.

“Gorgeous, girl, gorgeous!” The girl, Kennedy, practically lunged forward, her hands cupping my face with an almost startling warmth. Her touch was brief and electrifying, a gesture of pure, unbridled enthusiasm that almost had the energy of a kiss.

I felt a surge of pure, unadulterated relief and joy. I was in. I was now one of their five members. We were set to play at college events and various local functions. Though the chronic stage fright had been my shadow since childhood. I felt a quiet, fierce readiness. This was one of the few things I truly loved, this. The act of singing.

As the low light of the cramped studio cast long shadows, I was packing my bag, the sound of distant city traffic a low hum.

“What are you doing tonight?” Max’s voice, behind me, softer, almost tentative.

I didn’t turn around, I simply adjusted the strap of my own work backpack. “Uhm...nothing,” I murmured, keeping my gaze fixed on the ground. “Just laying low and I have a couple of assignments to finish.”

I started to walk out.

He caught up to me easily, his steps a hesitant rhythm beside mine.

“Do you think... like, maybe we could hang out?” he asked, the offer fragile and hopeful.

“Sorry, can’t,” I said, the words firmer than I intended. “Another time, sure.” I needed to be alone. The high of the audition was already fading and the dull ache of my lingering sadness was beginning to return. I had lost my lightness and I wouldn’t risk infecting anyone else with my gloom.

He stopped, his tall frame pausing just outside the studio’s chipped wooden door, accepting my refusal instantly. “It’s alright. I’ll see you at the school tomorrow.” His voice was kind, without a hint of disappointment.

“Yeah, see you,” I said walking away, plunging back into the night and the solitude I both craved and regretted.

## ADEN

Drinking had become a morbid ritual, an unwelcome art form. It was my single, unreliable anchor in a life where I was now utterly and deservedly hated by Evelyn.

“Ad, you’re up for the board meeting?” Luke’s voice sliced through the heavy air of my executive office, a vast, glass-walled space overlooking the cityscape.

A view I barely registered anymore. He stood framed in the open doorway. His posture was expectant.

“No. Cancel. Or you can just attend at my place. I’ve got something else to do.” I didn’t wait for a response. I shoved my chair back, the screech of the wheels loud in the silence and strode past him.

“Okay...” Luke’s single word hung in the air as I walked out,

leaving the polished veneer of my corporate life behind.

My heart seized in my chest when I spotted Evelyn in the school hall. Her face, usually glowing with a vibrant, inner light, was now a heartbreaking shade of pale.

“Incoming —” I heard Ana’s hissing whisper as she spotted me, a desperate, teeth gritting warning to Evelyn. Evelyn’s eyes locked onto mine for a fractured second, a flicker of pure, devastating pain, before she whipped her head away, attempting to melt into the crowd.

I moved instantly, my hand shooting out to capture her wrist. The contact was electric sharp. “We need to talk.”

She turned back, her chin lifting with a fragile, defiant strength.

“Mr. Pattersen,” she clipped, using the detested formal address.

“If you’ll excuse me, I have a class to attend to.”

“I —” the word caught in my throat, choked by the raw surge of emotion. Before I could regain control, a guy, Max, intervened, stepping between us with a sudden protective arrogance.

“Evelyn, are you okay?” His gaze, fixed on me, was a blatant challenge. A wave of visceral, territorial rage crashed over me. I wanted to shatter his composure, to make him regret his misplaced chivalry.

*Who the hell is he to touch my girl, to question her?*

I had to clench my jaw, fighting the animalistic impulse.

“Yes, I’m alright. It’s okay, you can go to class. I’m coming,” Evelyn said, her voice tight and steady.

Max didn’t move immediately; he had my stare for a tense, prolonged moment. A silent declaration of war. Before finally backing away to join the flow of students.

“Let’s go somewhere private. We’ll go to my dad’s office.” I didn’t ask; I commanded. As the founder’s son, I had access to the Executive sanctuary. A place of quiet, brutal power.

“There’s nothing to talk about.” She didn’t flinch. “You chose your path and now let me choose mine. Why are you even here? Eh? Go back to where you need to be. I don’t care. Just. Leave. Me. Alone.” Her voice cracked on the final word, a hairline fracture in her resolve.

“I’m not here to leave. You’ll hear me out and then I’ll go. Let’s move. Come on, don’t make this complicated. I didn’t come here to take ‘no’ for an answer.”

My grip tightened unconsciously.

“You can’t control me.” Her eyes were fierce, blazing with hurt and rebellion.

“I’m not one of your dolls anymore.”

“Eve, I’m done.” The control I’d been fighting for, snapped. “Either you walk with me now, or this will stop being funny,” I growled the words, low and dangerous. Knowing, I just bought myself some more hate. But I needed that.

“Or what? You’ll kill me too?” The sheer audacity of the question, the searing pain behind it stunned me. “Do it.”

I pulled her then, a sudden, brutal jerk on her wrist. The soft skin stretched taut under my fingers. I knew it hurt her; the realization was a fresh spike of self loathing. I was the same beast I always was. I didn’t deserve an inch of her.

I immediately released her, stepping back into the deserted office doorway.

“I’m sorry,” I managed, my eyes fixed on the pale skin of her wrist.



Already darkening to tell-tale red where my fingers had pressed. She gasped once, a tiny, involuntary intake of breath.

“Don’t be,” she said, her voice now flat, devastatingly devoid of emotion. “I earned this when I decided to be with you.”

I hated myself with a consuming fire in that instant, a desire to lash out, not at her, but at the monster I saw in the glass reflection.

“Okay, listen, Eve. Whether you believe it or not, you don’t wanna be with me. Trust me. I’m the beast you hate. It’s me. I’ve always been this monster inside and out —”

“No,” she cut me off, her words swift and ice cold. “I get it. It’s totally basic. I’m happy it happened. It was a must. It was just shocking how the lie had lasted this long. I don’t care about anything that relates to you.” Her performance was masterful, the conviction in her tone sharp enough to cut. But I knew the truth; beneath that armor, she still felt something. She still cared for me. I loved her and I knew she did too.

“You shouldn’t.” I conceded, a flicker of dark pride in her hatred.

“You should hate me like this. Everyone should. But listen to me, darling. I shouldn’t see you with another guy. This is going to be very hard for him. Remember that.” I was already turning to leave.

“You can’t just control everything!” Her voice shot up, vibrating with fury. “I’d do anything I want with my life. Kiss someone, sleep with someone—”

Before she could finish the thought, I was across the space, my body a dark blur of motion. I slammed her against the nearest wall, not violently, but with a sudden, immovable force. Her back hit the plaster with a dull thud.

I leaned in close, caging her with my hands, took my mouth to her ear, “if you do anything like that, watch me be the fucking beast I am. Try me and regret it, darling.”

I whispered the threat. My voice is a low gravelly promise. I could hear her heart beat so fast as she gasped for air. Then, I wrenched myself away and walked out, leaving her trembling against the wall.

I didn’t like the person I became around her. She had all my control. She didn’t know what I wanted to do with her. I didn’t even know how I pulled back and didn’t kiss her. I wanted to put her on the desk and kiss the hell out of her.

I loved her. I couldn’t see her with anyone else. Even if it made me the worst bastard of all. I couldn’t care less. I never gave a single flying fuck about who thought of me in what way. But, her perception mattered. But to her, I was nothing but a murderer and it was technically true.

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## CHAPTER 23

EVELYN

“Four years.” Maddie exhaled. The sound is tight with disbelief in Shayla’s car.

I had moved in with Ana in a different apartment. Which was kind of weird. Because I didn’t want to. But Oliver and Ana were insisting so much. I kind of had to. They were kind of weird but way too protective over me. They weren’t like that before. I hadn’t seen Aden in a long time. Hannah didn’t want me to move out either. But again, I wasn’t the same nineteen-year-old girl. The flat was quite nice. Oliver mostly lived here, given that they wouldn’t stop doing whatever they did.

“God, it feels like we left freshman year, yesterday.” The car was rushing us towards the massive school auditorium, a space that suddenly felt too huge, too final. It was utterly surreal that we were about to walk down an aisle in suffocating academic coats, graduating into the unknown.

“Did you know Aden’s coming, alongside Henry Pattersen,” Shayla murmured, her eyes flicking to me, expectant, searching.

The name was a low frequency hum of pure static in my head. I forced myself, scrambling for a change of subject. “So, about the set list...I don’t know how I am going to sing today. My stage fright is a monster.”

“You’re going to kill it, Evie. You always do.” Shayla affirmed from the driver’s seat. Her knuckles white in the steering wheel.

“Hell, yes!” Maddie and Ana agreed in a synchronised burst.

We arrived and the venue was a deafening, dizzying swarm of black gowns and echoing voices. My own one immediately betrayed me, the stiff fabric binding my arms as I tried to secure it.

“Here, let me help you.” A low, familiar voice cut through the chaos. Max materialized through the press of people.

“It’s fine, Max. I can do—” I struggled, but his fingers were already firm on the shoulder seams, effectively freeing me from the velvet chokehold. His touch was quick and nonjudgmental.

“I know you can,” he said, offering a small encouraging smile. “But the clock’s ticking.”

“Thank you.” I rumbled just as the president’s voice boomed, slicing the air from a distance.

“Ms. Evelyn Jones, You’re requested to ascend the stage.”

“Run, Eve, run!” Max urged, his hand gripping my elbow for a quick supportive squeeze before releasing me.

I bolted. The stage lights were a blinding inescapable furnace and then I saw him. Aden. Seated rigid and straight, a monument of tailored perfection next to the formidable Henry Pattersen.

My breath hitched, my entire momentum stumbling as the familiar, venomous cocktail of hatred and absolute undeniable love slammed into me. His mere presence was a gravity I fought, a magnetic dangerous pull towards a darkness I knew I didn’t want, yet craved with a shameful intensity.

I reached the podium. The microphone, a heavy cold, clumsy obstruction. “Hi,” I breathed, my voice barely audible. “Apologies. I had a wrestling match with my academic drapery.”

A thin, nervous laugh rippled through the front rows. I leaned into the mic, forcing my voice to steady. “Wow...this is surreal and honestly I’m terrified. But that’s alright. So, I’m just going to

deliver this to the only people I could lay my eyes on.” My friends’ roar of support was a loud, desperately needed lifeline, as I delivered my speech to only them.

“We did it. We clawed our way up here. If you’re standing at the edge of the future, paralyzed by fear, know that you’re not alone,” I declared.

My voice gained strength, “We have to be fearless to achieve something. Someone once stood here and said: ‘Do whatever you want and don’t let anyone tell you what to do,’” I said moving my gaze to Aden.

These were his words.

“Let’s keep it that way. People come and go. But, this. This is for life. We are going to be just fine. I congratulate all my fellow graduates and I just want to let them know, you’re best in your way and if you think it’s not enough. Well, the best is still yet to come. Thank you.”

The crowd erupted. But my focus was locked on the edge of the stage.

“I request Mr. Aden Pattersen to present the certificate to Ms. Jones.”

The announcement was a cruel, perfectly timed irony. Aden rose, moving with a controlled predatory grace.

“Congratulations, Eve,” he murmured as he handed me the rolled parchment.

His finger brushing mine with a deliberate rough warmth.

The flash of the official photographer was the cue. He seized me. His left arm clamped around my lower back, his hand splaying wide across my hipbone, an undeniable claim. His grip was iron, an unspoken, possessive declaration in front of a thousand witnesses. That deep, dark ownership I simultaneously

despised and desperately yearned for flared in the depths of his eyes.

I tried to pull away, a subtle, futile jerk of my torso, but he was granite, unyielding.

I was trapped, a trophy in his frame. The instant his grip relaxed, I bolted down the steps, across the floor. The heavy coat then felt like a ridiculous, suffocating straitjacket.

I burst into the sterile quiet of the women's lounge, slamming the door, I leaned against the cool tile, my heart hammering a panicked rhythm against my ribs.

*How dare he?*

The sheer audacity, the blatant, public assertion of power stunned me.

It was everything I fought against and yet, God help me, it was the raw, controlling force that made my resistance falter.

## ADEN

I watched Evelyn's frantic exit. She didn't walk away from the stage; she fled away. The warmth of her hip was still phantom, printed on my palm, a dangerous sensation I hadn't wanted to let go of. Her rejection, subtle but absolute, felt like a silent, public punch.

I settled back into the chair, the applause around me sounding distant and meaningless. Henry shifted beside me, his suit rustling.

"What's up with you and her?" he whispered, his eyes fixed straight ahead, pretending to be the involved father.

The question was like a match striking dry tinder. "None of your concern." I ground out, my voice flat and controlled.

“Come on, son. Am I that bad? I’m your father, you gotta talk to me,” he pushed, I knew he was trying to be sincere. But, that didn’t matter much.

“Oh, yeah?” I leaned in, my voice low and venomous,” I didn’t even see you sad for a second when mom died. Well, yeah, because you already had someone to replace her long ago, didn’t you? And her death just made it easier. Yeah, that’s right. So. Don’t play the I-have-a-right-to-know card on me.” I gritted my teeth, tasting blood from the effort of restraint.

His facade cracked. “Look, I’m sorry. I know I haven’t been a great father or a husband.”

“You think?” The word was a blade.

He sighed, his gaze flickering towards the stage. “Okay, have dinner with me. We could use some time and we could talk.”

“Well,” I said, a cold finality settling over me,” I’m not the same thirteen-year-old boy, who just needed his father. You do your business and let me do mine.” He finally had the good sense to shut up, his posture stiffening with defeat. The final certificates were delivered and the president’s booming voice returned.

“I now welcome the one and only ‘The Rare and Bare’ to perform for all of us today.”

A wave of anticipation washed over the audience. It was Evelyn’s band. I had listened to few of their tracks, but her voice; it was flawless, devastating thing.

I knew she would make it. They were now well-known around the city. This was just the beginning and that knowledge was both a prideful ache and a deepening dread.

They emerged from a sudden cloud of theatrical fog. We were sitting in the absolute front row. Evelyn’s friends, a row behind us

screamed her name in wild unison along with the crowd.

“This is the first time we are performing for a crowd like this.” The red-headed guitarist announced. “The song’s called ‘All the time’. We hope you’ll enjoy it.”

Then, the spotlight found Evelyn. It wasn’t just light; it was a deluge of gold that made her sleek black jacket disappear, leaving her radiant and exposed. My body went rigid. I hated it. The sheer audacity of every single person in the auditorium; big as a stadium staring at her, at the way her collarbone caught the light, at the intense, focused profile of her face. She was glittering, a star that I had no right to dim, but one I refused to let anyone else claim.

She raised the microphone and the first line was thrown into the massive echoing space,” Do you ever feel you’re lost?”

God her voice. It hit harder than any melody. It was the only music I listened to. I knew this song, every raw, exposed syllable.

After the finish line, she opened her eyes. A single glistening drop of water tracked a path down her cheek. “Thank you,” she whispered.

The song described everything about love and I knew I was everything she hated now.

The crowd went insane. It was everything she had ever wanted and I loved that she was happy.

The bassist clapped her hand on the shoulder. The drummer, Max guy, had to touch her face. He leaned in, his fingers briefly cupping her cheek. A noise, a low, guttural warning, escaped my throat. My blood didn’t just boil; it turned to molten slag. Who the hell did he think he was? That familiarity, that casual, intimate touch, was a territory violation.



I couldn't do anything about it, though all I wanted was to torture him there, I fucking hated him. But I couldn't. Evelyn would hate me more.

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## CHAPTER 24

### EVELYN

“Yes, mom. I’ll diligently take care of myself. Yeah... I love you too,” I mumbled juggling the phone precariously between my shoulder and ear. The door creaked open, my arms straining with the sheer weight of bursting grocery bags. The usual domestic chaos wasn’t present.

“Guys!” I yelled, the bags slipping a little in my sweaty grip. “Oh, my god! That’s repulsive!” I whipped around, my head snapping back. My gaze collided with the grotesque tableau on the living room couch; Ana and Oliver looked in a fierce, open-mouthed embrace. Both moaning and craving. Yuck.

They were sprawled in the tattered grey sectional, a focal point in the small, slightly cluttered living area. Sunlight, harsh and unfiltered, streamed in from the single large window, illuminating the dust motes dancing around their entwined bodies. Oliver’s bare chest was pressed against Ana’s floral tank top; his jeans were slung low on his hips.

“Oliver, please locate some proper attire,” I demanded, my voice tight with disgust.

He groaned in response, his head still buried in Ana’s neck. “Did you have to barge in, at this precise moment, Eve?” he grumbled.

Ana meanwhile, was shaking suppressed, uncontrollable laughter, her face flushed deep crimson.

“Excuse me? Uhm...you’re conveniently forgetting this dwelling is equally mine,” I retorted, taking a strained step aside. “And what sort of animals choose the main communal area for a public display of slobbering whatever that was, huh?”

“You can turn back now,” he hissed a hand waving dismissively in the air.

“Are you presentably covered?” I interrogated, still facing the door frame.

“Oh, for heaven’s sake. Yes.” I rotated slowly. My eyes narrowed and began the laborious task of hauling the bags into the kitchen, the linoleum floor cool beneath my sneakers.

“Why is it a universal law that every time I enter my house, I must bear witness to a clandestine make out session? And, why inexplicably, must the perpetrators be my own brothers?” I said, heaving a bag onto the counter.

“Half-brother,” Oliver corrected, his tone flippant with a playful grin as he adjusted his shirt.

I leaned my back forcefully against the wall beside the refrigerator.

The painted drywall, rough against my shoulders, I said, “Shut up and engage your brain.

“Never, under any circumstances, subject me to that again. It’s intensely peculiar, you and my best friend. Vile. So keep all your inappropriate interactions completely out of my sight. It’s enough that you guys moved in together. Stop all this. I don’t know why I had to move in with you two,” I stated my stance firmly.

Ana’s laughter, though muffled, persisted, bubbling up from the sofa.

He was my half-sibling, yes. But the genetic distance was irrelevant now. We had forged a true bond. But he was

overprotective. Even Ana. I hadn't witnessed them like that ever before. He was, in essence, the replica of an older brother to me, a steadfast, good man, much like Edward. Even Kira had visited me here accompanying Oliver and Derek. So, basically my whole family was here in the city. I never wanted to be in New York. But now I couldn't think of anything else. All my loved ones were in it. In many ways, everything felt more stable than before. Hannah was dating some enigmatic figure, a man I had never encountered. Derek, in turn, appeared genuinely content with Kira. Derek had made numerous, concerted efforts to reclaim his old role, the familiar father figure. I appreciated the sentiment, the gestures. But the past was irrevocable. Things would never return to their previous state. Still, I cherished his renewed presence.

"What's so uproariously funny, Ana?" I pressed, my patience fraying.

"Nothing. I'm not laughing. Look." She clamped her lips shut with a deliberate, theatrical gesture.

"So, little sister," Oliver goaded, a smirk playing on his lips as he stretched, his body uncoiling on the couch. "Where is your knight in shining armor? I haven't seen him in a while."

"Will you cease that insipid line of questioning? There is nothing between us. Aden and me. Whatever brief connection we shared is extinguished. I expect you to be utterly silent on the matter," I snapped the words out, then bolted.

I retreated into the sanctuary of my room, the door slammed shut behind me. Every single time his name was uttered, I felt an unbearable surge of helpless fury. I loathed the sheer deception of it all. Every word he had ever spoken to me was a calculated fabrication.

I was desperate to extricate him from my life. Yet, he was a cruel paradox: he didn't want me, but he would viciously prevent anyone else from claiming me. The suffocation of his influence was absolute. Everything about him was a heavy, crushing weight.

"...What? But how? And who are you?" Oliver's voice, usually a playful rumble, cracked with sudden steel over the phone.

The sharp, unexpected distress in his tone jolted me from my room. I sprinted into the living area, my heart hammering against my ribs. "What happened, Olie?" I demanded.

He whipped his head around, his eyes wide and glazed with shock. "It's...your dad," he choked out.

A familiar, agonizing contraction seized my chest, the exact, suffocating pain that had crushed me in Switzerland years ago. I had just reclaimed him after a decade-long void; I could not sustain another loss. Not him. Not now.

"Let's go! Now!" I shouted.

We tore out of the apartment, the door slamming against the frame. We careened down the stairwell and sprinted across the asphalt of the parking lot toward Oliver's car.

"Someone unidentified called," Oliver said, his jaw clenched as he slammed the key into the ignition. "He just said there'd been an accident. I don't know who the hell it was." The engine roared to life.

"So, where is he now?" I asked from the back seat, perched on the edge of the leather bench. Ana was already hunched forward in the passenger seat, her knuckles white against the dashboard.

"The caller specified the nearest hospital. We're blazing a trail there," Oliver snapped the gearshift into drive.

"Okay. Please, drive faster," I urged.

God. The sheer weight of it was too much to bear. I felt the ground slipping beneath me, the constant fear of losing every person I cherished. I had lost Derek once; I would not endure it again.

The car was a blur, hurtling through traffic, but the seconds were stretching into excruciating hours.

We finally screeched into the hospital's drop-off zone. As I flung myself out of the car, my eyes snared on a figure standing by the entrance: Aden.

"I called him," Oliver admitted, his gaze flickering toward me, anticipating my question about Aden's presence.

"Please, Eve," he muttered. I didn't dignify it with a response. I only wanted to will him out of existence, to pretend he was an invisible phantom. It was in that moment, as my mind was reeling with confusion and fear, that my phone vibrated. A call. From Derek

*Wait. What?* If he had been in an accident, how was he dialing me? The question incinerated all other thoughts.

Yet, I fumbled to answer.

"Hey, monkey? How are you doing?" His voice

was calm, perfectly intact. There was no pain, no panic, no awareness of any incident. I lowered the phone, my ear still tingling from the warmth of the speaker. Confusion was a scorching fire in my skull.

I saw Oliver striding directly toward Aden, a mixture of anger and relief on his face.

Then, the world slowed.

A sleek, black sedan, parked inconspicuously near the curb, had its tinted window sliding down with a low whine. A hand,

gloved and holding a handgun, emerged from the dark aperture. My eyes were locked on the muzzle, the cold, metallic aperture.

It wasn't aimed at me. Or at Ana.

It was focused squarely on Oliver.

I watched the bullet unleash itself, a tiny, lethal projectile slicing the air.

"Oliver!" I shrieked, the sound tearing from my lungs. He was already turning, instinctively shielding Aden with his body, but the bullet was already beyond recall.

It was too late. Before my desperate cry could bridge the distance, Oliver collapsed to the pavement. The shot had struck his upper right back. A stain of crimson immediately began to bloom and spiderweb across the white fabric of his shirt, quickly saturating the material. Aden, reacting with lightning speed, managed to cradle him before he hit the ground entirely.

"Somebody, help!" Ana's scream was a raw, animalistic sound as she scrambled toward the hospital entrance.

I sprinted forward, instantly hooking my shoulder under Oliver's weight, helping Aden drag his limp, bleeding body toward the emergency doors. I took one final, searing glance back at the black car. The window was gliding up. The face I glimpsed grim, unreadable-did not appear to hold any trace of satisfaction.

The shooter had hit his mark, yet he seemed haunted by his own lethal action.

## ADEN

It was a deliberate act. A meticulously planned diversion to lure Oliver out and assassinate me. The gun hadn't been targeting him; it had been seeking my life. Oliver, in his selfless instinct, had become my shield, intercepting the fatal projectile.

Ana, pale and shivering, had already frantically contacted Kira, Derek, and Edward.

Evelyn was a whirling vortex of panic, her movements erratic as she scrambled through the emergency room corridor. Oliver had been rushed into surgery: the doors were sealed, and absolute silence was enforced. The attending surgeon, who recognized me instantly, gave me a brief, reassuring nod, promising that Oliver would be stable.

“Eve, allow me to handle that,” I offered, reaching out to stop her as she careened toward the reception desk to sign forms.

“No!” She violently shook off my touch, her eyes flashing. The fluorescent lights of the hospital hall glared off the wet tracks on her cheeks.

“I can manage this. Besides, you shouldn’t be here. People are collateral damage because of you. He didn’t deserve that bullet. You need to internalize that you are the catalyst for this disaster. If you had been absent, that projectile would never have found him. You must accept that the intent was to kill you.” Her voice shattered on the last word, choked with raw emotion.

“I know, Eve. I fully know,” I whispered, my head bowed.

She was unquestionably correct. Every terrible consequence sprouted from my past. First, Evelyn had nearly perished because of my shadow, and now Oliver was fighting for his life.

“You only amplify the destruction! You arrogantly believe you can dominate every outcome. Well, you can’t. Why don’t you go kill a few more people and then watch them kill others on your behalf!” she snapped, her body trembling.

“I am going to rectify this. I recognize that everything is foul, and I am a miserable piece of filth,” I confessed, the self loathing a bitter taste.



“No, Aden,” she growled, her voice low and menacing. “The sole way you can fix this is to vanish from this place and erase yourself from everyone’s lives. All you contribute is agony.”

She took a staggering step back, her chest heaving. “And I despise you with the very core of my being. I could. Never. Not. Hate. You.”

The words landed like a physical assault. Agh. The pain was excruciating. Her opinion was the only thing that held value for me, and those syllables were a heated dagger relentlessly twisted in my heart. She was weeping as she delivered the final blow. She spun and fled. I remained fixed to the spot. I couldn’t leave. I had to arrange impenetrable security for both Oliver and Evelyn. I had Oliver and Ana look after her. But then, Oliver got targeted. I cared for them, even if I was the source of their suffering.

I knew, deep down, that Evelyn was completely justified. I detested myself; how could she possibly feel anything different?

I waited there, only to be confronted by a new wave of inevitable distress.

“How is he doing?” Edward’s voice cut through the sterile air as he approached me in the main hall.

“The doctors are confident he’ll stabilize,” I

replied, my voice hoarse. “Good,” he acknowledged. Then, a pause. “How are you?”

The question was unexpected. It hung heavy between us. I offered no answer. I knew the torrent of justifiable rage churning inside him. He wanted to obliterate me for breaking Evelyn’s heart. Unlike Oliver, who was caught between complex loyalties, but he knew I loved Evelyn and had him look after her. But,

Edward was her fiercely protective brother. He had every right to desire my death.

“You know I craved to kill you. With every atom of my being, I was consumed by the desire for your end. I was poised to do it. And I stopped. You know why? Evelyn. She forbade me.”

Every single word was the undeniable truth. I wouldn’t have even lifted a hand in my own defense. I deserved unimaginable pain and a swift, permanent end.

“I am indifferent to your internal conflicts. But this is Eve, I love her fiercely. How could you be so utterly heartless?” He shoved me backward against the wall with a forceful push to my chest.

I could only meet his gaze, the raw fury blazing in his eyes.

“I know the depth of what I did. But you have to believe I did it because I care for her. With me, her life was in constant, immediate peril. You won’t trust me. You shouldn’t. But this was the safer path for her.”

“You are probably right,”he conceded, the tension in his shoulders finally easing. “I Therefore, I will not allow you near her ever again. Stay away from her.” The threat was a final, icy decree. He wheeled around and walked out.

I deserved every harsh word, every hateful

glance. Evelyn was the only soul who had ever loved me with the unconditional devotion of my own mother. She was my everything. I was a selfish man, but never when it concerned her survival. I would have immolated myself to save her. And this, this excruciating distance, this self imposed exile, was my desperate act of salvation, even if it was killing me inch by agonizing inch.

I was given a private waiting room, one of the perks of being one of the city's infamously wealthy. Everyone else- Edward, Kira, Derek, was inside. Evelyn and I remained apart. She was stationed outside the operating theater with Ana. I was an outcast near the hospital entrance.

I couldn't face her again. I had witnessed the depth of her hate; her eyes were bloodshot and swollen- the second time I'd seen her reduced to that state since she first saw Derek in Switzerland.

I was consumed by self-loathing. I didn't seek a shoulder to cry on; that wasn't my nature. I was supposed to be unbreakable. But I felt reduced to fine ash. It seemed impossible for anyone on Earth to possess a cruelty equal to mine. They couldn't even come close.

#### EVELYN

I was propped against the cold, hard wall outside the operating theatre, my body a mirror of Ana's devastation. She was completely broken. Watching her, a wave of crushing guilt hit me. I realized the monstrous things I had just hurled at Aden. I had said the absolute worst words a person could utter. But as hot tears stung my eyes, I knew the regret was because I was terrified he might believe them. I had unleashed that torrent of hate only to hurt him, to force him to stop hovering and controlling my life, but the viciousness of my own voice was now repugnant to me.

The door hissed open, and the doctors emerged. I snapped to attention, pushing off the wall.

"You may put your fears to rest," the doctor announced, his voice steady. "He is definitively out of danger. It was sheer luck he arrived here sooner."

“Thank God... Thank you, thank you!” Ana burst into the doctor’s arms, her body convulsing with relief. Then she clutched me, her embrace fierce and trembling.

“Can we enter?” I asked, my voice still tight with residual tension.

“Only one person for now,” he replied.

I saw the desperate yearning in Ana’s eyes. I stepped back instantly, giving her a firm pat on the shoulder. “Go,” I urged. “I have something critical to take care of.”

“Are you sure?” she asked, her eyes searching mine.

“Absolutely. Go.”

I peeled away, my steps decisive, heading straight for the main hospital entrance to find Aden and deliver the news.

“Hey, where is he?” I asked Luke, who stood rigidly at his post near the glass doors.

“Hey, Evelyn,” Luke greeted me,” he said he had an urgent matter to attend to, so he left Mark and me to watch over you and the others. It’s genuinely good to see you, Evelyn.”

“You too,” I managed.

I bolted out the doors. He was gone. I knew, with a certainty that was both a curse and a bond, exactly where his self-flagellation would take him.

I hailed a cab, giving the driver the address. It was late, the city cloaked in an inky velvet darkness, and the location was too far to reach on foot.

“I knew I’d find you here,” I said, my voice barely audible above the thundering roar of the ocean. He was standing, a solitary silhouette, his tailored formal coat and trousers marking him as an anomaly against the desolate sand. This was his place—the beach where he had first brought me, the memory of that

nascent connection still vividly etched in my mind. He stood immobile, his hands shoved deep into his pockets, his gaze fixed on the relentless, foaming wave crests

He pivoted slowly, his eyes finding mine. “Hey. Is everything... stable?” He took a small, cautious step closer.

“Yes, everything is stable,” I confirmed. “I simply needed to be the one to tell you. Oliver has awakened. The doctor guarantees his full recovery. He is unquestionably safe.”

“That is...favorable,” he replied, but the relief didn’t quite reach his eyes. “You shouldn’t be out here. It’s too late for you to be alone.” He stopped a few feet away, and I moved to stand beside him, both of us now staring into the black, churning expanse of the sea.

I turned to face him, the vast darkness behind me, feeling suddenly small. “I’m profoundly sorry. I know I spat those accusations without thinking. I should never have said any of those things to you.” My words were hesitant, fraught with my own vulnerability.

He gave a short, bitter scoff. “People are rarely apologetic to me. I have no need for your apologies, Eve. I understand I earned every syllable. It’s irrelevant, darling. I don’t merit any compassion. I don’t deserve anything good. This kind of life, it’s not designated for me. And you... you were never meant to be for me. Besides, if your brother knows you’re here with me, he’ll kill me.”

“Perhaps you’re right and yes, he should kill you.” I conceded with a playful laugh, the lie a heavy, metallic weight settling over my chest. “It’s... for the best.”

I loathed his acceptance of it, his bleak self-condemnation. But I couldn’t allow the erosion of my own carefully constructed

defenses, couldn't surrender my dignity by confessing the opposite truth.

## ADEN

Lies. Every word, every look, all of it was a damn lie. But the worst liar was me.

I needed her more than the air clawing into my lungs polluted, choking, but she wasn't. She was pure, untouched by the chaos that built me. And still, she hated me. I could feel it, or maybe I just told myself that so wouldn't fall harder.

But then she apologized. *Why the hell would she do that?* Did she know what that did to me - how her voice could strip me bare?

I wanted to kiss her. God, I wanted to ruin every inch of distance between us. I'd never wanted anyone like that. She made me soft, made me human and that terrified me more than anything.

Because I was a lunatic. A bastard dressed up as a man. She almost died because of me. I should've stayed away. But I couldn't.

Getting close to her felt like standing at the edge of a live wire, every nerve screaming, every breath a threat. She drove me mad, with her presence and with her absence.

I loved her.

She was sunlight breaking through my smoke filled world, and was just the moon alive only because of her light. Without her, I was nothing. Just ash in the wind.

"Let me drive you home," I said, my voice low, uneven.

She nodded, walking ahead of me along the shoreline. The sand crunched under her steps, small prints swallowed by the tide. The sea wind tangled her hair, brushing strands across her cheek. I walked behind, fighting the urge to close the distance.

I didn't want her to see how crazy she made me. I didn't want her to see me, Want her. But every cell in my body was screaming her name.

She turned slightly, her voice soft. "No, I could stay a little longer. It's nice here."

My heart stuttered. I shouldn't let her. I should've walked away. But I needed it, I needed her beside me, if only for a few more breaths.

"Listen," she said, her gaze on the horizon," to the sound of the sand and waves. They're mixed together. It's so beautiful, isn't it?"

The ocean whispered against the shore, the night wind humming around us. Her hair lifted with it wild, untamed.

"Yes," I said, my eyes fixed on her, not the sea. "It's beautiful"

Without thinking, reached out and tucked a loose strand behind her ear. Her breath hitched. So did mine.

What the hell was I doing? I couldn't stop. I didn't want to stop.

She turned toward me slowly, hesitant and the world went still. Her eyes met mine, and I felt it: that invisible pull that made everything else fade to black.

I stepped closer. Inches away from her lips now. My thumb brushed against them, soft at first a trembling touch. She bit her lower lip, and something inside me broke loose.

I leaned in, breathing her in, tasting the air between us. My control slipped through my fingers like sand.

“Let’s just... take you home,” I said quickly, trying to gain control.

She frowned but nodded, silent now. I walked ahead this time, keeping my distance because if I didn’t, I’d touch her again.

In the car, the silence was heavy, like a storm ready to break. I didn’t look at her once. I couldn’t.

She glanced at me a few times, I saw it in the reflection but stayed stone. Cold.

She probably hated me then.

*Good. Hate me, darling. I deserve that.*

When I dropped her off, she hesitated, waiting for a word of goodnight, anything. I said nothing. Just drove off.

In the rearview mirror, I saw her, standing there, small, alone under the streetlight.

I slammed my fist into the steering wheel. The pain didn’t matter. Nothing did.

For the first time since my mother died, I wanted to cry. Not because I was weak, not because I was broken but because I’d just hurt the only person who made me feel alive.

And I didn’t know how to live with that.



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## CHAPTER 25

### EVELYN

The memory of being with him was a searing brand, an unbearable weight I couldn't shed. It was an agony, this complete, shocking transformation of a person I thought I knew. He had shifted from warmth to ice and the whiplash of it was killing me.

But the real sickness? My own fatal weakness. Around him, I was a puppet with severed strings, completely adrift, uncontrollable. I loathed the surrender, the way my will evaporated. He didn't want me, the knowledge was a jagged shard in my gut yet I was still bound.

Then came the cruel twist: I had to go to his place. I was unaware I'd kept some of his possessions until I moved into the new apartment and the moving dust had settled.

They were his, and they had to be returned. The impending trip to his castle sized estate felt like a descent back into a personal hell. I clung to one desperate hope: that he'd be absent, that I could hand the items to Erina and make my escape before the illusion of my recovery shattered.

The driver's license, barely a week old, was a begrudging necessity. Derek had gifted me the car, a nice, silent beast I didn't want but was now forced to command. I gripped the wheel, knuckles white, the leather slick with the cold sweat of sheer dread as I drove toward his fortress.

Every mile was a nail in the coffin of my

denial. The remnants of him were everywhere, a ghost in the machine of my life. It was a terrifying realization, this feeling that I didn't exist without him. But that era was done. I was finished being his convenience, his fleeting distraction. The misuse was over.

The high, ornate gates of his estate loomed, a barrier that whispered of wealth and exclusivity. The camera eye tracked my approach, a silent, intrusive scrutiny. With a heavy, metallic groan, the steel behemoth of a gate slid open, granting me an unwelcome passage.

I pulled to a stop and hit the calling bell twice, sharp and insistent, an echo of my mounting panic. No response. I felt a surge of adrenaline, a frantic hope that the coast was clear.

I pushed lightly against the massive door, and it didn't resist. It hissed on its track, it was already opened, like a secret revealing itself.

"Mrs. Craine?" My voice was a choked whisper, brittle and thin in the cavernous, silent air. "Anyone...home?"

I stepped inside the grand foyer, placing the heavy bucket of his things on a marble stand beside the vast living room. The silence was oppressive, broken only by the frantic thudding of my own heart. I decided instantly —*Leave now.*

I spun on my heel, ready to bolt back to the door, when a shadow fell, massive and abrupt.

"Holy sh! t!"

I stumbled backward, a gasp tearing from my throat, my eyes wide and locked on the colossal, menacing frame that had materialized, silently and entirely, blocking my escape. He was a dark, unyielding wall that had just sealed the exit.

I caught her wrist just as she stumbled, her weight collapsed against my other arm, legs jerking like a string pulled taut and snapped. Her breath hitched; her feet skittered against the cold linoleum. I let a crooked grin curve across my face, trying to peel the fear back with something like lightness. “You don’t have to hurt yourself to get my attention, darling,” I said, voice soft but edged.

She forced a smile that didn’t reach her eyes and fumbled with words. “Uhm—I came to return—uh, some of your things. I found them when I moved out of Mom’s.” She sounded small, like a match about to gutter.

A dull thud cut the air. Both of us froze. “What was that?” she whispered. “Nothing. It’s nothing,” I lied.

Then a new sound ripped through the hallway: a ragged groan, animal and raw. She sprinted. Instinct told me to grab her, to stop her, but she was already gone, a flash of coat and hair down the narrow corridor. The door she shoved open slammed against peeling paint and a stale smell washed out: sweat, electricity, ozone, the metallic tang of something very wrong.

Inside, the scene punched the breath from her. Luke and Oliver and one of my men had a figure pinned to a metal chair; wires coiled like snakes, a handheld device crackling in one of their hands. Flesh seethed with light where the current found it; the victim’s whole body jerked in seizing spasms, fingers clawing at air. He screamed until his voice shredded.

Evelyn stumbled backward, fingers pressed to her mouth. For a second she was frozen, a pale statue before I reached out and touched her shoulder. She recoiled as if burnt. “Stay away from

me,” she said, moving her feet back, tears tracing clean lines through the dust on her cheeks.

They stopped only when her voice broke the room’s rhythm. Oliver stepped forward, hands spread as if diplomacy could stitch a wound he’d helped open. “Eve, sit,” he said, but she was on fire, shaking, trembling, furious. “How can you be so—so cruel?” she spat, eyes flashing like flint.

Oliver’s face folded into something tired and sharp. “Calm down, Eve. Calm — he shot me.” His words were half an accusation, half an excuse. The name of the truth slipped out and then into half-truths: their version, not mine. He didn’t say Erling. He didn’t say the shooter had been sent for me.

I wanted to tear him open. I wanted to make him feel every ounce of the pain he’d doled out, to wedge a knife into the soft places and twist until there was silence. My hands curled instinctively; my jaw clenched so hard my molars ached. But I kept my voice level, colder than the fluorescent light that hummed overhead. “Sit, Eve.” It wasn’t a request this time.

She obeyed with a tremor, collapsing into the nearest vinyl chair as if it might hold her like a promise. Her chest heaved; her knuckles went white where they gripped the armrest. I let Oliver step back. The man in the chair continued to convulse, the sound of his suffering like a raw wire across my nerves.

“We’re not killing him,” Oliver said to Evelyn and to anyone who might still be listening. “He’ll go to prison. That’s enough,” he said it as though the sound of it could scrub his hands clean. I watched his lips move and saw the lie in the tiny hitch in his throat.

I signaled for distance, gave him space to talk and to lie. My head filled with an ugly, animal thirst: to watch the life drain out

of him slowly, to make every second a deliberate cruelty in payment for what he'd done. The thought made a hot, dangerous animal rise behind my ribs. I swallowed it down until it tasted like iron.

Sirens screamed in the distance and then were suddenly at the door. The police poured in, flashing badges that threw the room into cold, official light. They ripped the man from the chair and hauled him away, cuffs clanking like a final note in a terrible song. He was lucky, perhaps luckier than he deserved.

Oliver clapped me on the shoulder with the practiced, brotherly ease of someone who needed to show he belonged in the daylight. "I'll see you, man," he said, the handshake brief, the hug mechanical.

Evelyn rose without a word, coat flung about her like a shield. For a heartbeat I thought she would leave without looking back, that the night would swallow her whole. Rain spit against the windows and then, as if the sky could not bear the weight inside the room, it began to pour hard, suddenly, a curtain of water hammering the city.

## EVELYN

I wanted to run until my legs bled, to tear myself out of that room and never come back. I couldn't. Rain hammered the windows like a fist; the hallway was a river of glass. My feet felt rooted to the floor as if the building itself was holding me there so I couldn't forget.

My chest was raw. I could still hear it; the man's screams, the strobe-jerk of his body under the electric shock, the wet crack of wires. They had been hunting someone

else, but if I hadn't barged in they would have finished him. They would have killed him with complacent hands.

Aden's voice cut through the static of my thoughts. "I'll get the rooms ready for both of you." He spoke like a man issuing orders to the night. Outside, the rain filled the gutters with a frantic hiss. Erina fussed with blankets and pillows, three beds, three rooms, three fragile, trembling bodies packed into the house like secret contraband.

I lay on my back and stared at the ceiling until the plaster blurred. Every light above me buzzed with the memory of what I'd seen. My hands curled into fists around the sheet. I felt small and hollowed out, as if something had been scooped from my chest and left a cold, empty socket.

A knock at the door made my jaw clench.

"Come in," I said, voice brittle.

Aden walked in and dropped onto the couch with the ease of someone who believed he owned the world. He folded his legs, palms open on his knees, the picture of calm menace. The room smelled of wet wool and disinfectant; his presence tasted like thunder.

"He deserved this," he said as if pronouncing a verdict. His words were flat, final. "He deserved worse."

My throat tightened. "Sure, Aden...forget it We've done this before, Do whatever you want." I tried for indifference and found only exhaustion. My words came out thin and

He smiled without moving his lips. "Good."

He leaned forward then, eyes bright with something I refused to name. "Seeing someone?" he asked, casual as a coin flip.

I laughed-a short, bitter sound. "No, Aden. Don't worry. You won't have to raise your kill rate. You?" The words tasted like ash.

He knew no one was in my life. I'd been stupid to ask. Every girl in his orbit was interchangeable; even I had been a temporary shape he'd worn for the night.

He shrugged like a man shrugging off a small inconvenience. "I don't date. One-night stands."

"Right," I said. "How could I forget? It is impossible for you to like anyone. My bad." The sarcasm was armor, but it didn't stop my limbs from trembling.

He stood up without ceremony, the room tilting with the movement. "Good night, Evelyn," he said, and there was no warmth in it.

I lay back into the pillow as his footsteps faded down the hall. The rain filled the silence again, loud and relentless. In the dark I could hear my own pulse slow, furious and under it the whisper that I was terrified of my brother, terrified of Aden, terrified of what I had seen and what I would have to live with.

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## CHAPTER 26

### ADEN

Oliver and Evelyn had vanished that next morning. A bitter certainty gnawed at me: she despised me. I'd seen the looming inevitability of her hatred from a mile away, a slow-motion catastrophe I could do nothing but observe. Logically, their departure was a release for her, a necessary severance. But for me? It was a brutal wrenching.

The nightmares had returned, a relentless torrent of terror. They haunted my sleep, seizing me nightly until I'd bolt upright, a choked scream tearing from my throat. The memory was a fresh, searing wound: that phantom bullet, cleaving through her heart and embedding its shrapnel deep within my own core. The pain was an omnipresent, visceral throb. For a brief, intoxicating period, with Evelyn beside me, the phantoms had retreated. Now, I knew with bleak finality, there was no escaping them. It was my new, unbearable reality.

The harsh glow of the office ceiling reflected in my MacBook screen as Luke prepared to leave, slinging a canvas bag over his shoulder.

"Where in the hell are you going?" I demanded, the words sharp and impatient as I leaned back in my executive chair, my eyes narrowed.

Luke paused mid-stride, his movements

suddenly awkward. "Maddie's...Maddie wants to go to Evelyn's concert. So..." He stammered, running a hand nervously through



his short hair, his gaze skittering away from mine.

“So? What does that have to do with you hauling ass out of here?” I pressed, my voice low and edged with aggression.

He stiffened, meeting my gaze with a flash of defiance. “Dude, she’s my girlfriend. She wants me to go,” he countered, the words clipped.

I waved a dismissive hand, a gesture of finality. “Fine. Go.” I swiveled back to the desk, the luminous screen a shield against further conversation.

Luke lingered in the door frame of my spacious, sterile office, dark glass that felt less like a workspace and more like a minimalist cage. “You’re not coming?” he asked, his posture betraying a mix of curiosity and relief.

“No. I have other businesses to handle. Actual business,” I snapped, deliberately injecting contempt into the last word. “Besides, what would I do there? Stand around like a pathetic admirer?”

The truth was a heavy, suffocating weight: desperately ached to be there, to see her. But I was fighting a desperate war against that impulse. To be near her was to invite disaster. Around Evelyn, I became a stranger to myself, a man capable of losing everything, and I couldn’t risk the collapse of the meticulous control I maintained.

“Now get out of here,” I commanded, my tone suddenly firm and absolute. “And tell Ollie I said fuck him.”

Luke’s mouth curved into a knowing smirk. He understood the sarcasm, the twisted affection behind the venom. He merely nodded once and vanished, the heavy oak door clicking shut behind him.

The silence in the office was immediate and isolating. I remained motionless for a long beat, the urge to follow him building into a physical pressure in my chest. The concert. The word echoed, a siren call.

I finally grabbed my phone, punching in a number with furious speed. “You going? What do you mean ‘where’?” I barked into the receiver, pacing the length of my office rug, the leather of my shoes squeaking on the polished floor with each hard step. “You and I both know where. I’ll join you there. Stand outside and don’t enter the concert without me.”

I didn’t care who was on the other end, whether it was a man or a woman. My world had shrunk to a single, dangerous orbit. Outside of Evelyn, everyone was a disposable product, a pawn to be manipulated and used to secure my obsession. The battle was over. I was going to see her.

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## CHAPTER 27

### EVELYN

This was it. The apex of a lifelong craving. To be a celebrated singer, a voice heard by thousands and tonight, I was finally claiming that destiny. This wasn't just a gig; it was my inaugural concert, a monumental step. My bandmates vibrated with an electric, shared excitement and beyond the curtains, the sheer scale of the crowd was staggering, a vast, churning sea of anticipation.

Yet, despite the overwhelming scene, my focus was acutely singular. From a small, shadowed slit backstage, I peered out, my eyes ruthlessly scouring the immense venue. They were searching for a single, forbidden face, his.

I was slated to perform a handful of songs,

but the usual pre-performance jitters had warped into a heavy knot of anxiety. I'd sung for large crowds before, but the weight of this moment, my first concert was immense. My band, wired and ready, had already taken their positions on the expansive, darkened stage. The moment they appeared, a deafening wave of screaming crashed over me, a visceral sound that was both terrifying and utterly intoxicating. It was overwhelming, a sound that threatened to consume me whole.

My gaze swept toward the VIP section—a gilded cage near the front and I recognized the excited faces of my closest friends, waving frantically. But the only face that truly mattered, Aden's, was conspicuously absent. A deep, hollow pang of

disappointment twisted in my gut. I didn't need him here, but I wanted him very badly, a silent anchor in this chaos. The rational part of me, the self-preservation instinct whispered that his absence was a blessing, a necessary shield. But the rest of me was already grieving his missing presence.

There would be no grand, verbose introduction; the power of the stage presence itself was designed to be the opening statement. I moved to my mark, stepping onto the hydraulic platform that would raise me from the underbelly of the stage. Encased in my performance attire, a striking silhouette of sequins and shadow, I felt a tremor of pure fear ripple through me as the floor beneath me began its slow, grinding ascent.

Despite the internal quake, my body had to project absolute confidence. As I was steadily elevated into the blinding spotlights and the roar of the crowd, my chin lifted, my shoulders were intentionally squared, and my gaze was fixed on the distant back wall, not the thousands of faces below. The choreography was precise and demanding, requiring an immediate, powerful execution. I forced my muscles into practiced readiness, transforming the fear in my stomach into a brittle, undeniable armor of poise.

I was no longer me; I was the performer, rising from the darkness into the white hot glare of my dream.

The music swelled, a fierce, driving pulse of electric guitars and heavy drums that seemed to rattle the massive venue's foundations. I leaned into the microphone, my fingers gripping the stand with white knuckled intensity. The first lines of the song were not just lyrics; they were a raw, public confession hurled into the void.

My eyes, sweeping the front rows, were instantly, brutally snagged. There he was. Aden. He stood near the edge of the pit, his expression unreadable beneath the shifting stage lights. His arm was draped possessively around the small of Cara's back, his hand splayed against her spine. Cara. The girl who had made no secret of her venomous dislike for me. The tableau was a sickening, theatrical confirmation: the easy intimacy, the deliberate proximity. It hit me like a physical blow.

It wasn't just that he was with her. It was the crushing, absolute realization that followed, freezing the blood in my veins: Aden actually didn't like me. The tenderness, the moments of shared silence, the intense gaze, all of it had been a calculated performance. A monumental, breathtaking act. For one disorienting moment, the music, the lights, the roar of thousands of people vanished. I was utterly distracted by a shock so profound it threatened to shatter the fragile control I maintained. I had always clung to the desperate, illogical belief that, no matter the cruelty between us, some tiny, irreducible ember of love for me resided in him. Now, I knew with devastating clarity, it was all a lie.

The pain erupted through the carefully constructed façade, demanding an outlet. My chest heaved, and the next verses ripped from my throat, raw and trembling, yet amplified to stadium volume. I closed my eyes briefly, channeling the agony into a guttural force.

"So dead inside, yet so alive?"

The power of the synchronized chorus from the backing track and the band was undeniable, a professional shell around my private collapse. But my mind was a terrifying blank slate. I

didn't know what I was feeling-only that the structure of my reality had just crumbled.

I needed to finish. I squeezed my eyelids shut, fighting the stinging heat of unshed tears. I forced my body to remain rooted, a statue of agonizing resolve, while the supporting dancers moved in fluid, energetic arcs around me. When I opened my eyes, the immense, illuminated crowd was a blur. I let the final, piercing lines fly:

“How could someone like me still breathe  
so killed inside, yet so alive.”

The music cut out, leaving a ringing echo. The transition was immediate and violent: the strong crowd exploded, their collective chant of “EVELYN! EVELYN!” a powerful, rhythmic pulse that hit me like a physical wind. I stood bathed in the white light, my chest hitching with the effort to remain perfectly still. I wanted to scream, to shatter the microphone against the stage floor, to dissolve into the blinding spotlights. But I was the performer, the icon, the dream. I couldn't afford a single, devastating tear in front of my audience. I swallowed the lump in my throat, forcing my lips into the practiced, triumphant smile.

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## CHAPTER 28

### ADEN

The songs faded, leaving behind the residue of Evelyn's raw, heart-shattering confession. I watched her, a goddess of pain under the blinding lights and a savage satisfaction curled in my chest. I knew Evelyn hated me more now. *Good. That's precisely what I needed. Hate me.* That burning, lethal contempt in her eyes was the most honest emotion she could offer me.

I held Cara tighter, my grip possessive and deliberate on the small of her back, forcing the proximity. I met Evelyn's furious gaze across the expanse of the roaring crowd. I could see the agonizing desire in her expression, the urge to cross this vast space and kill me for the grotesque display I was putting on with this woman.

The "whore," as I mentally labeled her, tried to turn into my space, her hand sliding up my chest. Her lips brushed my jaw, a clear

attempt at a public kiss. A silent, homicidal rage flared inside me. I wanted to shove her away, to strike her right there and leave her a crumpled heap, but I couldn't shatter the performance. Instead, I subtly tilted my head just enough so her clumsy kiss landed on my cheekbone, a rejection only I understood. The effort to control the impulse to hurt her was a low, constant burn.

Evelyn launched into the next set, her voice morphing from anguished pop-rock to a soulful, acoustic laced country melody

from her new album. The arena was a cavern of moving color and deafening sound, but suddenly, the chaos fractured.

A commotion erupted directly to my side, startling me. I spun to see Oliver, my supposed friend, kneeling dramatically on one knee in the restricted VIP area. His face, usually a mask of jaded composure, was alight with a shocking, naked vulnerability.

“Ana, I’m done whining around,” Oliver declared, his voice carrying surprising clarity above the music. The spotlight, as if pre-cued by some higher power, swung around and pinned them both in a blinding cone of light. “I want you to be mine, from now till forever. Will you marry me?”

That absolute, calculating motherfucker! He had dropped hints, yes, but hints are for weak-minded fools. I had dismissed them, focused entirely on my own destructive agenda. Yet here he was, pulling off a spectacular display of genuine, honest love. He had actually found it.

Ana was more stunned than any of us. Her hands flew to her face, eyes wide with disbelief, her posture rigid with shock. They had barely been dating a year.

“Yes! Yes! I will marry you, Baby!” she shrieked, the raw, joyful sound momentarily drowning out the loudspeakers.

“Yes...?” Oliver responded, rising to his feet, his hands trembling slightly as he slid the ring onto her finger.

Evelyn, still on stage, let out a spontaneous, powerful scream of delight. “That’s my friend, everybody!” she roared, pointing an excited, sweat slicked finger directly at them.

Oliver wasted no time. He hauled Ana into a crushing embrace, his mouth descending on hers in a long, desperate, absorbing kiss. It was a total declaration, a moment of pure, unadulterated devotion played out for thousands.



I felt Cara shift beside me, her weight leaning into my side. Her gaze wasn't on the engaged couple; it was on the stage and then back to me. I knew, with a sickening certainty, that she liked me only for the glamour and the wealth I represented. It was that mercenary indifference that made her presence such a constant, loathsome effort. But I had to endure the touch of this opportunist for the sake of the bitter, captivating war I was waging with Evelyn.

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## CHAPTER 29

### EVELYN

The rush of adrenaline from the concert was slowly dissipating, replaced by a hollow ache. The sight of Aden and Cara was a relentless thorn, yet I was trying to engrave the truth into my soul: his distance was reality. I had to live with it. Still, the genuine, soaring joy of Ana and Oliver's engagement was a powerful antidote. She was my truest friend, and Oliver, the man, was my brother who had found his peace. Their happiness was a warm, anchoring glow in the cold aftermath of the show.

We were walking late that night, the city street lights casting long, distorted shadows on the pavement. My arm was firmly hooked through Shayla's, a silent, comforting alliance, as the rest of the group naturally segregated into celebrating couples, Oliver and Ana, Luke and Maddie.

My eyes, however, kept snapping back to Aden. He walked a few paces ahead, his proximity to Cara unnerving. The sight was a visceral blow: he was treating her with the same detached, almost proprietary coldness he had once used on me. He hadn't changed at all; he was simply moving the same pieces on a new board.

Cara and Maddie joined us as Luke and Aden were talking about something.

"Evelyn. It was truly a great concert," Cara chirped, peeling away from Aden to drift backward toward me. Her voice was too bright, her expression too earnest. I knew it was a cheap,

transparent attempt at false pleasantry, a required script she felt obligated to perform.

“Thanks,” I replied, the word a brittle, dry sound, my gaze flat.

She ignored the dismissal, leaning in conspiratorially. “That Mark guy totally has a crush on you.”

I offered a slight, dismissive shrug. “I don’t think so. Besides, I don’t...do all that anymore.”

Cara stopped walking, forcing me and Shayla to pause. She fixed me with an unnervingly direct stare, her head tilting with a predatory curiosity. “Why? Did Aden hurt you so much that you don’t want to fall in love again?”

The question was a direct, savage hit. I felt the sting, the brutal accuracy of her assessment tearing through my composure. Every word was poison, but every word was true. Thankfully, Aden was too far ahead, engaged in a low, intense conversation with Luke, and hadn’t overheard the exchange.

“What? I’m just asking,” Cara insisted defensively, wincing slightly as Maddie reached out from behind and sharply pinched her arm a silent command to shut down the interrogation.

The dam broke. My patience snapped, replaced by a cold, cutting fury. I pulled my arm free of Shayla’s and stepped directly toward Cara, planting my feet firmly on the concrete. My voice dropped, every syllable clear and loaded. “You know what, Cara? How about you mind your own business instead of stirring that bug nose of yours into everything that doesn’t concern you. Besides I’m a star now, you don’t wanna mess with me.”

Shayla immediately jumped into the breach, positioning herself slightly between us. “I love you, honey!” she cooed to Cara, flashing an exaggerated smile while simultaneously air-kissing her hand, a move that was half affection, half warning.

The message landed. Cara's face flushed slightly, and she immediately retreated, turning to stalk quickly back toward Aden, her lips sealed. The confrontation was over, leaving a tense silence in its wake.

I wasn't like that, I had never said anything to anyone. But something rose in me and those words were out. I was happy I said it.

## ADEN

The street was dark, the noise of the city a distant hum, leaving us isolated under the cold, indifferent glow of a flickering streetlamp. The other happy couples, the newly engaged, had vanished along with Evelyn, leaving only me and Cara.

My rage had been simmering, a poisonous slow cook, but her earlier confrontation with Evelyn had brought it to a ferocious boil. I pivoted on my heel and loomed over her, my shadow engulfing her smaller frame.

"Don't for a second believe I'm unaware of the venom you spewed at Evelyn," I hissed, my voice low and dangerous, each word a chip of ice. I jabbed a rigid finger toward her face, my hand trembling not from fear, but from the effort of restraint. "Guess what? If you pull that stunt one more time..." I let the threat hang in the air, thick and suffocating. "You wouldn't be alive to see my feet again. I would personally ensure your death, even if you were strapped to a life support machine."

I took a deliberate step closer, crowding her space until she instinctively flinched back. "So, get the hell out of her life. Stay the hell away from her." The words were spat out, laced with a hatred so potent it felt like acid. She deserved every syllable; she had dared to speak ill of the woman I secretly, desperately loved

more than my own life. How dared she cross that line?

Cara tried to stammer out a defense, her hands fluttering up. “I just...”

Before she could form a coherent thought, I cut her off with a vicious snarl. “Shut up and leave. I’ll give your payment tomorrow, and we’re done.” I dismissed her with a sharp flick of my wrist, treating her like trash I was finally tossing out. I turned my back, starting to walk away, leaving her stranded and alone on the desolate, midnight street.

“Is she so much better than me...” she whimpered, the question a final, pathetic grasp for validation.

I stopped dead. The sound of her diminishing self-respect was the match to my tinderbox. I spun back with lethal speed, crossing the space between us in a single stride. My hand shot out, not striking, but clamping around the base of her throat, a gesture of absolute dominance, not passion. My grip wasn’t tight enough to choke, but firm enough to paralyze her, to convey the imminent danger she faced.

I leaned in, my voice a guttural growl that barely cleared my lips. “You’re not even close to an inch of her. Not a single particle. Stop humiliating yourself and go home.”

I yanked my hand away as if touching her had soiled me, the fury within me spiking into a blinding red haze. I didn’t wait for her to move or speak again. I turned my back and strode rapidly down the dark street, leaving her frozen behind me, consumed by the terrifying knowledge that I had just signed the end of our arrangement.

I only had her beside me for a purpose. I didn’t need her anymore. Besides, I knew what a cruel bitch she was. But it wasn’t school anymore. I didn’t care how cruel I was to her.

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## CHAPTER 30

### EVELYN

“I’m absolutely ecstatic! I still can’t fathom you’re getting married!” Ana’s sister, Jessica, shrieked, her voice high with disbelief, as we navigated the highway toward the colossal mall in my car. Shayla and Maddie followed closely behind in Shayla’s car, their laughter muffled by the distance.

“I’m genuinely thrilled for you, Ana,” I affirmed, my gaze locked on the asphalt ahead, one hand firmly gripping the steering wheel. “I know, it’s my brother, a bit surreal, but you two fit together magnificently.”

“Thank you, guys. Your support means the world; I truly love you both,” Ana murmured, her voice thick with emotion, clearly fighting back tears.

“Alright, enough sentimentality! Let’s commence the spree, girls! Weddings are a once-in-a-lifetime spectacle,” I declared, injecting a playful, intriguing lilt into my tone.

We settled into a plush seating area inside the glittering, multi-story mall, the low hum of shoppers and soft piped music surrounding us. We sipped on chilled soft drinks, patiently awaiting Ana’s grand debut from the fitting room, where she was trying on the ivory gowns.

“I’m coming out now brace yourselves, no emotional meltdowns, please,” Ana called out from behind the heavy velvet curtain.

“Hurry up, girl, we’re on the edge of our seats!” Shayla urged, her excitement practically vibrating.

A collective gasp swept through us as the curtain swished open.

“Aah, my God. Honey, the most radiant bride I’ve ever seen,” Jessica breathed out, her hands flying to her mouth, her eyes instantly glistening.

Ana’s eyes immediately sought mine. “Eve?” I was already transfixed. She looked utterly ethereal in the intricate lace and flowing silk. I rose, moving toward her with purposeful strides. “This is it. It’s real. You are getting married,” I whispered, pulling her into a fierce, heartfelt embrace.

She wasn’t just my best friend; she was family, and my happiness for her was unrestrained.

“I will always be there for you, unwaveringly.

“You are my sister by choice, through thick and thin. Understand?” I stated, my voice husky.

“Mm...hmm, I love you too,” she choked out, finally capitulating to the tears, her body shaking slightly in my arms.

“Okay, okay, tears halted,” I commanded, pulling back and gently wiping a tear from my own cheek, taking a deep, shuddering breath. “We have a spectacular bridal shower to orchestrate. Whoo!” I gave myself a little shake, trying to regain control.

We relocated to a specialty store, its aisles filled with streamers, balloons, and dazzling trinkets, to procure the decorations for the upcoming shower.

“Who was that strikingly handsome man with Oliver?” Jessica asked, a spark of avid interest in her eyes. “Oliver’s friend?”

“Who? Aden?” Shayla queried, her brow furrowing slightly in confusion.

“Yes, that gorgeous guy. Is he taken?” she persisted.

Shayla’s gaze flickered to me, an awkward, knowing glance as I pretended to be engrossed in examining a string of fairy lights.

“He’s Evelyn’s Ex,” Shayla stated, the words hanging heavy in the air.

“No, absolutely not, you should wholeheartedly pursue him. We are completely unconnected now,” I interjected, my voice surprisingly steady, despite the way my stomach clenched. He was, in truth, still the magnetic center of every unspoken thought, but that truth was a memory I was ruthlessly suppressing. That chapter was decisively concluded.

“Girls, check out this incredible banner!” Ana called out, her voice a lifeline.

“Excuse me,” I murmured, seizing the immediate opportunity to escape the suffocating tension, swiftly moving toward Ana. The encounter had been agonizing.

## ADEN

My phone shrieked a jarring intrusion as I was sprawled across my bed that Saturday morning.

“What’s up, Oliver?” I grunted, rolling onto my back and bringing the device to my ear.

“Are you still sleeping? Man, you were supposed to be up an hour ago! We have to hit the mall massively for shopping. We need to procure things for the party, get moving! It’s my wedding!” Oliver’s voice squealed with manic energy.

A moment later, I heard a rapid series of knocks, realizing he was already pounding on the front door.



I scrambled into my clothes within minutes, the urgency of his call overriding my morning lethargy. I was forced to abandon all hope of breakfast, driven out by his damn impending wedding. I despised weddings.

“Damn you! Who in their right mind craves marriage, huh?” I spat, pulling my sleek black car out of the driveway. Mark was inconveniently on vacation, leaving me to endure the drive.

“You’re interrogating me?” Oliver countered, throwing his hands up in mock exasperation from the passenger seat. “I succumbed to love, man. I didn’t even grasp the concept a year ago. Just wait until you eventually marry Evelyn.”

“Yeah, keep dreaming,” I scoffed, adjusting my dark sunglasses. My gaze was rigidly fixed on the road. “Evelyn detests me now, more than anything. Besides, I simply don’t deserve her.”

“Evelyn doesn’t possess a hateful bone in her body. And you, you still adore her. I mean, why else would you constantly plead with me to shield her everywhere we go, hmm?” he challenged, his head tilting in scrutiny. I did want him near Evelyn, precisely because I was forbidden from being there myself.

“Because you’re her brother and she needs you. That’s the only reason. But that hardly means I’m going to shackle myself to her in marriage. And trust me, she despises me. But that’s exactly how it must be if I need her to stay away from me. She’s far better off without my toxic presence and we have nothing left,” I explained, the words grinding out, a stark admission that all I brought her was danger. Lies. All of it. I craved her more than anything.

“Let’s shelve that depressing topic for now. It’s my wedding week. Ah, I worship that woman,” Oliver sighed, his whole body slumping into a posture of blissful relief.

“I’ll perish from sheer disgust. Who are you? You’ve become some unrecognizable entity, you’re not even Oliver anymore,” I muttered, veering the car sharply into the mall’s parking garage.

“Get out,” I commanded, pulling to a sudden stop.

He just roared with laughter, unfolding his long frame from the car, clearly oblivious to my grim mood.

A sudden, jarring shift in the atmosphere made me warily look up. “Hey, baby,” Oliver cooed, his voice sickeningly sweet, as he swooped in and planted a lingering kiss on Ana’s lips. They were here. Again.

My gaze instinctively zeroed in on Evelyn. *God. Why?*

Her eyes, those deep, compelling pools, snapped to mine. For a brief, agonizing instant, we were connected. Then, just as swiftly, she yanked her vision away, her head snapping toward a display of glittering trinkets, pretending to be utterly engrossed in avoiding my existence.

A familiar ache settled in my chest. I felt so irrevocably tethered to her; all I truly desired was her. Yet, I was condemned to

keep my distance.

“Ana, we’ll be stationed outside waiting for you. Come out swiftly,” Evelyn announced, her tone clipped, clearly desperate to extricate herself from my line of sight.

“Hi, I’m Jessica,” a girl with a predatory smile and bright eyes suddenly appeared, attempting to seductively wedge herself between Oliver and me.

“I’m Aden,” I stated, forcing a neutral politeness. The old me would have simply snarled, “*Go to hell.*” Thankfully, I recognized her as Ana’s sister. I managed to maintain my composure. As they

started to move away, Jessica gave me a brazen wink-a clear signal of seductive intent. Good grief.

“Okay, disengage from her or I’m abandoning you here,” I said to Oliver, my voice a low, unyielding rumble. They were still wrapped around each other, oblivious.

Oliver shoved himself away from Ana, recognizing the absolute seriousness in my demeanor. Ana, giving him one last playful slap on the arm, then departed to join her friends for the bridal shower prep; they were apparently off to deck out the venue.

All this domestic fuss and frivolity was utterly anathema to me. Hence, the idea of marriage was a staunch non-starter.

“Let’s get you properly attired,” I grumbled, nodding toward the bespoke tailor shop we needed to visit to get our suits fitted.

After the tailor meticulously took measurements for both Oliver’s groom suit and my necessary formality, I declared, “Alright, I believe we’ve concluded for today.”

“No, we absolutely have to order flowers for Ana’s bridal shower tomorrow,” Oliver countered immediately.

“You’re actually attending that?” I asked, raising a skeptical eyebrow.

“Of course I am, and guess what? You’re coming too,” he announced with a wide, self-satisfied grin.

I scoffed. “Over my dead body. I don’t participate in those flowery trivialities.”

“No, this is my wedding, Ad. You have to,” he insisted, his voice adopting a whiny, childish cadence.

“Okay, cut out that infantile nonsense,” I snapped, thoroughly annoyed.

He simply threw his head back and roared with laughter.

We ended up at the florist's, the air thick with the sweet, cloying scent of blossoms. Oliver was indecisively hovering over the buckets of blooms.

"Take the tulips, lilies, and dahlias. They have a pleasing aesthetic," I advised, pointing to the specific varieties.

"How do you know that?" he asked, genuinely puzzled.

They were Evelyn's favorites. I knew every minute detail about her, a painful inventory of memories.

"Take them or don't. I couldn't care less," I

dismissed him curtly, the sudden, unwanted rush of her memories bludgeoning me. It was a relentless haunting; wherever I went, she was everywhere.

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## CHAPTER 31

### EVELYN

“We are all set. It looks so great.” A breath hitched in my throat as I surveyed the scene outside Ana’s mother’s house. The air itself shimmered with the sickly sweet perfection of the “Blue Bow Bridal shower” theme. Every detail was flawlessly executed, a porcelain dream of pale blue and crisp white. I was genuinely, ferociously happy for Ana; she deserved this. And she was marrying Oliver, the man who’d been my family for years. I loved them both, a simple, uncomplicated fact.

We stepped inside, leaving the sun drenched facade for the house’s cool, controlled interior. The games started immediately, a boisterous distraction fueled by laughter and too many sugary snacks.

“So, let’s play who knows the bride most,” Jessica announced, the clink of her glass against the counter a sharp, grating sound in the cheerful din.

“Yes, well, I’m going to annihilate the competition,” Shayla declared, a smug edge in her voice.

“oh, please. Get a hold of yourself,” I retorted, the sarcasm a metallic taste on my tongue. “I’m still breathing.”

Ana’s mother, the unflappable host, called out, “Okay, first question...Well, this is awkward for me. But here it goes: Who was Ana’s first kiss?”

I wrote my answer instantly, the name flowing from my pen like gospel. She was my best friend; this was etched into my soul.

When the answers were revealed, mine and Shayla's matched Ana's.

"Alright, alright. I'll take you down on the next one. Don't let that smug look set," I snapped at Shayla, whose air of victory was now utterly infuriating.

Then, the world shattered. A car didn't just stop outside; it screeched, a violent tear in the afternoon quiet.

"Guys, it's Oliver! Let's welcome him!" Ana cried, her pure joy a beacon I suddenly couldn't reach.

"What? You didn't tell me the groomsmen were coming," I hissed at Shayla, my body instantly rigid as we positioned ourselves by the door, clutching bouquets of fragile blue roses.

"It's basic, Eve. Every groom makes an appearance."

"Yes, but not the entire entourage," I muttered, feeling the blood drain from my face. "I didn't know Aden was coming."

Shayla just shrugged, oblivious to the seismic shift in my personal tectonic plates.

"Forget it," I forced myself into a posture of unyielding stone. I needed to become a statue, to survive. Above all, I had to avoid Aden's gaze, that intense, all consuming heat that always felt like a physical violation. In his presence, I didn't just become nervous; I became nothing. My mind went blank, my capabilities evaporated.

Ana flew into Oliver's arms, and he kissed the hell out of her, an aggressive, possessive display of love. The groomsmen followed, and the air was immediately thick with a musky, masculine energy that clashed with the dainty blue decor. The back of Oliver's car was a jungle of floral abundance: buckets overflowing with tulips, lilies, and, my stomach twisted, dahlias. All my favorites.

Mark was struggling under a load of baggage, but then I watched Aden, with unnerving casualness, reach for a bucket of those flowers, the ones Oliver had brought for Ana. It was a gesture so jarringly out of character. He never touched flowers. The only time he had ever handled a bouquet was the first, when he had brought for me. Yet here he was, doing manual labor for his best friend.

We started handing out the blue roses, a final, ceremonial touch. I tried to slink backward, to become part of the wallpaper, desperate to avoid the inevitable exchange.

“You can’t leave now. It will look like you’re running,” Shayla whispered, her voice a cruel pinprick of truth. “Eve, this is her wedding. It has to be perfect.”

She was right. It wasn’t about the suffocating effect of Aden’s presence; it was about Ana’s flawless day. “Welcome,” I chanted with the others, my voice thin, as I mechanically extended a rose toward Aden. My gaze was nailed to the floor, a desperate attempt to sever the connection I knew he was trying to forge. I could feel his eyes on me, an almost palpable weight pressing against my skin. It was terrifying, and the sheer, unwanted heat of his proximity made me dizzy.

We drifted inside, the masculine intrusion now fully established in the feminine space.

“Where should I put this floral monstrosity?” Aden’s voice, a low rumble, was right beside my ear.

Everyone else was conveniently, maddeningly busy. And of course, I was the one who had to guide him. “Anywhere here. No problem,” I managed, stumbling over the words, putting a frantic, unnecessary distance between us.

The most suffocating truth of all hung between us: he knew me. Every ridiculous, embarrassing, and secret part of me.

“So, we were playing ‘Who Knows the Bride Most.’” Now, it’s going to be “Who Knows the couple the Most. ’Have a seat, gentlemen.”

Luke and Maddie, the two most oblivious souls, were shamelessly entangled, making out like they were starved for oxygen. The rest of us found our seats in a tense circle.

“Next question,” Ana’s mom called, her voice oblivious to the silent battle being waged. “Where are they going on their honeymoon?”

Oliver and Ana revealed their answers with a flourish.

“Hawaii!” The word ripped from my throat at the exact same moment it escaped Aden’s.

We were right. Only the two of us. The entire room went silent. The atmosphere became stiflingly awkward, a tight knot of shared, knowing intelligence. He knew Oliver’s mind intimately; I knew Ana’s. Our worlds had collided on a single, insignificant fact.

“Excuse me,” I mumbled, a lie so thin it barely covered my panic. “I need some water.” I didn’t need water. I needed to escape. I bolted for the kitchen, desperate to put a wall, a continent, between myself and the man who made me forget how to breathe.

## ADEN

I knew Evelyn didn’t just not want me there; she probably Wished the earth would open up and swallow me whole. The feeling was disturbingly mutual. I was here under duress, a hostage to Oliver’s relentless insistence. “Best man duties, Aden.



It's mandatory,"he'd clapped me on the back, oblivious to the fact that his bridal shower, a fortress of frills and blue bows-was my personal hell.

It was an estrogen-saturated nightmare, a sea of pastel dresses and high-pitched laughter. The air was thick with perfume and forced cheer, and I was choking on it. To top it off, Jessica, a walking, talking migraine in a cocktail dress, had designated me her target. I didn't just hate her; I felt a primal revulsion every time her gaze snagged on mine.

"You wanna look around the house?" Her

voice was cloyingly sweet, and her hand soft, invasive, landed on mine as I stood guard over my sweating glass.

I recoiled with surgical precision, making the movement appear casual, a mere adjustment of my stance. "I have a clear field of vision from here. No necessity,"I replied, my voice level, emotionless. *What in God's name is wrong with these people? Do they not grasp the concept of personal space, of basic deterrence?*

Then, a reprieve. Ana's mother, booming with maternal pride, announced," The winner of the game is Evelyn!"

"Eve, honey! Come here. It's time for the toast,"she called, summoning Evelyn from the temporary sanctuary of the kitchen.

Evelyn, looking infuriatingly composed, moved to the center. She lifted her drink, a crystalline shield and began.

"Ana and I have been inseparable for five years. I can't even articulate what a friend she is; she's my sister, my other half. I adore everything about her, save for the fact that she and Oliver can be sickeningly over the top sometimes. And ollie? I love you, you're my brother. It's genuinely wonderful that you finally found

your better half.” Her gaze flickered over him, radiating pure, uncomplicated affection. “I love both of you. Keep shining.”

The room erupted a deafening chorus of “whoos” and clinking glass. Her toast was genuine, warm, and brutally effortless.

“Aden, your turn.” Ana’s mother’s finger pointed at me, a loaded weapon.

I stepped forward, the weight of the moment pressing down. “Oh, it’s...overwhelming,” I admitted, my eyes locked on Oliver, ignoring the rest of the swirling chaos. “Ollie, you’ll always be my best friend, the one anchor that doesn’t drag me under. Now, just quit being such a spectacular jerk sometimes, and for the love of God, keep Ana happy.” I raised my glass. “I wish you both every scrap of happiness in this miserable world.”

My toast was clumsy, devoid of the practiced polish Evelyn possessed. speeches weren’t my domain. But the sentiment was ironclad: Oliver was one of the few people who mattered in my life, and I wanted nothing less than absolute, untarnished joy for him.

The ceremony dragged on, the painful unwrapping of gifts, the forced expressions of gratitude. The only agonizing element was the persistent, humming awareness that Evelyn had to bear my presence. She was close, yet miles away, radiating a defensive chill that cut through the overheated room. Marriage, to me, was a suffocating trap, and I was watching my best friend walk willingly into the gilded cage. I didn’t want it. Ever.

Finally, mercifully, it was time to leave. I extracted Oliver and Luke from their clutching, tearful girlfriends, a scene that was not only pathetic but genuinely cringeworthy. It felt like we were hauling prisoners out of their cells. As we left the house, the sterile perfection of the blue and white decor faded, and I finally

took a deep, clean breath of the evening air. The tension inside had been a suffocating weight, and I was glad to be rid of the porcelain prison.

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## CHAPTER 32

### ADEN

Oliver's apartment felt like a staging ground for a psychological operation before we deployed to the club. The bachelor party was supposed to be a sophisticated, exclusive affair, something requiring a velvet rope and an unlisted number. Instead, Oliver, in a spectacular display of his persistent mediocrity, insisted on a "usual party."

Ana stopped for the requisite good-luck kiss before leaving the apartment with Evelyn. "I'll see you later, honey." Her voice was soft, her presence a brief, unwelcome reminder of the reason for this whole debacle. Their party was at a different club; mine were miles away. They'd pushed for a joint celebration, a nauseating prospect, but I had shut that down with an iron fist. Bullshit. I wouldn't spend his last night of freedom before the wedding watching two groups of people perform synchronized affection.

At the club, we were immediately swallowed by the sensory assault. "Unlimited shots! Keep them coming!" Luke's scream was a grating signal flare directed at the bartender. The VIP section was our gilded cage, high above the pulsing, sweating mass on the dance floor. The air was a thick soup of bass, cheap liquor, and human contact. I hated it. Drinking, however, was a necessary anesthetic.

"I will always love you guys," Oliver slurred, his eyes glazed with a sickly sweet sentimentality.

Reign, ever the pragmatist, shot back,” Dude, stop being so cringe.”

I leaned forward, my gaze fixed on the frantic movement below. “I genuinely need to understand this, Ollie. You couldn’t hold out a year, and now you’re getting married? How the hell does that work? Who in their right mind voluntarily signs up for that kind of solitary confinement?” I scoffed, my voice laced with genuine contempt.

Oliver bristled, straightening his spine. “No, she’s different. Ana loves me for me.”

Luke choked on his drink. “Really? She loves that notorious womanizer?”

We exploded into harsh, therapeutic laughter.

“Alright, you can cut the commentary,” Oliver snapped, though a genuine smile tugged at his mouth. “Ha-ha, funny. I am not a womanizer. And besides, she is the only one now.”

The laughter didn’t stop. It was a cynical, desperate acknowledgment of the lie, or perhaps the truth we refused to believe.

“Let’s dance, guys! It’s my last night being a free man!” Oliver declared, already stumbling toward the chaos.

I tried. I forced my body onto the dance floor, enduring the crush of strangers, the aggressive tempo, the people on each other. It was an intolerable miasma of desperation. I lasted less than three minutes before I had to bail. I hated gatherings. They were a vacuum that sucked the life right out of me.

I pushed through the exit, seeking the cold, clean oblivion of the night air. The back alley was dark, reeking of spilled beer and forgotten cigarettes. I turned right, instinctively searching for a slice of quiet...

And there she was. Evelyn.

She was hunched over, her body convulsing, violently purging into the shadows. The shock was a jolt of ice water through my veins. Every single defense mechanism, the cold indifference, the strategic distance shattered. I didn't care about the searing hatred she harbored for me, or the obsessive need I had to keep her exiled from my proximity. I ran.

"Hey! Hey, are you alright?" I gripped her hair, pulling it back from her face, my own breath hitching with a panicked urgency I hadn't felt in years.

"Don't look at me, ugh." The sound was a raw, pathetic moan, laced with self-disgust.

"It's fine. Let me take you home. Now." My hand was on her back, a point of solid, unwelcome contact.

"No, it's unnecessary. I have to find the girls," she spat out the final dregs, wiped her mouth with the back of her hand, and then stood, refusing to lift her eyes to meet mine.

She started walking, a hurried, unsteady retreat into the shadows. I stood frozen, watching her back. She didn't want me near her. That was the goal, the explicit boundary we had established. So why the hell wasn't I stable? I wanted her contempt; it was the only safe currency between us. But watching her frail, defeated form walk away, it hurt. It felt like a violent tear in my own emotional fabric. *What in the name of God is happening to me?*

She stopped abruptly, reaching for her phone, her expression momentarily confused as she listened. Then, with a decisive, uncharacteristic speed, she didn't look back for her friends; she just got into her car and peeled out, vanishing into the city's endless grid.

That was not the Evelyn I knew. That was a flash of desperation, a controlled explosion. And it left me alone in the dark, wrestling with a painful, terrifying truth.

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## CHAPTER 33

### EVELYN

The world didn't just spin; it fractured. Hannah was gone, ripped away by a voice that was both chillingly calm and utterly venomous. The call had been placed from her own number, a mockery of her distress. The kidnapper had not demanded a ransom; he had issued a summons. *Be there. Alone.* Though my mind screamed that he wouldn't let me walk away easily, my feet betrayed me, driven by a primal, non-negotiable need to save her.

My tires shrieked as I found the location, a forgotten section of the city, a place of urban rot and decay. The entrance was a rotting, unmarked metal door leading down into what looked like an ancient sewer access. The air immediately became thick, stale, and smelled of rust, damp concrete, and something metallic, like blood.

The space was a vast, subterranean crypt. A single, bare bulb hung from a frayed wire, casting a sickly yellow glow that barely pushed back the encroaching shadows. The walls were weeping with moisture, and the floor was slick with grime.

And there she was. Hannah. My mother. She was lashed to a folding chair with thick, coarse ropes that bit into her wrists. A filthy, knotted piece of cloth was shoved into her mouth, silencing her cries, though her eyes, wide, swimming pools of pure terror, were howling my name.

"Mom!" I lunged, every instinct screaming at me to free her.



“Oh, oh, oh, not so easy, sweetheart.” A hand, strong, cold, and utterly predatory, snared my arm in mid-stride, an iron cage locking me in place.

I was forced to pivot, confronting the architect of this nightmare.

“Hi, Evelyn. I’m Shean Erling.” His smile was not a social gesture; it was a vicious, exposed blade. His eyes were too bright, manic, and held a possessive hunger that made my skin crawl.

“Why are you doing this? What has she done to you?” My voice was a shredded whisper, the effort of forming words an immense strain.

He chuckled, a dry, rasping sound. “Oh, she didn’t do a damn thing to me, honey. We were...dating.” His eyes flickered down to her bound form with a disgusting leer. “she’s quite lovely on the bed, actually.”

My stomach churned, bile rising in my throat. This was the mysterious man Hannah had been seeing, some younger parasite I’d never been allowed to meet. The truth was repulsive.

Shean glanced around the dank basement, his head cocked in feigned curiosity. “You didn’t bring Aden with you?”

My breath hitched. “You know him?” His grin widened, revealing a flash of genuine madness. “Oh, do I know him? We went way back. We were the absolute best of friends. But I gutted his mother, so now? Now we’re not friends anymore.” The admission was delivered with the casualness of discussing the weather, but the intensity in his eyes was a promise of annihilation.

He took a slow, deliberate step closer, invading my last pocket of personal space. “I thought he loved you. How could he leave you alone like this?”

I felt the blood freeze in my veins, but I forced the words out, a desperate, futile defense. “There’s nothing between us. Aden and I—we are nothing.”

He leaned in, his fetid breath hot against my ear, the whisper a venomous hiss. “Oh, you are so deeply wrong. He kept you away to shield you. To hide you from me. How can you not know this, little superstar? But he failed. His protection was a joke.”

As he pulled back, my peripheral vision snagged on a figure lurking in the shadows to my left. Cara.

“Cara? What in God’s name are you doing here?” Confusion was a weak shield against the tidal wave of betrayal. She wasn’t so good of a friend. But she was at least with us. Maddie’s best friend.

Shean strode to her, his movements fluid and sickeningly confident, and kissed her hard, a proprietary, possessive act. She was probably one of his conquests. “Oh, this darling girl is my gift-giver. She delivered all the necessary intel. After all, it’s an established fact that Aden is far too handsome not to be fiercely wanted. Poor little Cara wanted him. But he couldn’t stop obsessing over you. So, neutralizing you was the final, elegant step. A beautiful win-win.”

My control snapped. “You bitch! How could you commit this monstrosity?” The growl tore from my throat, a single, scalding tear carving a path down my cheek.

“Now, now.” Shean turned back to me, his hands spread in a mock gesture of peace. “Tell me, what final wish do you have? I’m not entirely cruel, honey. I’m prepared to grant one and I am absolutely going to let Hannah walk away unharmed.”

“Please. Just stop this entire insane delusion,” I pleaded, my voice breaking.

His facial muscles tightened, the smile finally dissolving into a mask of pure, hardened fury. “Oh, kiddo, I wanted the same thing. But Aden wasn’t careful enough. I asked him for one thing, just one task, and everything would be fine. Guess what? Your beloved Aden didn’t do it. So, I am keeping my promise. I am systematically killing off every single person he loves.” His teeth ground together with an audible crunch, the threat of a tangible, violent force in the claustrophobic space.

## ADEN

“Hello, Shean.” The words sliced through the stagnant, metallic air of the basement. I didn’t announce my presence; I materialized. The moment Evelyn had projectile vomited her panic and then vanished in a desperate, un-Evelyn-like flight, I knew. I had activated the tracker on her phone, a precaution installed years ago and followed the signal to this damp, crumbling crypt.

Shean pivoted, his expression shifting from menacing confidence to startled recognition.

“oh, look who decided to join the party! So you did bring him with you?” Shean sneered at Evelyn.

“No...” Evelyn’s voice was a terrified, stammering wreck.

“No, she didn’t,” I stated, stepping fully into the sickly yellow light. My eyes never left Shean’s. My stance was wide, relaxed, and lethal.

“But you have the guts to step foot back in this country. I’m impressed by the sheer arrogance,” I mocked, letting my contempt coat every syllable.

Shean’s eyes narrowed, the manic energy intensifying. He leveled the gun, a heavy black shadow in his hand, straight at

Evelyn. “And guess what? I can put a bullet right through your little girlfriend as well.”

“Oh, really? I don’t think so.” I took a calm, deliberate step forward. “Because how will you leave this basement alive if you so much as cause her a single flicker of pain?” I knew the end game was here.

Once this venomous piece of my past was neutralized, Evelyn would finally be free of the darkness that radiated from me. But the brutal knowledge, that every terror she’d endured was a consequence of my existence—was a crushing, immovable weight. I had to save her, regardless of the cost to myself.

“I’ll tell you what, Shean. You’ve always been a coward, flying away, always prioritizing your own hide. This pathetic ambush isn’t the kind of fight I’ll take. If you’re anything close to the man you pretend to be, you’ll fight me. Man to man. Let the women go.”

I watched his pupils dilate. I knew this narcissistic bastard. He craved the spectacle and the validation of a physical challenge. But, he got into my trap. I had just issued a direct assault on his fragile ego, and he couldn’t resist.

A cruel smile stretched his face. He tossed the gun aside, it clattered loudly against the

concrete floor and shrugged out of his jacket, letting it drop to the grime. I matched him, peeling off my own leather, preparing for the inevitable, visceral collision.

“Guess, we’re doing this,” he snarled. Evelyn, seeing her moment, scrambled toward her mother, her fingers frantically working at the thick ropes binding Hannah.

Shean lunged first, a wild, desperate animal. His fist was a blunt object aimed at my head, but it ripped harmlessly through

the air, just beside my ear. The breeze was negligible.

“Ooh. Is that all you’ve got?” I taunted, the mocking tone designed to push him past rational thought.

He became a blur of uncoordinated fury, swinging like a drunken amateur, his fists

landing wherever gravity dictated. I held back, an immovable wall, deflecting his blows with my forearms, conserving my energy. I was defending, repositioning, pushing him off balance. I needed him exhausted.

But the waiting was over. This wasn’t a sparring match; this was the settling of a mortal debt.

My control snapped the instant my mind

flashed to Evelyn’s terrified face. “This is for laying a hand on her.”

With a sudden, explosive counter, I seized his wrist mid swing and twisted it until a sickening crunch echoed in the small space. As he howled and dropped to his knees, clutching his ruined arm, I slammed the heel of my boot into the back of his exposed knee, sending him crashing to the floor.

I stepped back, breathing hard, my own adrenaline surging. “Come on, fight me, get up, bastard.”

The rage I carried, the cold, calcified hatred for the man who murdered my mother, threatened to drown me. I wanted to end him right there, to tear him apart until there was nothing left but pulp.

Shean, fueled by pure malice, managed to scramble up and landed a wild, desperate punch, connecting squarely with my nose. Then another. I felt the sharp, hot tear of skin and the immediate warmth of blood.

“Ooh, I’m impressed,” I conceded, wiping the smear of crimson with the back of my hand.

He lunged again. This time, I didn’t block; I intercepted. I locked his arms in a cruel vise, trapping his chest, and began delivering short, brutal, piston-like blows directly into his ribs—left, right, left, right, until he was a sputtering fountain of pain, a choked animalistic growl tearing from his lungs.

I released him, letting him collapse again. “Get up, big man, get up. We’ve got a fight to finish.”

He scrambled, resorting to a dirty move. He produced a switchblade and lunged, managing to slash my bicep. The sting was immediate, but the superficial cut was meaningless.

“Alright. This one, Shean, is for my mother.” I grabbed his knife hand, ignoring the searing pain in my arm, and used his own momentum against him, driving the blade down into his chest. It was a shallow, agonizing cut, designed to scar him—to make him a monument to his failure. Then I shoved him, slamming him onto the cold concrete, face down. I put my knee on his back, trapping his damaged arm beneath my weight.

“Listen to me, you murdering piece of filth,” I grated into his ear, my voice low and vibrating with contained violence. “Nothing I do to you now will ever be enough. You’ll always be the motherfucking bastard who killed everything that mattered to me.”

I pressed down hard on his twisted arm, forcing a scream from him.

“I want to rip your throat out. I want to cause you so much exquisite pain that you’d beg for the sweet relief of death. But do you see this girl?” I angled my head, pointing to Evelyn, who stood rigid, watching, near her finally freed mother.

“She is why you would live. She taught me what humanity even is, Shean. And somehow, you touched her. You wanted to kill her.” My leg pressed harder into his arm, the bone grinding. “She is the girl who pulled me out of the darkness, and hurt her, several times, because she was hurt around me, and it was all because of you.”

I took a deep, shuddering breath, the smell of blood and concrete filling my lungs.

“And now I’ve realized that if I killed you, there would be no difference between us. So, no. I’m not going to kill you. But know this.” I leaned down again, the final threat delivered with quiet, terrifying sincerity.

“You’re going to live. But if you so much as dare to look at her, ever, ever again, I will hunt you down, cut off your testicles, and I won’t even feed them to a dog so that nothing on this earth becomes like you. And then, I will finally kill you.”

I released the pressure, letting him gasp and writhe. “And congratulations, Shean. You’re going to meet your father in federal prison.” I had arranged his father’s incarceration days ago, knowing Shean would follow.

He made a weak, desperate reach for the discarded gun. I slammed my boot onto his broken hand, the scream he emitted this time a desperate, high pitched shriek.

The sound of sirens was suddenly deafening. The basement door burst open, and a flood of uniformed officers stormed the space. Oliver, Luke, Ana and a frantic Maddie appeared behind them.

“Wait!” Maddie yelled, stopping the officers from immediately hauling Shean and Cara away.

She walked directly to Cara, whose face was a mask of terror and shame. Maddie didn't hesitate. Her hand cracked across Cara's face with a shocking, loud snap that echoed in the silence.

"That's what you deserve, bitch," Maddie spat, the wedding-day excitement replaced by cold fury.

The cops took Shean away along with Cara for helping him, but she'll be released soon anyway. Yet, a pathetic, bloody mess finally neutralized. The man who killed my mother, the man who nearly destroyed Evelyn, was gone.

I wasn't happy that he'd live. He didn't deserve to. But, not killing him would at least restrain a little hate of Evelyn for me.

I stood there watching Evelyn's eyes flickering at me and then moving away.

She took Hannah home.



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## CHAPTER 34

### EVELYN

The morning after the basement horror was a blur of underwhelming consolation. Everyone offered soft words and pitying glances, but I didn't need their gentle murmurs. My mind was still processing the raw, terrifying clarity of Shean's confession- the way my life had been a pawn in a game I didn't know I was playing.

"You're done. You're really stunning." Hannah's hands were steady as she finished my makeup, a forced normalcy clinging to her movements.

I spun back to face her, the guilt a suffocating shroud. "Mom, I'm so thankful nothing happened to you. And I am profoundly sorry for everything."

She dismissed my apology with a wave of her hand. "It's not your fault, honey. I should have been smarter. Now, we have a wedding to attend. Erase it. Get up." She was actively burying the trauma, forcing us both to move forward.

But I couldn't erase Aden. The man had performed an act of lethal, terrifying protection, but the central, crippling fact remained: he had hurt me. He had built a wall of ice between us for four years, making me believe he was a stranger, a casual nuisance, all to "shield" me. My feelings were a raw, open wound, and they were his doing. His presence was not just a reminder of the danger; it was a constant, sharp echo of his betrayal.

I knocked on Ana's door, taking a fortifying breath. "May I come in?"

"Come in!" Ana's voice was a bright, joyous bell.

I walked in and saw her, a vision. "God. You look ethereal, baby. Get over here." I enveloped her in a fierce embrace.

"Okay, no waterworks," I commanded, pulling back and dramatically fanning my eyes. "I'm the Maid of Honor; I cannot destroy my makeup." She erupted in a laugh that was pure, uncomplicated happiness, and for a fleeting second, the world felt safe.

"Uhm, Eve, I need to tell you something." Ana's smile faltered, her voice dropping to a hesitant whisper. "Aden and Luke are the best men, so... you're walking with them."

My stomach dropped, a dead weight. My muscles locked. "No, no, absolutely. It's your day. Your perfect day." My assurance was immediate, automatic. "I will do anything for you."

But inside, I was screaming. To be physically bound to Aden, especially after the volatile, raw drama of yesterday, felt like a punishment. I had to do it. For Ana.

I moved outside, where the ceremony was laid out like a dream sequence. The theme was a stark, breathtaking contrast to the urban decay of last night: a vision of white and emerald green. White roses, Oliver's favorite, climbed over a wrought iron archway, set against the rich, deep green foliage of Ana's choice. It was perfect, an isolated island of beauty in a chaotic world.

Guests were settling in the pristine white chairs. The tension of anticipation was a physical hum in the air.

"Hey, bean. Are you okay?" Derek's familiar voice cut through my anxiety. He was worried, his brow furrowed with genuine

concern over the news of Shean's attack.

"I'm genuinely sorry I couldn't be there." "No, it's alright, Dad. We're fine. Mom's fine. It's over." I spoke slowly, placing a calming hand on his arm.

"Oh, thank God. I was terrified for you both."

"Dad?" I stopped him before he could retreat. The moment was fragile, and I seized it. "Thank you. For everything. And I know I've said terrible things, but I love you. I've always loved you."

He visibly softened, his eyes misting. "It's okay, bean. I know you do. I love you too. You'll always be my gorgeous little girl, no matter how much you grow up." He kissed my forehead, a lingering, paternal gesture. "Now, I'll go take my seat."

Oliver's entrance was marked by a slow, sweeping swell of music. He looked genuinely overwhelmed. Jessica, Maddie, and Shayla took their positions, the bridesmaids a line of graceful, nervous excitement.

Then, it was my turn. The unbearable gauntlet lay before me: the long, white aisle, flanked by two men; one, Luke, a friendly shield, and the other, Aden, the architect of my deepest emotional scar.

"Hey," I managed, looking only at Luke as I slipped my arms into the space between them. My hands were forced to rest in the crook of Aden and Luke's elbows. I could feel the hard, unyielding muscle of Aden's bicep beneath my fingers, the precise spot where Shean had cut him—a testament to his lethal devotion. I did not, could not, look at him.

Walking the aisle felt like traversing a canyon on a tightrope. Every step was an excruciating climb, an endless, performative

exercise. Finally, Aden released me with a subtle, professional withdrawal, positioning me alongside the other bridesmaids.

The music shifted. The crowd collectively sighed. Ana made her entrance, radiant and slow, guided by her father. She carried a tight bouquet of deep red dahlias-my favorites-a subtle nod to our friendship. Her father handed her to Oliver, their hands meeting in a perfect, momentous clasp.

I leaned in and whispered fiercely to Oliver,” Don’t cry. Don’t you dare cry, you idiot. She’s finally yours.”

He let out a shaky chuckle, but a single, brilliant tear escaped, running a path through his perfect makeup.

Their vows were sincere, their kiss a promise. As their lips met, a hidden mechanism was triggered, and from behind the altar, brilliant, multi-colored fireworks shot into the pale sky-a dazzling explosion of color against the white backdrop.

Later, the music shifted again, signaling the dance. “Hey, Max,” I greeted my bandmate as he tentatively asked for a dance.

“You look adorable, Eve.” His voice was low, earnest.

“Thanks. You don’t look half bad yourself,” I

retorted with the old, familiar sarcasm. He laughed, and we moved into the slow rhythm.

I couldn’t help it. My gaze tracked across the dance floor. Aden was dancing with Jessica, the girl who had practically stapled herself to him at the shower. She was draped over his arm, her body pressed against his with blatant, aggressive intention.

As I watched, a tight knot forming in my chest, Max’s voice cut through the noise, thick with nerves.

“Evelyn,” he said, his body almost imperceptibly trembling. “I really like you. I truly do. It’s not some fleeting crush; it’s a genuine constant.”

I forced my attention back to him, my voice softening to spare him. “I like you too, Max. But I can’t. I’m just not ready to be in a relationship again. I genuinely can’t.” I squeezed his hand, a painful honesty. “Besides, I value you as my friend and my bandmate too much. It’s better this way.”

“It’s alright,” he murmured, his disappointment a visible slump in his posture.

“I’m genuinely sorry, Max.”

“No, it’s fine,” he insisted, straightening. “I’ll always be the same. I’ll always like you. I know what a pure heart you have.”

“Thank you, Maxi.” I gave him a grateful smile. The music swelled, signaling the dizzying spin that would change our partners. I braced myself. The dance floor was about to become a lottery of agony.

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## CHAPTER 35

### ADEN

The music swelled, signaling the cursed partner swap. I practically flung Jessica; that irritating, clingy parasite away from me. The feeling of her soft, insistent body leaving my side was a profound relief.

Everyone rotated. The moment the crowd cleared, the universe delivered her to me.

Evelyn.

The craving to have her in my arms-to simply possess her presence, was a visceral, sharp ache. It had been years since I'd held her like this. Her body was rigid with resistance, yet perfectly compliant in the slow, agonizing rhythm.

"Hi." The word was a dry husk in my throat.

"Hi." Her voice was a barely audible echo. Her gaze was nailed to my chest, avoiding eye contact, as if my stare were an executioner's blade.

"You're breathtaking." The word slipped out, raw and unplanned. I wanted to spill every confession, every agonizing thought I'd had for the last four years. She was all sharp angles and defensive tension, yet devastatingly feminine, heartbreakingly mine.

"Thank you." She didn't move. "Look, I'm profoundly sorry for all of it..." I started, forcing the apology into the tiny space between us, referring to the trauma of the night before.

She finally tilted her face up, her eyes-liquid green pools of hurt-meeting mine for a searing instant.

“It’s alright. It’s over now. Everything’s settled.” Her tone was dangerously even, dismissive. She looked down again, sealing herself off.

After a pause,” I think about you, “I confessed, the words a raw, unfiltered blast of truth.

Her head snapped up again. Her gaze was locked onto mine, searching, analyzing.

“All the time. There hasn’t been a single second in four years when you weren’t a permanent, agonizing fixture in my mind, Eve.”

“Stop it. Please. I don’t need any more complications.” Her voice was a low, desperate plea, laced with warning.

I gripped her hand tighter, refusing to let her withdraw. “No. I have to say this. I know I destroyed you. I wounded you in every conceivable way, and no matter what atonement I offer, it will never be enough. But I will spend the rest of my life trying to pay the debt anyway. I had to keep you away from me, from Erling. I knew what he could do.”

“You don’t have to,” she countered, her voice now regaining its firm, familiar steel. “And yes, you shattered me, Aden. So severely it defies comparison. You made me feel like an irrelevant pawn in your game. I understand the cold, calculating logic of your supposed ‘safety’ mission. But that twisted nobility is still not enough to forgive the isolation.”

Her honesty was a physical punch, yet it was exactly what I needed to hear.

“I want you back.” I lowered my voice, making the plea guttural, absolute. “I need you back. My existence without you is

an aimless void, love. I need you to anchor me.”

“Don’t call me that,” she hissed, the term of endearment a trigger for her anger. “And you don’t need me.”

With a sudden, violent pull, she ripped her hand from mine, the contact severing like a tripwire. She didn’t look back; she simply

executed a sharp pivot and walked rapidly away from the brightly lit dance floor, toward the shadows near the periphery of the reception. She was seeking solitude, an escape from the suffocating pressure of my proximity.

I stood there, surrounded by the swirling, ecstatic bodies of the wedding party, completely paralyzed.

It was fine. I told myself. She left. She needs space. I was not going to let this be the end. Last night, in the dark, I’d argued with myself, trying to believe I didn’t deserve her. And maybe I don’t. But that didn’t matter anymore.

She is not a luxury; she is a necessity. She is the vital organ I didn’t know I lacked until I almost lost her to the darkness of my own past. I would do anything—anything short of destroying her, to reclaim her.

“Ad, it’s time for the speech. Let’s go.” Luke’s hand clamped down on my shoulder, breaking the agonizing trance.

I inhaled sharply, dragging my focus back from the beautiful, devastating ghost walking away from me. The war was far from over.



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## CHAPTER 36

### EVELYN

A gentle hand landed on my shoulder. “Are you alright, kiddo?” Edward’s voice was a warm, anchoring presence.

“No. No, I am not alright, Ed. I’m shattered,” I confessed, the word tearing from my chest. I allowed myself to collapse into his hug, seeking momentary refuge on the periphery of the reception, a small, dark patch of grass slightly removed from the dazzling white archway. The air here was cool, carrying the faint, sweet scent of extinguished fireworks.

“Tell me what happened,” he urged, his arms holding me firmly.

“He wants me back. Now,” I choked on a sob. “And I love him. That is the thing that absolutely terrifies me. I crave him, but I can’t go back to the way it was. I don’t know what to do.”

“It’s alright, it’s alright.” He pressed a kiss into my hair. “Whatever path you choose, it will be the right one. Trust your gut. All I know about that man is that he is toxic, he is complicated, but he would burn the world down to keep you safe.” He stood, offering me his arm. “It’s time for the speech. Let’s go.”

I returned to the reception, stiffly taking my seat next to Max. Aden was on the stage, bathed in the sharp, merciless light of the spotlight.

“Marriage had never been a logical thing to me. I always thought those who embraced it were fools.” His voice was low,

resonant, stripped of all artifice. He wasn't giving a toast; he was giving a confession.

"Everything I believed was true, until the moment I felt the absolute, bone-deep terror of losing someone who meant everything to me. Maybe I lost her already. Maybe I haven't."

His eyes swept over the crowd, and I felt the weight of his gaze settle on me like a physical pressure.

"But nothing in this entire world makes me as happy as she does. And somehow, I am not lucky enough to simply have her." He paused, his expression raw, exposed. "Then I realized: marriage is just another, fierce act of love. It's a bond that strengthens two people, giving them the constant support and power of their other half, twenty-four-seven. You two are the luckiest people alive, because you get to exist with your better half, every single second. Some people aren't even lucky enough to think that thought."

He finished with a final, hollow wish of happiness for the couple, but the entire speech had been a brutal, desperate declaration to me. When he returned to the table, I was a statue of despair. I sat rigid, unable to move, unable to even join the women gathering for the bouquet toss. The joy of the wedding was a distant, cruel melody.

Later, the music softened, the celebration winding down into the intimacy of night. I walked out to a secluded patio area—a platform of cool, polished glass that reflected the scattered moonlight. I sat down, my feet bare on the cool surface, feeling utterly exposed and alone.

"Waiting for someone?"

Aden's voice, quiet and immediate, shattered the fragile peace. He walked toward me, the moonlight catching the dangerous

intensity in his eyes.

“You can’t talk about us in front of everyone like that,” I stated, my voice dangerously level, still staring out at the moonlit lawn.

“Why not? People should know what a pathetic loser I am.” He moved with a practiced, predatory grace and sat down heavily beside me, his thigh brushing mine. The heat was instantaneous.

“Because things will never be the same again. They can’t be.” I finally turned my head, meeting his gaze, letting him see the fierce exhaustion in my eyes.

“I don’t want it to be the same,” he countered, leaning closer, his voice dropping to a low, seductive rumble. “I’m going to make it better. For whatever it takes.”

I shot to my feet, the cold glass sending a shock up my legs. “No! You can’t just swoop in and decide to change the rules when it’s convenient for you! It doesn’t work like that, Aden!”

I towered over him, my hands shaking. “And I would very much appreciate it if you stop this pursuit. Stay in your path, and let me be in mine.”

He rose slowly, towering over me in the moonlight, his presence a physical force. “You know I can’t do that. I am going to win you back. And I mean that with every particle of my screwed-up soul.”

“Okay.” My heart was hammering against my ribs. I stared at him down, channeling every ounce of past hurt into defiance. “Then be ready for your first defeat.” I turned sharply, already walking away.

“No, love.” His voice, though quiet, was a steel cable that stopped me dead in my tracks. “It’s not the first. I lost for the first time four years ago-the moment I decided to give up on you and realized you are everything I needed to stay alive.”

I stopped. I froze. The brutal, simple truth of it twisted the knife in my gut. I took one last, ragged breath, refusing to turn around. I wiped the tears that had instantly sprung to my eyes, desperate to conceal my weakness, and walked out. I didn't wait for Ana. I drove directly to my apartment, leaving the wedding, the love, and the relentless man who claimed to need me, behind.

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## CHAPTER 37

### ADEN

I knew Evelyn would not grant me easy absolution. But I was the master of my own will, and my will was to reclaim her. I was a man of cold, hard intent, and retreat was not in my DNA. I called her apartment for two days; she severed the connection every time. So I went to her apartment.

It was locked from the outside. She wasn't hiding; she was fleeing.

My pursuit led me to Hannah's house. I knocked, a bouquet of irrelevant flowers gripped in my hand.

"Edward." Evelyn's brother answered. "Aden." His voice was flat. "I need to see Evelyn. Is she here? Her place is empty." I pushed past the pretense.

"she left for Los Angeles this morning. Recording session. Her band went with her," he stated, his arms crossed, a silent guard.

A cold, agonizing spike of panic pierced my chest. "What time is the flight?" I demanded.

"11:30, I think—"

I didn't wait for the last syllable. I dropped the flowers, the petals scattering across the porch like discarded dreams, and bolted to the curb. I wrenched the car door open. "Mark! Airport! Now! Max speed, I don't care about the laws!"

I was not going to permit her to vanish again. To leave me, she would literally have to kill me. I would interpose myself between her and the plane. I would have her. I knew it.

She was the fierce love I discovered in that desolate August, a warmth that pulled me back from drowning in my own sterile existence. I hadn't forgotten how to love her; I had simply maintained a brutal, agonizing resistance to that love.

I had maybe five minutes to reach the terminal gates. It was mathematically impossible. I had always scorned 'luck,' viewing it as a crutch for the weak. But now, gripping the dashboard, my knuckles white, I was staking everything on the reckless throw of fate.

The car didn't stop. It skidded to a halt at the curb. I hauled myself out, ignoring the shriek of the tires, and sprinted through the automatic doors. The terminal was a blur of polished marble, anxious faces, and blinding fluorescent light. I shoved my way to the airline counter, gasping for breath.

"Excuse me! Next flight to Los Angeles!" I roared at the woman behind the glass.

She checked her screen with agonizing slowness. "I'm sorry, sir. That's impossible before noon. The last flight just closed its doors."

She was gone. The realization was a devastating physical blow. I leaned against the counter, my chest heaving, the air thick with defeat.

"Looking for someone?" The voice was directly behind me. Low. Familiar. The air went out of my lungs. I spun around, my heart slamming against my ribs like a trapped bird.

She was standing four feet away, a magnificent, infuriating vision in the harsh airport light.

"I love you, darling," I managed, the confession a primal, guttural noise ripped from my throat.

Her face was a mask of furious certainty. "No, you don't."

“I love you, Love.” I repeated, staking my claim on the very word she had forbidden.

She moved. Not with hesitant steps, but with the velocity of a bullet.

SMACK!

The sound echoed through the

high-ceilinged terminal. Her palm met my cheek with a stunning, bone-jarring force. It was a precise strike, powered by four years of banked resentment-stronger, cleaner, and far more painful than anything Shean had managed.

She immediately pivoted, her back ramrod

straight, trying to walk away again. But she didn’t possess the necessary conviction. She knew, down to her core, that I would simply follow her to the ends of the earth.

“I love you, and I am not leaving you alone. Ever again. Hit me again. Kill me. Do whatever you need to, darling.” I stalked after her, my body loose and ready for her next blow, every muscle dedicated to her pursuit.

She stopped. A sudden, violent halt. I stopped two feet behind her. “If you so much as take another step, I’m not letting you leave again. And if you try to, I will kill you.” Her voice was a low, terrifying growl.

“You can have my weapon. You can have my entire empire. You can have all of me, love.” I shrugged, letting my body language convey total surrender, all my defenses dropped.

And that was the breaking point. The final dam burst.

She didn’t speak. She didn’t hit. She launched herself backward and into me. Her arms snapped around my neck in a fierce, strangling embrace. My own arms instantly wrapped

around her back, locking her to my chest, my body finally coming home after a four year exile.

She wasn't just crying; she was sobbing, a terrible, wrenching sound that tore at my soul.

"I am truly sorry, baby. If even killing myself would erase the harm I inflicted upon you, trust me, I would do it now," I whispered into her hair, kissing her temple, holding her weight against me.

"Do you remember, years ago, you asked me who I loved the most in this world?" I asked, my voice thick with emotion.

She only shook her head against my chest. "It's you. It has always been you. I was just a coward, terrified to admit it to myself. From the first moment I saw you, I knew you would be the glorious, devastating end of me. And I love you with every fractured, dark part of my being."

She pulled back abruptly, her eyes red, her face streaked with tears. I cupped her face in my hands, my thumb gently wiping away the devastation. I leaned in, and she lifted up onto her tiptoes, meeting my mouth with a desperate, all-consuming kiss.

"I love you." The words were almost lost in the kiss, a soft, sacred whisper.

She had never said it before. The realization hit me with the force of an avalanche. She was here. She was mine. I would never again allow the shadows of my past to touch her. I would become the impenetrable wall she deserved. Never again.



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## CHAPTER 38

### EVELYN

The shift in my life was seismic, a total realignment of my soul I never saw coming. Before Aden, love was a hollow concept, a word used by others that held no weight in my world. But the moment I realized I loved him, my heart became a fortress with only one inhabitant. It was him or the void; he didn't just complement my life, he finally made it whole.

A sharp, jagged gasp broke the silence of the room. "Please, don't leave me... please. No, no!" Aden's voice was thick with a raw, subconscious terror. He was thrashing against the sheets, caught in the throes of a nightmare I assumed was born from the ghosts of his past.

"Hey, look at me. I'm here. I'm right here with you," I whispered, my voice a steady anchor in his storm. I cupped his face, my palms grounding him as I pressed a lingering, tender kiss to his forehead.

He bolted upright, his breath coming in ragged hitches before he collapsed back, resting his head heavily in my lap. I instinctively pulled him closer, my arms winding around his shoulders and locking across his chest, shielding him from the remnants of his dream.

"It wasn't about her," he muffled against me, his voice trembling with a vulnerability that pierced my heart. "It's about you. I can't lose you again, Eve. You're the architect of the man I've become. I was nothing before this."

He shifted, turning his gaze upward. The intensity in his eyes was blinding, a mixture of desperation and absolute devotion. “Eve, will you marry me?”

The air left my lungs. The timing was chaotic, born of a feverish midnight moment. “Aden... you’re exhausted. You’re still caught in the dream,” I murmured, brushing a stray hair from his brow. “Go back to sleep. We’ll talk when the sun is up.”

But he didn’t back down. He sat up with a sudden, jolting energy, his hands finding mine and gripping them with a strength that demanded I listen. “I have never been more awake. I am a shell without you, Eve. You are my entire world, the very air I breathe. I need you to be my life, because I don’t have one without you. I love you with a ferocity that scares me. Marry me.”

The sheer weight of his confession broke through my defenses. I moved instinctively, sliding onto his lap and anchoring myself to him, my legs holding him close as if to merge our two lives into one. I leaned in, capturing his lips in a kiss that tasted of promises and forever.

“I am yours,” I breathed against his skin, my hands framing his face as I looked into the depths of his soul. “In every lifetime, in every universe, I am yours, Aden Pattersen.”

A radiant, disbelieving smile broke across his face, transforming his features. “That’s a yes? Truly?”

“Yes,” I laughed, the sound bubbling up from a place of pure joy. “Yes, a thousand times yes!”

He pulled me down into the pillows, his movements filled with a sudden, quiet gravity. The excitement faded into something deeper, something sacred. He looked at me as if I were the only light in a dark world.

“I will never fail you,” he vowed, his voice a low, resonant vow. “I will spend every day loving you better than the day before. You are mine, and every fiber of my being belongs to you.”

“I love you,” I whispered, the words a final, peaceful seal on the night as we lay there, tangled together, watching each other until sleep finally claimed us.

**THE END**

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## **AUTHOR'S NOTE**

Loved each and every moment of describing the magnificent and ineffable chemistry the two had. The story had described a flamboyant yet so charming characteristic of both the characters. Being the first documentary that I've created, it's honestly a proud feeling and moment of pride for me. I enjoyed being the mind who created this.